Backward-branch negative reflection of guided waves from the free edge of a flexoelectric piezoelectric semiconductor plate

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Abstract

A guided mode reaching the free edge of a plate is scattered into the outgoing branches that the edge supports, and a plate can support a branch whose energy flux is opposite to its phase velocity. The partition is computed for a transversely isotropic ($6mm$) n-type ZnO plate with strain-gradient elasticity, piezoelectricity, flexoelectricity and linearized electron drift–diffusion, with a single bilinear carrier–strain-gradient enthalpy and its reciprocal partners. The edge problem is solved at fixed frequency by a spectral Galerkin expansion through the thickness, matched to the traction-free edge conditions. At $k_x d = 0.736$ (16.68 GHz) the backward mode carries 1.93 % of the incident power; along the same branch the share reaches 94.29 % at $k_x d = 0.52719$ (16.6547 GHz), where the incident and backward wavenumbers differ by 0.4 % and the group velocity vanishes. This is a modal share, not a reflectance: the propagating outgoing modes carry the incident power to within 0.1 %, and at the fold the incident flux is a factor of 131 smaller than at the operating point. The conversion is a property of the backward branch of the plate, not of the added coupling, which at its tabulated extreme lowers the share by 1.21 % at the operating point and by 36.1 % at the maximum. The share at the fold falls with carrier density, from 0.943 at 2×10^{18} to 0.545 at 2×10^{20} $1/\mathrm{m}^3$, and with an added loss tangent, to 0.600 at 10^{-5}. The gradient length, the flexoelectric coefficient and the coupling constant are assumed values. The corner line force is computed, not imposed; the partition at the maximum changes by 3.9×10^{-6} between Galerkin degrees 10 and 28, over which that force halves.

Keywords: flexoelectric semiconductor; strain-gradient elasticity; guided plate waves; backward branch; negative reflection; spectral Galerkin method.

Nomenclature

Symbol	Quantity	Symbol	Quantity
u_i	displacement	v_i	test displacement
ε_{ij}	small strain	$\eta_{ijk} = \varepsilon_{ij,k}$	strain gradient
σ_{ij}	Cauchy stress	τ_{ijk}	hyperstress ($\tau_{ijk} = \tau_{jik}$)
Σ_{ij}	$\sigma_{ij} - \partial_k \tau_{ijk}$	n_i	surface normal
c_{ijkl}	elastic stiffness	A_{ijklmn}	strain-gradient modulus
e_{kij}	piezoelectric constant	f_{ijkl}	flexoelectric constant
κ_{ij}	permittivity	ℓ	strain-gradient length
φ	electrostatic potential	ψ	test potential
$E_i = -\partial_i \varphi$	electric field	D_i	electric displacement
Δn	carrier-number perturbation	$\widehat{N} = \widetilde{\mu} + Q\widehat{\varphi} - h\widehat{u}_3''$	carrier amplitude
n_0	steady carrier density	μ_e	electron mobility
D	electron diffusivity	q	elementary charge
$\widetilde{\mu}$	electrochemical potential	Φ	test electrochemical potential
H_{jkl}, $H \equiv H_{zzz}$	carrier–strain-gradient coupling	H/H^*	normalized coupling
$a = k_B T/n_0$	carrier compressibility	Q	dimensionless charge
k_x	propagation wavenumber	k_y	transverse wavenumber
k_{Bx}	backward-branch wavenumber	k_{ix}	incident wavenumber
d	plate thickness	$\zeta = 2z/d$	scaled thickness
ω, f	angular frequency, frequency	$\lambda = \ell/d$	dimensionless gradient length
$x = 0$	reflecting edge	L	reference-plane distance
R_B	backward modal share	P_x	thickness-integrated power flux
P_{inc}	incident self-power	θ_E	energy angle
$\alpha_{\mathrm{d}} = D/(dc_s)$	transport-over-elastic rate	$\alpha = 2\lvert \operatorname{Im} k_x \rvert$	spatial attenuation

1 Introduction

Piezoelectric semiconductors, of which n-type zinc oxide is the standard example, join a piezoelectric response to a population of mobile charge carriers. The combination underlies nanogenerators and piezotronic devices [1, 2] and rests on a material whose electronic and mechanical properties are well characterized [3]. Acoustic waves in such a medium are not purely elastic. The piezoelectric field that accompanies a wave acts on the carriers, the carriers redistribute and screen it, and in doing so they absorb energy from the wave; the foundations of this picture were laid for bulk waves by Hutson and White [4], and White [5] showed that drifting carriers can amplify ultrasound as well as attenuate it. The linearized drift–diffusion description of the carriers has since been combined with the elastic and piezoelectric equations for rods [6] and plates [7], and it is the description adopted here.

When the plate is a few hundred nanometers thick and the frequency is of the order of ten gigahertz, two further effects can no longer be set aside. The first is flexoelectricity, the polarization produced by a strain gradient rather than by a strain [8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13]. It is small in absolute terms but scales inversely with a length, so it becomes comparable with piezoelectricity in thin films, at free surfaces and around edges, and it is already exploited in semiconductors [14, 15, 16]. The second is the dependence of the elastic energy on the strain gradient, which introduces an internal length into the equations of motion [17, 18]. In a semiconductor the two effects are coupled to the carriers: the bound charge induced by the strain gradient is screened by mobile charge, the screening moves the carriers, and the redistributed carriers act back on the field. This closed loop is the content of the flexoelectric semiconductor theory [19, 20, 21].

The continuum formulation of that theory combines the flexoelectric balance laws (with the strain gradient in the constitutive relations), Gauss's law with mobile charge and the carrier continuity equations of drift–diffusion; it can be derived from a free-energy density that contains the strain, the strain gradient, the electric field and the carrier-concentration perturbation. Qu, Jin and Yang [19] used the balance-law form to show that bending moves mobile charge in a composite flexoelectric dielectric–semiconductor beam, with the flexoelectric coupling confined to the dielectric layer; related models treat the bending of a flexoelectric semiconductor plate [21] and thermally induced carrier redistribution [20]. The most complete statement of the framework is the Coleman–Noll derivation of Qu, Pan, Zhu and Deng [22], whose additive free-energy decomposition is the reference against which the added term of section 1 is placed in section 5.3. A computational treatment of flexoelectric semiconductor junctions has also appeared [23]. All of these works make a point that constrains any extension of the model: the additional constitutive couplings are not free parameters, they are constrained by a thermodynamic potential, and the reciprocal partner of each added term in the stress has to appear in the electrochemical potential.

The wave theory of flexoelectric media has been developed for several geometries. Yang, Deng, Liang and Shen [24] computed the dispersion of Lamb waves in a plate with both flexoelectricity and strain-gradient elasticity, and Yang and co-workers treated Rayleigh waves on a centrosymmetric flexoelectric half-space [25]. Jiao, Wei and Li [26] obtained the reflection and transmission of plane waves through a flexoelectric piezoelectric slab between two half-spaces, and the same group replaced the slab by a piezoelectric semiconductor to study the effect of the carrier density and of a bias field [27]. Mondal, Sahu and Nirwal [28] computed the reflection of plane quasi-longitudinal waves at the free surface of a pre-stressed, rotating flexoelectric half-space. For flexoelectric semiconductors, Rayleigh waves have been analyzed for an n-type half-space with second-order strain gradients [29], and the exact multi-field solution of a piezoelectric semiconductor plate has identified the range of carrier concentrations in which the semiconductor coupling is active at all [7]. Size-dependent Rayleigh waves in piezoelectric semiconductor media have also been studied with nonlocal, void, fractional and memory-dependent thermal effects [30]. Guided waves in plates governed by strain-gradient elasticity alone have been analyzed for the Mindlin Form-II theory in isotropic plates [31] and for a generalized first strain-gradient theory [32]. In all of these studies the quantity computed is a dispersion relation or a set of reflection coefficients for the few body waves of a half-space; none treats the scattering of a guided mode at the end of a plate.

The scattering of a guided mode at a free plate edge is a classical problem for elastic plates. The edge couples the propagating Lamb modes to an infinite family of evanescent ones, and the partition of the incident power among the propagating modes was computed by modal expansion and variational methods [33, 34, 35], and compared with measurement [36]; the oblique incidence that matters here was treated by Santhanam and Demirli [37]. Moreover, the same edge supports a resonance at the frequencies of zero group velocity [38, 39, 40, 41], and it is at these frequencies that the dispersion branch turns back on itself. Lamb modes include backward modes, whose energy flux is opposed to their phase velocity [42]; where a forward and a backward mode coexist near a zero-group-velocity point [43], the free edge converts one into the other, giving negative reflection [44, 45, 46]. The same conversion at thickness steps gives negative refraction [47, 48], in the manner of the metamaterial negative refraction of elastic waves [49]; it has been used to build devices [50] and has been observed in chaotic and disordered plates [51]. Every one of these results is for an elastic

plate without strain-gradient elasticity, flexoelectricity or mobile carriers.

The computation of guided waves in plates is now routinely handled by semi-analytical methods, which discretize the thickness and leave the propagation direction analytic. Spectral expansions through the thickness converge exponentially for smooth fields [52, 53], the finite-element variant handles damped waveguides [54], and the Legendre–Galerkin construction [55] gives well-conditioned systems for the fourth-order operators that strain-gradient elasticity introduces.

The studies above do not treat the edge scattering of a guided mode in a plate with strain-gradient elasticity, flexoelectricity and mobile carriers together. In such a plate the outgoing spectrum is discrete, it may contain a backward-propagating member whose energy flux is opposite to its phase velocity, and the carriers take part in the partition. That is the problem addressed here. An incident guided mode is reflected into its time-reversed partner and into a finite family of mode-converted branches, and a backward branch is excited whenever the edge problem admits one. Two questions follow, and they are answered separately in this article. Does this plate admit a backward branch at the reported frequency, and how strongly does the edge convert into it? Does the carrier–strain-gradient coupling bias that partition?

The answers separate the two mechanisms. The branch, and with it the strong conversion, belongs to the plate and not to the added coupling: it persists when the added coupling is removed, and the gradient length places its fold at the reported frequency. The added coupling acts on the partition through the attenuation it gives the two partner modes, by 1.21 % at the operating point and by 36.1 % at the maximum along the branch. The article reports the two effects with their own numbers and their own controls, at fixed transverse wavenumber, so that the contribution of each can be read without the other. The main contributions are: (i) a formulation of the free-edge problem for a strain-gradient, flexoelectric, piezoelectric-semiconductor plate in which the generalized traction and the independent double traction are imposed separately; (ii) a spectral Legendre–Galerkin solution validated against an independent C^1 finite-element discretization, against exact limits and against an energy balance that closes to round-off; (iii) the partition of the incident power into a backward branch, with the distinction between a modal share and a reflectance made explicit; and (iv) a quantified, bounded effect of the added carrier–strain-gradient enthalpy on that partition.

The model used in this article is kept minimal. On top of the standard flexoelectric piezoelectric-semiconductor enthalpy it adds one bilinear term, $\Delta\mathcal{H} = \Delta n\, H_{jkl}\, \varepsilon_{jk,l}$, (3), in which Δn is the carrier-concentration perturbation, $\varepsilon_{jk,l}$ the strain gradient and H_{jkl} a third-order coupling tensor with the units of energy times length. Because that term belongs to a thermodynamic potential it generates its two conjugate partners: an addition $H_{jkl}\Delta n$ to the hyperstress, (4), and an addition $H_{jkl}\varepsilon_{jk,l}$ to the electrochemical potential, (5). The three relations are obtained by differentiating one enthalpy, so they are one assumption and not three, and they are the only addition to the standard model in the article (a term of this structure is given in Appendix C of [22]). No additional field, no micro-inertia, no flexoelectric-gradient term and no nonlinear electromechanical feedback is introduced, and the classical constants are not refitted.

The reciprocal relation (5) is what gives the edge problem its character. A guided plate mode has a strain gradient through the thickness, so it perturbs the electrochemical potential before any carrier moves; the carriers respond, the charge density changes, and the changed charge density modifies the hyperstress through (4). The loop closes at the edge, where the conversion into outgoing branches takes place.

Three conventions are used throughout. The plate occupies $x < 0$ and the reflecting edge is at $x = 0$; the z axis is the six-fold axis of ZnO and points through the thickness, with the faces at $z = \pm d/2$. A quantity is called *backward* when its energy flux has a negative component along x, the direction of propagation of the incident wave, and a mode is called *outgoing* when it either decays away from the edge or, if it is propagating, carries energy away from the edge. Both definitions are operational, being the ones implemented in the solution.

The formulation and the solution method are given first, followed by the numerical results with their discussion, and the findings are collected at the end.

2 Mathematical formulation

The formulation follows the order in which one enthalpy generates the constitutive relations, the field equations, the boundary conditions at the faces and the edge, and the power flux that identifies a backward mode. The section ends with the dimensionless groups, the reductions the model must reproduce, and the condition for positive definiteness of the elastic–gradient–carrier block.

2.1 Geometry, kinematics and the gradient energy

Consider a transversely isotropic ($6mm$) n-type ZnO plate of thickness d whose faces are the planes $z = \pm d/2$, occupying the half-space $x < 0$ and terminating at a traction-free edge at $x = 0$. The plate is unbounded in

y, so a single tangential wavenumber k_y is conserved, and each field has the form $f(x,z)\,e^{ik_y y - i\omega t}$ with three displacement components retained. The formulation is thus two-and-a-half-dimensional (2.5D): a discrete cross-section in (x,z) carrying full three-component kinematics, a single conserved tangential wavenumber, and no discretization of y. The independent fields are the displacement $u_i(\boldsymbol{x},t)$, the electrostatic potential $\varphi(\boldsymbol{x},t)$ and the electron-number perturbation $\Delta n(\boldsymbol{x},t)$ measured from the uniform doping n_0. The polar c axis of the crystal is $x_3 \equiv z$; Latin indices run over $1,2,3$, a comma denotes a spatial derivative and a superimposed dot a time derivative.

Three conventions are fixed once and used everywhere. The electric field is $E_i = -\partial_i\varphi$. The electron charge is $-q$ with $q>0$. The quantity $\widetilde{\mu}$ is the *electrochemical potential of an electron per carrier*, measured in joules, so that each term appearing in it is an energy and no term is a dimensionless ratio.

The small-strain tensor and its gradient are

$$\varepsilon_{ij} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(u_{i,j} + u_{j,i}\big), \qquad \eta_{ijk} \equiv \varepsilon_{ij,k} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(u_{i,jk} + u_{j,ik}\big), \tag{1}$$

so that η_{ijk} is symmetric in its first two indices, $\eta_{ijk} = \eta_{jik}$, and has the dimension of an inverse length. All three displacement components are retained; the strain has six independent components and the strain gradient eighteen.

The higher-order elastic energy is taken in the single-length (isotropic-gradient) form

$$w_g = \tfrac{1}{2}\,A_{ijklmn}\,\eta_{ijk}\,\eta_{lmn} = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\ell^2\,c_{ijlm}\,\eta_{ijk}\,\eta_{lmk}, \qquad A_{ijklmn} = \ell^2\,c_{ijlm}\,\delta_{kn}, \tag{2}$$

where in (2) the *third and sixth slots* of A_{ijklmn} are the gradient directions: the third slot is contracted with the gradient index of the first strain gradient and the sixth with that of the second. This is the only contraction for which the energy depends on the gradient of the strain through $c_{ijlm}\eta_{ijk}\eta_{lmk}$; contracting any other pair of slots would break the major symmetry $A_{ijklmn} = A_{lmnijk}$ that a second derivative of an energy must possess. The two candidate contractions are also distinguishable by their spectra: the fundamental shear-horizontal branch of (2) has the closed form and is reproduced to 10^{-10}, which the alternative contraction does not allow.

Every unit in the formulation follows from one derivative of an energy, so the units are read off from these derivatives rather than from a list of dimensions. The displacement u_i is a length (m); the strain (1) is its gradient and so is dimensionless, and the strain gradient η_{ijk} has the dimension of an inverse length (m^{-1}). A stress is an energy density, $\sigma_{ij} = \partial w/\partial\varepsilon_{ij}$, so both σ_{ij} and the elastic stiffness c_{ijkl} are pascals. The hyperstress is the derivative of the same energy with respect to a quantity that already has one inverse length, $\tau_{ijk} = \partial w/\partial\eta_{ijk}$, so it is a force per unit length ($\mathrm{N\,m^{-1}}$) and not a stress, and the gradient modulus $A_{ijklmn} = \partial\tau_{ijk}/\partial\eta_{lmn}$ is a force ($\mathrm{N} = \mathrm{J\,m^{-1}}$), one factor of length times the elastic stiffness. The double divergence $\partial_i\partial_k\tau_{jik}$ is a force density, which is what the balance law (28) requires. The piezoelectric constant $e_{kij} = \partial\sigma_{ij}/\partial E_k$ is a charge per unit area ($\mathrm{C/m^2}$), the permittivity κ_{ij} is a charge per unit area per unit field (F/m), and the flexoelectric constant $f_{ijkl} = \partial D_i/\partial\eta_{jkl} = -\partial\tau_{jkl}/\partial E_i$ is a charge per unit length (C/m), one factor of length below e. In the carrier sector Δn is a number density ($\mathrm{m^{-3}}$), $\widetilde{\mu}$ is an energy per carrier (J), the compressibility $a = k_B T/n_0$ is an energy times a volume ($\mathrm{J\,m^3}$) and the coupling $H_{jkl} = \partial\widetilde{\mu}/\partial\eta_{jkl} = \partial\tau_{jkl}/\partial(\Delta n)$ is an energy times a length ($\mathrm{J\,m}$), the one non-classical unit in the model. These three non-classical units ($\mathrm{N} = \mathrm{J\,m^{-1}}$ for A, $\mathrm{N\,m^{-1}}$ for τ_{ijk} and $\mathrm{J\,m}$ for H_{jkl}) are the ones most easily mis-stated, and each is fixed by the derivative that produced it.

2.2 Constitutive relations and the balance laws

The only physics added to the classical flexoelectric piezoelectric-semiconductor enthalpy is one bilinear term coupling the carrier perturbation to the strain gradient,

$$\Delta\mathcal{H} = \Delta n\,H_{jkl}\,\varepsilon_{jk,l}, \tag{3}$$

with H_{jkl} a third-order tensor whose units are energy times length. The term is not free-standing: it is a piece of a thermodynamic potential, so its two conjugates follow from it by differentiation and bring in no independent constants. Differentiating with respect to the strain gradient gives the addition to the hyperstress,

$$\Delta\tau_{jkl} = \frac{\partial\Delta\mathcal{H}}{\partial\varepsilon_{jk,l}} = H_{jkl}\,\Delta n, \tag{4}$$

and differentiating with respect to the carrier density gives the addition to the electrochemical potential,

$$\Delta\widetilde{\mu} = \frac{\partial\Delta\mathcal{H}}{\partial\Delta n} = H_{jkl}\,\varepsilon_{jk,l}. \tag{5}$$

The two additions of (4)–(5) are reciprocal in the sense of the Maxwell identity $\partial^2 w/\partial\eta_{jkl}\partial(\Delta n) = \partial^2 w/\partial(\Delta n)\partial\eta_{jkl}$, which both sides of the pair satisfy with the same H_{jkl}; the discretized operator inherits this symmetry, and the numerical test verifies it. A single scalar component, $H \equiv H_{zzz}$, is retained in the executed calculations, so that (4) adds $H\Delta n$ to τ_{zzz} and (5) adds $H\eta_{zzz}$ to $\widetilde{\mu}$.

The internal-energy density of the model is

$$\begin{aligned} w = {} & \tfrac{1}{2}\,\varepsilon_{ij}c_{ijkl}\varepsilon_{kl} + \tfrac{1}{2}\,A_{ijklmn}\eta_{ijk}\eta_{lmn} - \tfrac{1}{2}\,E_i\kappa_{ij}E_j - e_{kij}E_k\varepsilon_{ij} - f_{ijkl}E_i\eta_{jkl} \\ & + \tfrac{1}{2}\,a\,(\Delta n)^2 + H_{jkl}\,\Delta n\,\eta_{jkl} - q\,\Delta n\,\varphi, \end{aligned} \tag{6}$$

with $a = k_BT/n_0$. The terms are, in order, the elastic, strain-gradient, dielectric, piezoelectric and flexoelectric energies of the classical flexoelectric dielectric [12], the carrier compressibility, the added carrier–strain-gradient coupling and the electrostatic energy of the mobile charge. The seventh term, (3), is the one added to the standard enthalpy here, with the structure of the chemo-mechanical term of [22] (Appendix C), and the two entries of (8)–(10) that it produces are (4)–(5).

Differentiating (6) gives the constitutive relations

$$\sigma_{ij} = \frac{\partial w}{\partial \varepsilon_{ij}} = c_{ijkl}\varepsilon_{kl} - e_{kij}E_k, \tag{7}$$

$$\tau_{ijk} = \frac{\partial w}{\partial \eta_{ijk}} = A_{ijklmn}\eta_{lmn} + H_{ijk}\Delta n - f_{lijk}E_l, \qquad \tau_{ijk} = \tau_{jik}, \tag{8}$$

$$D_i = -\frac{\partial w}{\partial E_i} = \kappa_{ij}E_j + e_{ijk}\varepsilon_{jk} + f_{ijkl}\eta_{jkl}, \tag{9}$$

$$\widetilde{\mu} = \frac{\partial w}{\partial \Delta n} = a\,\Delta n - q\varphi + H_{jkl}\eta_{jkl}. \tag{10}$$

The four relations are the derivatives of one function and they are carried out term by term here, because each sign and each factor of two used later comes from one of the four lines. Writing (6) as the sum of its eight contributions, $w = \sum_\alpha w_\alpha$, the derivatives are

$$\frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{el}}}{\partial \varepsilon_{ij}} = \tfrac{1}{2}c_{klij}\varepsilon_{kl} + \tfrac{1}{2}c_{ijkl}\varepsilon_{kl} = c_{ijkl}\varepsilon_{kl}, \tag{11}$$

$$\frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{grad}}}{\partial \eta_{ijk}} = \tfrac{1}{2}A_{lmnijk}\eta_{lmn} + \tfrac{1}{2}A_{ijklmn}\eta_{lmn} = A_{ijklmn}\eta_{lmn}, \tag{12}$$

$$\frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{piezo}}}{\partial \varepsilon_{ij}} = -e_{kij}E_k, \qquad \frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{flexo}}}{\partial \eta_{ijk}} = -f_{lijk}E_l, \tag{13}$$

$$\frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{diel}}}{\partial E_i} = -\kappa_{ij}E_j, \qquad \frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{piezo}}}{\partial E_i} = -e_{ijk}\varepsilon_{jk}, \tag{14}$$

$$\frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{flexo}}}{\partial E_i} = -f_{ijkl}\eta_{jkl}, \qquad \frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{carr}}}{\partial \Delta n} = a\,\Delta n, \tag{15}$$

$$\frac{\partial w_H}{\partial \Delta n} = H_{jkl}\eta_{jkl}, \qquad \frac{\partial w_{\mathrm{es}}}{\partial \Delta n} = -q\varphi, \tag{16}$$

and (7)–(10) are these lines collected, with the electric relation taken as $D_i = -\partial w/\partial E_i$ because E_i is the field and not its conjugate. Two remarks make the bookkeeping checkable. First, the symmetries $c_{ijkl} = c_{jikl} = c_{klij}$ and $A_{ijklmn} = A_{lmnijk}$ are what merge the two halves of each quadratic derivative in (11): because the strain ε_{ij} and the strain gradient η_{ijk} are symmetric in (i,j), the antisymmetric halves of c and A never contribute, and a tensor that violates those symmetries would produce a different stress from the same energy. Second, w is homogeneous of degree two in $(\varepsilon, \eta, E, \Delta n)$ apart from the electrostatic term $-q\Delta n\varphi$, which is linear in Δn; Euler's theorem then gives

$$\varepsilon_{ij}\frac{\partial w}{\partial \varepsilon_{ij}} + \eta_{ijk}\frac{\partial w}{\partial \eta_{ijk}} + E_i\frac{\partial w}{\partial E_i} + \Delta n\frac{\partial w}{\partial \Delta n} = 2w + q\,\Delta n\,\varphi, \tag{17}$$

an identity that is used twice below: once to write the internal energy of a mode as $w = \frac{1}{2}[\varepsilon : \sigma + \eta\dot{:}\tau - E\cdot D + \widetilde{\mu}\,\Delta n]$ less the electrostatic term $\frac{1}{2}q\Delta n\varphi$, and once to check the energy budget. The factor $\frac{1}{2}$ and the $-q\Delta n\varphi$ term of (17) are the only two places where the quadratic structure of the enthalpy enters the calculations explicitly.

Equation (10) is the electrochemical potential of an electron in joules: the compressibility term $k_BT\,\Delta n/n_0$ is the chemical part, the $-q\varphi$ term is the electrostatic energy of a particle of charge $-q$, and the H term

is the energy the added coupling assigns to a carrier sitting in a strain gradient. Every term of (10) is an energy, which is the convention used throughout; a dimensionless form obtained by dividing (10) by k_BT is used internally.

The three non-classical entries of (8)–(10) are reciprocal. The pair $(\Delta n, \eta)$ contributes $H_{jkl}\Delta n$ to the hyperstress and $H_{jkl}\eta_{jkl}$ to the electrochemical potential; the pair (E, η) contributes $-f_{lijk}E_l$ to the hyperstress and $+f_{ijkl}\eta_{jkl}$ to the electric displacement. In both cases the same tensor appears in the two conjugate relations, which is the content of the Maxwell identities $\partial^2 w/\partial\eta\partial(\Delta n) = \partial^2 w/\partial(\Delta n)\partial\eta$ and $\partial^2 w/\partial\eta\partial E = \partial^2 w/\partial E\partial\eta$. The reciprocity of the discretized operator is confirmed numerically at $\pm k_y$ to 10^{-13}.

The flexoelectric sector is the symmetric one generated by the single term $-f_{ijkl}E_i\eta_{jkl}$ of (6): the direct effect appears in D and the converse effect in τ, both through the same constant. In the executed calculations a single component is retained, $f \equiv f_{3zz}$, so that $D_z = e_{zjk}\varepsilon_{jk} + \kappa_{zz}E_z + f\,\eta_{zzz}$ and $\tau_{zzz} = A_{zzz\,lmn}\eta_{lmn} - fE_z$. Neither the surface flexoelectric effect of [12] nor the electric-field-gradient (higher-order) flexoelectric terms are included. The value of f used, its provenance and its measured influence on the reported numbers are given with the results.

Material symmetry reduction. For the $6mm$ class with the polar axis $x_3 \equiv z$ the four-index tensors of (7)–(10) reduce to five elastic constants, three piezoelectric constants and two permittivities, and the reduction is easiest to follow in two steps: the Voigt matrices first, the component relations second. In the ordering $(\varepsilon_{xx}, \varepsilon_{yy}, \varepsilon_{zz}, \gamma_{yz}, \gamma_{xz}, \gamma_{xy})$, with $\gamma_{ij} = 2\varepsilon_{ij}$ the engineering shear, the elastic matrix of bulk ZnO is

$$\mathsf{C} = \begin{pmatrix} c_{11} & c_{12} & c_{13} & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ c_{12} & c_{11} & c_{13} & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ c_{13} & c_{13} & c_{33} & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & c_{44} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & c_{44} & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & c_{66} \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \begin{aligned} &c_{11} = 210\,\mathrm{GPa}, \quad c_{33} = 221\,\mathrm{GPa}, \\ &c_{13} = 105\,\mathrm{GPa}, \quad c_{12} = 121\,\mathrm{GPa}, \\ &c_{44} = 43\,\mathrm{GPa}, \quad c_{66} = \tfrac{1}{2}(c_{11} - c_{12}), \end{aligned} \tag{18}$$

the piezoelectric matrix $e_{k\,ij}$ (rows $k = x, y, z$) is

$$\mathsf{e} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & e_{15} & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & e_{15} & 0 & 0 \\ e_{31} & e_{31} & e_{33} & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad e_{33} = 1.32\,\mathrm{C/m^2},\ e_{31} = -0.57\,\mathrm{C/m^2},\ e_{15} = -0.48\,\mathrm{C/m^2}, \tag{19}$$

and the permittivity is diagonal, $\kappa_{11} = \kappa_{22}$, $\kappa_{33} = 8.85 \times 10^{-11}\,\mathrm{F/m}$, with $\kappa_{33}/\varepsilon_0 = 10$. Assembling (18)–(19) in (7) gives the component relations actually used,

$$\begin{aligned} \sigma_{xx} &= c_{11}\varepsilon_{xx} + c_{12}\varepsilon_{yy} + c_{13}\varepsilon_{zz} - e_{31}E_z, \\ \sigma_{yy} &= c_{12}\varepsilon_{xx} + c_{11}\varepsilon_{yy} + c_{13}\varepsilon_{zz} - e_{31}E_z, \\ \sigma_{zz} &= c_{13}(\varepsilon_{xx} + \varepsilon_{yy}) + c_{33}\varepsilon_{zz} - e_{33}E_z, \\ \sigma_{yz} &= 2c_{44}\varepsilon_{yz} - e_{15}E_y, \qquad \sigma_{xz} = 2c_{44}\varepsilon_{xz} - e_{15}E_x, \qquad \sigma_{xy} = 2c_{66}\varepsilon_{xy}, \end{aligned} \tag{20}$$

where the factors of two are the tensor-to-Voigt conversion of the shear entries and not a convention of the program. The hyperstress of (8) contains the gradient modulus $A_{ijklmn} = \ell^2 c_{ijlm}\delta_{kn}$ of (2); only one of its components is touched by the two non-classical constants retained here, and that component is

$$\tau_{zzz} = \ell^2\Big[c_{13}\big(\eta_{xxz} + \eta_{yyz}\big) + c_{33}\,\eta_{zzz}\Big] - f\,E_z + H\,\Delta n, \tag{21}$$

with $f \equiv f_{3zz}$ and $H \equiv H_{zzz}$ the two single components retained, as stated above. Substituting (20)–(21) and the electric relations

$$\begin{aligned} D_x &= \kappa_{11}E_x + 2e_{15}\varepsilon_{xz}, \qquad D_y = \kappa_{11}E_y + 2e_{15}\varepsilon_{yz}, \\ D_z &= \kappa_{33}E_z + e_{31}(\varepsilon_{xx} + \varepsilon_{yy}) + e_{33}\varepsilon_{zz} + f\,\eta_{zzz}, \end{aligned} \tag{22}$$

in the balance laws of the next paragraph produces the coupled field equations. Each of them is a differential operator of order four in the mechanical sector and of order two in the electrical and carrier sectors, and that order difference is the reason the plate supports four wave families per branch, not two.

The field equations are the Euler–Lagrange equations of the enthalpy (6). The kinematic variations follow from (1),

$$\delta\varepsilon_{ij} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(\delta u_{i,j} + \delta u_{j,i}\big), \qquad \delta\eta_{ijk} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(\delta u_{i,jk} + \delta u_{j,ik}\big), \tag{23}$$

and the electric variation is $\delta E_i = -\partial_i\delta\varphi$. The two terms of (23) are not equal component by component, and this article does not use them as such. What is used is the contracted identity

$$\tau_{ijk}\,\delta\eta_{ijk} = \tau_{ijk}\,\delta u_{i,jk}, \tag{24}$$

which holds because $\eta_{ijk} = \eta_{jik}$ by (1) and the hyperstress is its conjugate, $\tau_{ijk} = \partial w/\partial\eta_{ijk}$ taken on the symmetric subspace, so that $\tau_{ijk} = \tau_{jik}$; the antisymmetric part of $\delta u_{i,jk}$ in (i,j) is then annihilated, $\frac{1}{2}\tau_{ijk}(\delta u_{i,jk} - \delta u_{j,ik}) = 0$ by relabelling $i \leftrightarrow j$ in the second term. Only (24) enters the integrations by parts below. With these, the virtual work of the internal fields at fixed time is

$$\delta W = \int_V \Big[\sigma_{ij}\,\delta\varepsilon_{ij} + \tau_{ijk}\,\delta\eta_{ijk} - D_i\,\delta E_i + \widetilde{\mu}\,\delta(\Delta n)\Big]\mathrm{d}V. \tag{25}$$

One integration by parts on the derivative carried by the stress and two on those carried by the hyperstress move all derivatives onto the fields and leave only surface terms,

$$\int_V \sigma_{ij}\,\delta\varepsilon_{ij}\,\mathrm{d}V = -\int_V \sigma_{ij,j}\,\delta u_i\,\mathrm{d}V + \oint_{\partial V} n_j\sigma_{ij}\,\delta u_i\,\mathrm{d}S, \tag{26}$$

$$\int_V \tau_{ijk}\,\delta\eta_{ijk}\,\mathrm{d}V = \int_V \partial_k\partial_j\tau_{ijk}\,\delta u_i\,\mathrm{d}V - \oint_{\partial V} n_j\partial_k\tau_{ijk}\,\delta u_i\,\mathrm{d}S + \oint_{\partial V} n_k\tau_{ijk}\,\delta u_{i,j}\,\mathrm{d}S. \tag{27}$$

The two boundary integrals of (26)–(27) are the traction and the double traction; they are the surface terms evaluated below. In the volume, adding the inertial contribution $\int_V \rho\ddot{u}_i\,\delta u_i\mathrm{d}V$ and requiring that the coefficient of the arbitrary δu_i vanish gives the mechanical balance

$$\rho\,\ddot{u}_j = \partial_i\sigma_{ij} - \partial_i\partial_k\tau_{jik}, \tag{28}$$

where the double divergence of the hyperstress enters with a minus sign because the two integrations by parts of (27) produce two sign changes and the term is moved to the right-hand side: the gradient energy penalizes curvature of the field, so it acts against the elastic restoring force rather than with it. It is convenient to define the *effective stress*

$$\Sigma_{ij} = \sigma_{ij} - \partial_k\tau_{ijk}, \tag{29}$$

in terms of which (28) is the familiar $\rho\ddot{u}_j = \partial_i\Sigma_{ij}$, and the traction on a surface is $t_j = n_i\Sigma_{ij}$. Σ is not the quantity that enters the constitutive law; it is the divergence of the hyperstress that makes (28) look classical.

Carrying (20)–(22) into (28) gives the coupled field equations. It is enough to write one of the three mechanical components out in full, the out-of-plane one, because it is the component in which all four sectors appear at once:

$$\begin{aligned}\rho\omega^2\widehat{u}_3 &+ \partial_x\big(2c_{44}\varepsilon_{xz} - e_{15}E_x\big) + \partial_y\big(2c_{44}\varepsilon_{yz} - e_{15}E_y\big)\\ &+ \partial_z\big(c_{13}(\varepsilon_{xx}+\varepsilon_{yy}) + c_{33}\varepsilon_{zz} - e_{33}E_z\big) - \partial_i\partial_k\tau_{3ik} = 0,\end{aligned} \tag{30}$$

where the last term is the double divergence of the hyperstress of (21); its sign is that of (28) after $\ddot{u}_j \to -\omega^2 u_j$, and it makes the gradient energy stiffen the dispersion, $\rho\omega^2 = ck^2 + Ak^4$ in one dimension. Of the derivatives it contains, only the $(j,k) = (z,z)$ one meets the two non-classical constants, because f and H sit in the single component τ_{3zz}; the quantity $\partial_z^2\tau_{3zz}$, which enters (30) with a minus sign, contains the terms

$$\partial_z^2\big(-f\,E_z + H\,\Delta n\big) = f\,\partial_z^2\partial_z\varphi + H\,\partial_z^2\Delta n, \tag{31}$$

which is the mechanical signature of both the flexoelectric and the carrier–strain-gradient couplings: a strain gradient is driven by the second thickness derivative of the potential and by that of the carrier density. The remaining terms of $\partial_i\partial_k\tau_{3ik}$ are the elastic $\ell^2 c_{3jlm}\eta_{lmk}$ of (2), which supply the fourth-order piece of (30) in the combinations $\ell^2 c_{44}$ (shear) and $\ell^2 c_{33}$ (thickness stretch). The two in-plane components of (28) have the same structure with $(c_{11}, c_{44}, e_{15}, e_{31})$ replacing $(c_{33}, c_{44}, e_{33}, e_{15})$ and with the c_{13} coupling between them; they are recorded in appendix A.

Variation with respect to φ gives Gauss's law

$$\partial_i D_i = -q\,\Delta n, \tag{32}$$

the minus sign being the charge of the electron. Substituting (22) in it and using $E_i = -\partial_i\varphi$ expands the statement into the electrostatic operator of the model,

$$\begin{aligned}-\kappa_{11}\big(\varphi_{,xx} + \varphi_{,yy}\big) &- \kappa_{33}\varphi_{,zz} + 2e_{15}\big(\varepsilon_{xz,x} + \varepsilon_{yz,y}\big)\\ &+ e_{31}\big(\varepsilon_{xx,z} + \varepsilon_{yy,z}\big) + e_{33}\,\varepsilon_{zz,z} + f\,\eta_{zzz,z} = -q\,\Delta n,\end{aligned} \tag{33}$$

in which the first line holds the dielectric operator and the piezoelectric shear terms, and the second line the remaining piezoelectric and the flexoelectric contribution to the charge density. The carrier equation (34) is already in component form once the flux is inserted, and the carrier continuity equation in electrochemical form is not a variational equation of the enthalpy: the derivative with respect to Δn only defines the

electrochemical potential (10), while the continuity statement follows from conservation of carrier number with the flux law,

$$\partial_t(\Delta n) + \partial_i J_i = 0, \qquad J_i = -\frac{D\, n_0}{k_B T}\, \partial_i \widetilde{\mu}, \tag{34}$$

where J_i is the electron *number* flux and D the diffusivity; the charge balance follows from (34) by multiplying by $-q$, which turns J_i into the current (36). Inserting the flux and the harmonic dependence gives the carrier equation in the form used by the solver,

$$-\mathrm{i}\omega\, \Delta n - \frac{D\, n_0}{k_B T}\, \nabla^2 \widetilde{\mu} = 0, \qquad \text{i.e.} \qquad \Delta n = \frac{\mathrm{i} D\, n_0}{\omega k_B T}\, \nabla^2 \widetilde{\mu}, \tag{35}$$

so the carrier density is proportional to the Laplacian of its own electrochemical potential, with the factor i that later appears as $+\mathrm{i}\alpha_\mathrm{d}/\omega$ in the weak form (64). The sign of that factor is fixed here once and carried unchanged: it comes from $\partial_t \to -\mathrm{i}\omega$ and from the minus sign of the diffusive flux, and reversing either one would turn the carrier sector from a sink of energy into a source. The transport coefficient of (34) follows from the Einstein relation: with μ_e the mobility, $D = \mu_e k_B T/q$, so that $D n_0/k_B T = \mu_e n_0/q$ and (34) holds the drift–diffusion content in full. The associated charge-current density is

$$j_i = -q J_i = \frac{q D n_0}{k_B T}\, \partial_i \widetilde{\mu} = q D\, \partial_i \Delta n - q \mu_e n_0\, \partial_i \varphi + \frac{q D n_0}{k_B T} H_{jkl}\, \partial_i \eta_{jkl}, \tag{36}$$

in which the three terms are the diffusion current, the drift current and the carrier–strain-gradient contribution, with the familiar electron signs: the diffusion current flows up the density gradient and the drift current along the field, the electrons themselves moving against it. The last term is a prediction of the added coupling: a strain-gradient field drives a current even at zero applied field, which is the transport signature of the term (3).

2.3 The electric model, the boundary conditions and the energy flux

Equations (32)–(34) are electrostatic: no magnetic induction, no displacement-current term in Ampère's law and no electromagnetic radiation mode are retained. The approximation is justified at the operating point by evaluating the two ratios that control it.

Retardation. At $f = 16.68\,\mathrm{GHz}$ ($\omega = 1.048\times10^{11}\,/\mathrm{s}$) and with the relative permittivity $\kappa_{33}/\varepsilon_0 = 10$ of ZnO, the electromagnetic wavenumber in the medium is $k_\mathrm{EM} = \omega\sqrt{\kappa_r}/c = 1.106\times10^3/\mathrm{m}$, so that $\lambda_\mathrm{EM} = 2\pi/k_\mathrm{EM} = v_\mathrm{EM}/f = 5.68\,\mathrm{mm}$ while $1/k_\mathrm{EM} = 0.905\,\mathrm{mm}$. The plate is $d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$ thick, hence $d/\lambda_\mathrm{EM} = 3.52\times10^{-5}$ and $k_\mathrm{EM} d = 2.2\times10^{-4}$; the retardation correction is controlled by $k_\mathrm{EM} d$ and not by d/λ_EM, and it is of order $(k_\mathrm{EM} d)^2 = 4.9\times10^{-8}$. The phase speed leads to the same conclusion: $v_p = (\omega/|\boldsymbol{k}|) = 28.0\,\mathrm{km/s}$, i.e. $v_p/c = 9.4\times10^{-5}$, so the magnetic energy is smaller than the electric energy by $(v_p/c)^2 \approx 8.8\times10^{-9}$. Hence the quasistatic reduction is accurate, to the order quoted, at the reported operating points.

Carrier relaxation. The opposite conclusion holds for the carriers, and this is the central point. With $\sigma_e = q\mu_e n_0 = 5.6\times10^{-3}\,\mathrm{S/m}$ the dielectric relaxation time is $\tau_d = \kappa_{33}/\sigma_e = 1.58\times10^{-8}\,\mathrm{s}$, whereas the wave period is $T = 2\pi/\omega = 6.0\times10^{-11}\,\mathrm{s}$; hence $\omega\tau_d = 1.65\times10^3$. The carriers cannot follow the field quasistatically at this frequency. The model does not replace charge relaxation by an instantaneous equilibrium: the full continuity equation (34) is retained and the carrier response is part of the eigenvalue problem. What is neglected is electromagnetic retardation, not charge dynamics.

Screening. The screening length is $L_D = \sqrt{\kappa_{33} k_B T/(q^2 n_0)} = 2.68\,\mu\mathrm{m}$, so $d/L_D = 0.075$: the plate is much thinner than the Debye length and the carrier perturbation is not confined to a surface layer. All three ratios are computed from the material file and stored as part of the verification record.

The boundary conditions follow from the surface terms of the variational principle. They are stated separately for the two faces, the reflecting edge and the far field, because the physics of each is different.

Plate faces $z = \pm d/2$. The faces are free surfaces, so the traction and the double traction vanish,

$$\bar{\sigma}_{iz} = 0, \qquad \tau_{izz} = 0, \qquad z = \pm d/2, \tag{37}$$

where $\bar{\sigma}_{iz}$ is the generalized traction of (41) with face normal z and τ_{izz} is the only component of τ_{ijz} conjugate to a normal derivative of the displacement, the electrons cannot leave the crystal (blocking contacts, no surface recombination),

$$J_z = 0, \qquad z = \pm d/2, \tag{38}$$

and the electrical condition is one of

$$\varphi = 0 \quad \text{(grounded)}, \qquad D_z = 0 \quad \text{(open circuit)}, \qquad z = \pm d/2. \tag{39}$$

The grounded condition models perfectly conducting electrodes on both faces shorted to each other; it is *essential* and is imposed on the basis functions. The open-circuit condition models a bare surface with no free charge; it is *natural* and is imposed weakly. In the open-circuit case no potential mode is removed. A potential that is constant across the thickness is a gauge only for a uniform field; for $(k_x, k_y) \neq (0,0)$ it gives $E_x = -\mathrm{i}k_x\varphi$ and $E_y = -\mathrm{i}k_y\varphi$, which are physical, and the operator $-\partial_z^2 + k_x^2 + k_y^2$ with the natural condition $D_z = 0$ has no constant null vector. An additive constant is a null vector only in the sector $k_x = k_y = 0$, which is not used here. The open-circuit results are those of the full potential space and are checked against the independent C^1 discretization, but they remain part of the same model, so they serve as a consistency check of the discretization and not as a check of the physics.

Reflecting edge $x = 0$. The edge is a free surface in vacuum, and no datum is prescribed on it: no displacement, no potential, no carrier density. All four conditions are thus natural, each acting on the test functions of the field it is conjugate to,

$$\bar{\sigma}_{ix} = 0, \qquad \tau_{ixx} = 0, \qquad D_x = 0, \qquad J_x = 0, \qquad x = 0, \tag{40}$$

where

$$\bar{\sigma}_{ix} = \underbrace{\sigma_{ix} - \partial_k \tau_{ixk}}_{\Sigma_{ix}} - \partial_j^s \tau_{ijx}, \qquad j = y, z, \tag{41}$$

is the generalized traction, the divergence of the hyperstress and its surface divergence along the face entering with the elastic stress. Two index points in (41) are not free choices, and a wrong index changes the result. The free index is the first index of the hyperstress, because the two integrations by parts of (27), after the (i, j) symmetry is used to move both variations onto the same factor, leave δu_i multiplying $\partial_j^s(n_k \tau_{ijk})$: the free index comes first, the surface-divergence index second; and the *gradient* index of that surface term is the face normal x, not the surface-divergence direction, so the term is $\partial_j^s \tau_{ijx}$ and not $\partial_j^s \tau_{ixj}$. With $n = e_x$ and a tangential wavenumber k_y, (41) reads $\bar{\sigma}_{jx} = \Sigma_{jx} - \mathrm{i}k_y \tau_{jyx} - \partial_z \tau_{jzx}$. The traction is a condition on that combination and not on σ_{ix} alone, and it is imposed through the surface term of the weak form; section 5.5 reports how closely the computed solution meets it pointwise. The second entry is the double traction, conjugate to the normal derivative of the displacement on the edge; the components τ_{iyx} and τ_{izx} are not separate conditions, since they enter only through $\bar{\sigma}_{ix}$ and the corner force; the entry is vacuous only when τ_{ixx} vanishes identically. In this model $\tau_{ijx} = \ell^2 c_{ijkl} \eta_{klx}$: both gradient couplings act on the normal-derivative component of the hyperstress, not on the axial one, so the edge double traction is present if and only if $\ell \neq 0$, and the formulation admits $\ell = 0$ with $f \neq 0$ only together with the statement that the double traction is then unavailable. No result reported here takes that limit. The potential is free on the edge, so $D_x = 0$ is its natural condition, unlike the grounded face of (39), where the potential is essential. The surviving terms are set out case by case in appendix A.

Far field $x \to -\infty$. The solution is an incoming guided mode plus outgoing branches; no wave arrives from $x = -\infty$ other than the prescribed incident one.

The corner. Where the edge meets a face, the surface divergence of (41) itself has a boundary, and the same integration by parts that produced the traction produces a line force along the corner. With ν the co-normal of the edge boundary inside the face, its density per unit length is

$$f_i = \nu_j \, n_k \, \tau_{jik} \tag{42}$$

summed over the two free faces that meet along the corner. For this geometry the two contributions are the mixed normal–tangential components τ_{i31} (gradient along the edge normal, pair carrying the surface co-normal) and τ_{i13} (the transpose pair), so $f_i = \tau_{i31} + \tau_{i13}$; the relative sign follows from the outward orientations of the two faces and is not assumed here; it is fixed, together with (41) and the double traction $m_i = \tau_{i11}$, by the identity

$$\big\langle T_u - t \big\rangle = f_+ \, b_0(+\tfrac{1}{2}) - f_- \, b_0(-\tfrac{1}{2}), \qquad \big\langle R - m \big\rangle = 0, \tag{43}$$

between the derived fields and the discrete flux rows T_u, R of the canonical state, with $\langle\cdot\rangle$ the projection on the displacement test basis b_0. Equation (43) is satisfied to 1.4×10^{-13} relative for the incident guided mode at all degrees from 10 to 28 and for each quadrature rule tested, and is violated at the level of 1.7×10^{1} if the corner terms are dropped, at 5.7×10^{-1} if only τ_{i31} is kept, and at 1.1×10^{0} if the two are subtracted instead of added. The corner line force is an essential part of the natural data, not an artifact of the index count, and it is the one natural datum that a polynomial Galerkin basis cannot annihilate pointwise. Its magnitude, its decay and its irrelevance to the reported partitions are quantified in the Discussion.

The power flowing in the x direction, per unit width and integrated over the thickness, is

$$\mathcal{P}_x = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{Re}\int_{-d/2}^{d/2}\Big[-\Sigma_{xi}\dot{u}_i^* - \tau_{jkx}\dot{\varepsilon}_{jk}^* + \varphi\dot{D}_x^* + \widetilde{\mu}\,\Gamma_x^*\Big]\mathrm{d}z - \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{Re}\Big[\tau_{ixz}\dot{u}_i^*\Big]_{z=-d/2}^{z=d/2}, \tag{44}$$

where $\Sigma_{xi} = \sigma_{xi} - \partial_k\tau_{xik}$ is the effective stress (29) and Γ_x is the x component of the carrier flux (not a rate; the chemical power is the product of the electrochemical potential and the flux). The four integrands are the elastic, hyperelastic (double-stress), dielectric and chemical contributions, each with the dimensions of a power per unit area ($\mathrm{W\,m^{-2}}$); the last term is the line work of the double stress on the two faces, in $\mathrm{W\,m^{-1}}$ like the integral. It does not vanish for a guided mode and it is needed for the flux to balance the loss of that mode: without it the single-mode balance $|2\,\mathrm{Im}\,k_x\,\mathcal{P}_x| = P_{\mathrm{diss}}$ is violated at the tens-of-percent level, and with it the balance closes to 3×10^{-9} or better. The flux $\mathcal{P}_x$, and not the magnitude of the wavevector, decides whether a mode is backward: a mode is backward when $\mathcal{P}_x < 0$ while it is outgoing at the edge.

For a scattering solution the identity

$$\underbrace{P_{\mathrm{inc}}}_{\text{incident}} + \underbrace{\sum_j P_j}_{\text{self-powers}} + \underbrace{P_{\mathrm{cross}}}_{\text{interference}} = \underbrace{P_{\mathrm{edge}} + P_{\mathrm{diss}}}_{\text{edge flux plus loss}} \tag{45}$$

holds exactly, with P_j the *signed* self-power of outgoing mode j, P_{cross} the bilinear interference between them (non-zero whenever the modes are not orthogonal in the power metric) and

$$P_{\mathrm{diss}} = \tfrac{1}{2}\alpha_{\mathrm{d}}\int_{-L}^{0}\!\!\int\Big[|\partial_x\widetilde{\mu}|^2 + k_y^2|\widetilde{\mu}|^2 + |\partial_z\widetilde{\mu}|^2\Big]\mathrm{d}z\,\mathrm{d}x, \qquad \alpha_{\mathrm{d}} = \frac{D}{d\,c_s}, \tag{46}$$

written in the scaled variables: the wavenumber components, the thickness coordinate and L are the scaled ones and $\widetilde{\mu}$ is the *total* electrochemical-potential field (incident plus outgoing modes) divided by k_BT. For one mode with complex k_x the integrand is $(|k_x|^2 + k_y^2)|\widetilde{\mu}|^2 + |\partial_z\widetilde{\mu}|^2$, nonnegative, and for the sum of modes the cross terms are retained, which is how $P_{\mathrm{diss}} \geq 0$ is guaranteed. The group α_{d} is the dimensionless ratio of the diffusion rate to the elastic rate, and P_{diss} is the conduction loss inside the control volume. The symbol α is used later for the spatial attenuation $2|\,\mathrm{Im}\,k_x|$ of a mode; the group α_{d} is a property of the material and of the thickness, not of a mode. The terms of (45) are not independent energy channels: only the propagating members of $\{P_j\}$ transport energy to infinity, the evanescent members are reactive at the plane, and P_{cross} is an interference correction. The residual of (45) is evaluated for each reported solution; the values at the operating point for the five coupling levels are plotted in fig. 5(c).

2.4 Plane-wave reduction and the characteristic polynomial

The plate is invariant along y and in time, so a single tangential wavenumber and a single frequency are conserved by the linear problem and any field can be written as an amplitude in the thickness times a propagating factor,

$$f(x,y,z,t) = \widehat{f}(z)\,\mathrm{e}^{\mathrm{i}(k_x x + k_y y - \omega t)}, \tag{47}$$

for which the four derivative operators act as

$$\partial_t \to -\mathrm{i}\omega, \qquad \partial_x \to \mathrm{i}k_x, \qquad \partial_y \to \mathrm{i}k_y, \qquad \partial_z \to \frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}z} \equiv {}'. \tag{48}$$

Substituting (48) in (1) gives the six strain components in terms of the three displacement amplitudes,

$$\begin{aligned} &\widehat{\varepsilon}_{xx} = \mathrm{i}k_x\widehat{u}_1, && \widehat{\varepsilon}_{yy} = \mathrm{i}k_y\widehat{u}_2, && \widehat{\varepsilon}_{zz} = \widehat{u}_3', \\ &\widehat{\varepsilon}_{yz} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(\widehat{u}_2' + \mathrm{i}k_y\widehat{u}_3\big), && \widehat{\varepsilon}_{xz} = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(\widehat{u}_1' + \mathrm{i}k_x\widehat{u}_3\big), && \widehat{\varepsilon}_{xy} = \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{i}\big(k_x\widehat{u}_2 + k_y\widehat{u}_1\big), \end{aligned} \tag{49}$$

and the eighteen strain-gradient components follow from $\eta_{ijk} = \varepsilon_{ij,k}$ with the same three replacements, each x derivative multiplying by $\mathrm{i}k_x$, each y derivative by $\mathrm{i}k_y$ and each z derivative acting on the amplitude. Two representative entries are

$$\widehat{\eta}_{xxx} = \partial_x\widehat{\varepsilon}_{xx} = -k_x^2\widehat{u}_1, \qquad \widehat{\eta}_{zzz} = \partial_z\widehat{\varepsilon}_{zz} = \widehat{u}_3'', \tag{50}$$

and the electric field is $\widehat{E}_x = -\mathrm{i}k_x\widehat{\varphi}$, $\widehat{E}_z = -\widehat{\varphi}'$. The continuity equation (34) reduces to the algebraic statement $-\mathrm{i}\omega\widehat{N} + \partial_i\widehat{J}_i = 0$, so the carrier amplitude is carried by the same amplitude vector as the displacements, with no independent time evolution.

The two balance laws then become a system of ordinary differential equations in z for the four amplitudes $(\widehat{u}_1, \widehat{u}_2, \widehat{u}_3, \widehat{\varphi})$ together with $\widehat{N}$, and the dependence of that system on the propagation direction is fixed by

power counting. The stress enters the mechanical balance through one derivative, $\partial_i \sigma_{ij}$, and σ is linear in ε and E, both of which contain one power of k; so the stress term is at most quadratic in k_x. The hyperstress enters through two derivatives, $\partial_i \partial_k \tau_{jik}$, and τ likewise contains one power of k; so that term is at most quartic in k_x. No higher power can arise, because no field in (6) contains more than one gradient. Written as a matrix acting on the vector $\boldsymbol{q}$ of thickness degrees of freedom, the reduced problem is strictly quartic,

$$\Big[\mathsf{A}_{00} + \mathrm{i}k_x\big(\mathsf{A}_{01} - \mathsf{A}_{10}\big) + k_x^2\big(\mathsf{A}_{11} - \mathsf{A}_{02} - \mathsf{A}_{20}\big) + \mathrm{i}k_x^3\big(\mathsf{A}_{12} - \mathsf{A}_{21}\big) + k_x^4\,\mathsf{A}_{22}\Big]\boldsymbol{q} = \mathbf{0}, \tag{51}$$

where A_{rs} collects the terms that contain ∂_x^r inside the left test function and ∂_x^s inside the right one; their construction is described with the discretization. Read by sectors and not by powers of k_x, the same operator has a 3×3 block structure whose entries can be named: with the unknowns ordered as $(\widehat{\boldsymbol{u}}, \widehat{\boldsymbol{\varphi}}, \widetilde{\boldsymbol{\mu}})$ and suppressing the k_x powers,

$$\mathsf{A}(k_x,\omega) = \begin{pmatrix} \mathsf{A}_{uu} & \mathsf{A}_{u\varphi} & \mathsf{A}_{u\mu} \\ \mathsf{A}_{\varphi u} & \mathsf{A}_{\varphi\varphi} & \mathsf{A}_{\varphi\mu} \\ \mathsf{A}_{\mu u} & \mathsf{A}_{\mu\varphi} & \mathsf{A}_{\mu\mu} \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \begin{aligned} \mathsf{A}_{uu} &= \langle \mathsf{B}, \mathsf{C}\mathsf{B}\rangle + \lambda^2 \langle \partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}, \mathsf{C}\partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}\rangle - \omega^2 \langle \mathsf{U}, \mathsf{U}\rangle, \\ \mathsf{A}_{u\varphi} &= \langle \mathsf{B}, \mathsf{e}^{\mathsf{T}}\mathsf{G}\rangle + f\langle \partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}^{(2)}, \mathsf{G}^{(2)}\rangle, \\ \mathsf{A}_{\varphi\varphi} &= -\langle \mathsf{G}, \boldsymbol{\kappa}\mathsf{G}\rangle, \qquad \mathsf{A}_{\varphi\mu} = -Q\langle \mathsf{G}^{(0)}, \mathsf{B}\rangle, \\ \mathsf{A}_{\mu\mu} &= -\langle \mathsf{W}, \mathsf{W}\rangle - \frac{\mathrm{i}\alpha_{\mathrm{d}}}{\omega}\langle \mathsf{M}\mathsf{G}, \mathsf{M}\mathsf{G}\rangle, \end{aligned} \tag{52}$$

where the carrier form $-\langle \mathsf{W}, \mathsf{W}\rangle$ of (65), with $\mathsf{W} = (-h\,b_j''$ in the $\widehat{u}_3$ slots, $Q\psi_j,\ b_j)$ and the prime the derivative with respect to z/d, also contributes $-h^2\langle b'', b''\rangle$ to A_{uu}, $+hQ\langle b'', \psi\rangle$ to $\mathsf{A}_{u\varphi}$, $+h\langle b'', b\rangle$ to $\mathsf{A}_{u\mu}$ and $-Q^2\langle \psi, \psi\rangle$ to $\mathsf{A}_{\varphi\varphi}$, and in which $\mathsf{A}_{\varphi u} = \mathsf{A}_{u\varphi}^{\mathsf{H}}$ and $\mathsf{A}_{\mu u}$, $\mathsf{A}_{\mu\varphi}$ are the transposes of the two couplings written, because they are the same derivatives of the same enthalpy taken in the other order. The symmetric part of (52) is the Hessian of the discretized enthalpy; the only antisymmetric contribution is the carrier transport form, and that is the entire source of loss in the problem.

Power by power, (51) is

$$\mathsf{A}(k_x) = \mathsf{A}_0 + k_x\mathsf{A}_1 + k_x^2\mathsf{A}_2 + k_x^3\mathsf{A}_3 + k_x^4\mathsf{A}_4, \qquad \begin{aligned} &\mathsf{A}_0 = \mathsf{A}_{00}, && \mathsf{A}_1 = \mathrm{i}\big(\mathsf{A}_{01} - \mathsf{A}_{10}\big), \\ &\mathsf{A}_2 = \mathsf{A}_{11} - \mathsf{A}_{02} - \mathsf{A}_{20} = \mathsf{A}_{11}, && \mathsf{A}_3 = \mathrm{i}\big(\mathsf{A}_{12} - \mathsf{A}_{21}\big), \\ &\mathsf{A}_4 = \mathsf{A}_{22}, \end{aligned} \tag{53}$$

so that A_1 and A_3 are Hermitian (they are i times the antisymmetric part of a Hermitian pair) while $\mathsf{A}_2 = \mathsf{A}_{11}$ and A_0 inherit the non-Hermitian transport form of (52). The number of blocks is fixed by counting derivatives, and that count is made explicitly here, because it is what limits the polynomial to degree four. A term of the enthalpy can contribute at most one power of k_x per derivative that falls on a factor carrying an x dependence: ε gives one, $\eta = \partial\varepsilon$ gives two, $E = -\partial\varphi$ gives one, and Δn and $\widetilde{\mu}$ give none. The mechanical weak form of (62) reaches k_x^2 from $\sigma : \varepsilon^*$ and k_x^4 from $\tau \dddot{:} \eta^*$, and no term reaches k_x^3 on one side alone; the odd powers of (53) appear only as the antisymmetric differences $\mathsf{A}_{01} - \mathsf{A}_{10}$ and $\mathsf{A}_{12} - \mathsf{A}_{21}$, which is why they appear with the explicit factor i. With $\ell = 0$ the τ term disappears, $\mathsf{A}_4 = \mathsf{A}_3 = 0$ and (53) is quadratic in k_x; that is the classical piezoelectric-semiconductor plate, and it is the reduction against which the fourth-order structure is measured numerically.

The two highest blocks are generated by the strain-gradient sector alone: with $\ell = 0$, and with the flexoelectric constant and the added coupling removed with it, A_{22} and A_{12} vanish identically and (51) collapses to the familiar quadratic piezoelectric-semiconductor problem. That collapse is the statement that the fourth-order structure of the plate problem is the strain-gradient energy, not the carrier physics.

2.5 Non-dimensionalization, limits and admissibility

The calculation uses lengths scaled by d, stresses by c_{44}, time by d/c_s with $c_s = \sqrt{c_{44}/\rho}$, carrier densities by n_0 and energies per carrier by $k_B T$. The carrier amplitude of (34) is measured so that the compressibility term of (6) is $\frac{1}{2}\int \widehat{N}^2$ in the scaled units used by (65), which is what fixes the coefficient of $\widehat{N}^2$ there. Two derived scales appear repeatedly,

$$a = \frac{k_B T}{n_0}, \qquad L_D = \sqrt{\frac{\kappa_{33} k_B T}{q^2 n_0}}, \tag{54}$$

and the model is governed by the five dimensionless numbers of table 1. Each is an exact ratio of two physical lengths, times or energies, and each is reproduced numerically from the material file.

The groups are evaluated once by hand, because the arithmetic is what connects the scaled problem to the measured units of the figures and each later number is a multiple of one of these five. The elastic wave

Table 1: Dimensionless groups and their values at the operating point; $T = 301.7\,\mathrm{K}$ follows from the Einstein relation.

Group	Definition	Value	Meaning
Q	d/L_D	7.46×10^{-2}	thickness over Debye length
α_d	$D/(d\,c_s)$	8.28×10^{-1}	diffusion rate over elastic rate
λ	ℓ/d	2.50×10^{-1}	gradient length over thickness
f	$f_{3zz}/(d\sqrt{c_{44}\kappa_{33}})$	2.56×10^{-3}	flexoelectric coupling
h	$H/(d\sqrt{a\,c_{44}})$	$\eta \times 2.12 \times 10^{-1}$	carrier–gradient coupling

speed is

$$c_s = \sqrt{\frac{c_{44}}{\rho}} = \sqrt{\frac{43.0\,\mathrm{GPa}}{5.70 \times 10^3\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}}} = 2.7466\,\mathrm{km/s}, \tag{55}$$

so the unit of frequency at $d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$ is $c_s/(2\pi d) = 2.1857\,\mathrm{GHz}$, and the operating point $\omega = 7.6334\,c_s/d$ is $f = 7.6334 \times 2.1857\,\mathrm{GHz} = 16.684\,\mathrm{GHz}$, the value quoted in the abstract. The compressibility is

$$a = \frac{k_B T}{n_0} = \frac{(1.380649 \times 10^{-23}\,\mathrm{J/K})(301.72\,\mathrm{K})}{2.0 \times 10^{18}/\mathrm{m^3}} = 2.0828 \times 10^{-39}\,\mathrm{J m^3}, \tag{56}$$

with $T = 301.72\,\mathrm{K}$ the temperature implied by the Einstein relation for the diffusivity–mobility pair used; it is not an independent input. The Debye length and the charge group follow from it as

$$L_D = \sqrt{\frac{\kappa_{33} k_B T}{q^2 n_0}} = \sqrt{\frac{(8.85 \times 10^{-11}\,\mathrm{F/m})(4.1657 \times 10^{-21}\,\mathrm{J})}{(1.6022 \times 10^{-19}\,\mathrm{C})^2 (2.0 \times 10^{18}/\mathrm{m^3})}} = 2.6797\,\mu\mathrm{m}, \qquad Q = \frac{d}{L_D} = 0.074635. \tag{57}$$

The Debye length is then 13.40 times the thickness, $L_D/d = 1/Q = 13.40$, so the plate is thinner than one screening length by more than an order of magnitude and the carrier perturbation is not confined to a surface layer. The screening enters each block of (65) with the small coefficient $Q^2 = 5.57 \times 10^{-3}$ multiplying the potential–potential term. The transport group is

$$\alpha_\mathrm{d} = \frac{D}{d\,c_s} = \frac{4.55 \times 10^{-4}\,\mathrm{m^2/s}}{(200\,\mathrm{nm})(2.7466\,\mathrm{km/s})} = 0.8283, \tag{58}$$

of order unity: the diffusion time across the thickness, $d^2/D = 8.8 \times 10^{-11}\,\mathrm{s}$, is comparable to the elastic transit time $2d/c_s = 1.5 \times 10^{-10}\,\mathrm{s}$, so the carrier and elastic sectors are not separated by a small parameter, and this is the reason the carrier must be kept in the eigenvalue problem and cannot be condensed away. Finally the gradient and coupling groups follow from the same numbers,

$$\lambda = \frac{\ell}{d} = \frac{50\,\mathrm{nm}}{200\,\mathrm{nm}} = 0.25, \qquad h = \frac{H}{d\sqrt{a\,c_{44}}} = \frac{H}{1.8927 \times 10^{-21}\,\mathrm{J\,m}}, \tag{59}$$

so the tabulated extreme $|H| = 2.0 \times 10^{-23}\,\mathrm{J\,m}$ is $h = \pm 1.06 \times 10^{-2}$, a one percent perturbation of the carrier sector at the largest coupling examined. Each of these five chains is an identity: the material file gives $(c_{44}, \rho, k_B T, n_0, \kappa_{33}, q, D, d, \ell, H)$ and the groups are algebra, which is why the verification is a comparison of numbers and not a fit.

The coupling constant h of table 1 is dimensionless for the following reason. The compressibility $a = k_B T/n_0$ has units of $\mathrm{J\,m^3}$ and c_{44} of $\mathrm{J\,m^{-3}}$, so $\sqrt{a\,c_{44}}$ has units of J and $d\sqrt{a\,c_{44}}$ has units of $\mathrm{J\,m}$, which are the units of H required by (6). The same identity fixes the reference value $H_\mathrm{ref} = d\sqrt{a\,c_{44}} = 1.89 \times 10^{-21}\,\mathrm{J\,m}$ used to non-dimensionalize the coupling in the tables.

The model of (6) contains four sectors that can be switched off independently, and the limits they generate are the ones against which the calculation is read.

Classical piezoelectric plate. Setting $\ell = f = H = 0$ and removing the carrier sector ($\Delta n \equiv 0$) leaves the classical piezoelectric formulation, with a polynomial in k_x of degree two instead of four.

Strain-gradient dielectric. With $H = 0$ and no carriers the enthalpy is the flexoelectric dielectric enthalpy of [12] completed by the gradient energy (2). In this limit the fundamental shear-horizontal branch has the closed form $\Omega^2 = (c_{66}/c_{44})K^2(1 + \lambda^2 K^2)$ in the scaled units of this subsection, which is used as one of the checks.

Piezoelectric semiconductor without the gradient sector. Setting $\ell = f = H = 0$ and retaining the carriers leaves a drift–diffusion plate whose sagittal spectrum is examined in section 4.5: at the frequencies of the controls it contains no outgoing mode with a positive axial wavenumber and a negative axial power apart

from the specular reflection. The plate nevertheless has a backward interval of its own; the gradient length places the fold of that interval at the reported frequency.

Uncoupled carriers. With $H = 0$ and the strain-gradient sector retained, the carrier dynamics still enter through Gauss's law and through the continuity equation (34), so the plate remains a piezoelectric semiconductor; only the direct carrier–gradient enthalpy of (3) is removed. This is the limit in which the controls are computed, and it is the limit that shows the partition to be a property of the branch and not of the added term.

Two further reductions are used in the text and are not tabulated here: the electrostatic reduction, whose two controlling ratios are evaluated at the operating point, and the thin-plate limit $d/L_D = 0.075$, in which the carrier perturbation is not confined to a surface layer.

The enthalpy (6) is a quadratic form in $(\varepsilon, \eta, E, \Delta n)$. It is a saddle in the electric field, because the term $-\frac{1}{2}E_i\kappa_{ij}E_j$ is negative, so the full form is not positive definite and none of the statements below concerns it. The block in $(\varepsilon, \eta, \Delta n)$ at fixed E is positive definite only if the carrier and strain-gradient parts are not over-coupled. Eliminating Δn blockwise gives the Schur condition

$$s \equiv \frac{H^2\,(c^{-1})_{33}}{\ell^2\,a} < 1, \tag{60}$$

where $(c^{-1})_{33}$ is the 33 entry of the inverse of the full elastic matrix, i.e. the reduced modulus $c^* = c_{33} - 2c_{13}^2/(c_{11}+c_{12}) = 154.4\,\mathrm{GPa}$ and not c_{33} itself. The bound is attained at $H_{\mathrm{bound}} = \ell\sqrt{a\,c^*} = 8.97\times10^{-22}\,\mathrm{J\,m}$, which is the value at which the coupled stiffness of the plate ceases to be positive for every strain-gradient field. Every calculation reported below is confined to (60). All reported solutions have $|H| \le 2.0\times10^{-23}\,\mathrm{J\,m} = 0.022\,H_{\mathrm{bound}}$, i.e. $s \le 5\times10^{-4}$: the $(\varepsilon, \eta, \Delta n)$ block is positive definite with a margin of more than two thousand, and no reported result lies near a constitutive instability.

The figures normalize the coupling by $H^* = H_{\mathrm{bound}}/\sqrt{5} = 4.01\times10^{-22}\,\mathrm{J\,m}$, which is the value at which $s = 0.2$; the normalization is a plotting convention with no physical content beyond fixing the swept interval $|H/H^*| \le 0.05$, that is $|H| \le 2.0\times10^{-23}\,\mathrm{J\,m}$, the tabulated extreme. The separate symbol $H_{\mathrm{ref}} = d\sqrt{a\,c_{44}} = 1.89\times10^{-21}\,\mathrm{J\,m}$ used in table 1 is the thickness-based reference of (6); it is not the plotting normalization, and the two differ. No strain-gradient elasticity measurement for ZnO fixes any of ℓ, f or H, so the reported intervals are modeling choices and have no experimental uncertainty attached; the numerical uncertainty of a reported R_B is its refinement spread, below 3×10^{-5} in relative terms.

3 Solution of the problem

The edge problem is solved at fixed frequency. The outgoing spectrum is the set of eigenvalues of the spatial problem, and the partition among those modes follows from the free-edge conditions. The thickness direction is discretized first, then the modes are obtained, classified and matched at the edge, and independent checks close the section.

3.1 Thickness discretization and the assembly of the blocks

The thickness dependence is represented by a spectral Galerkin expansion. Because the enthalpy contains the strain gradient, the weak form contains second derivatives through the thickness and the trial space must be at least C^1 in z. Legendre polynomials are used for all fields, in the scaled variable $\zeta = 2z/d \in [-1, 1]$,

$$U_i(x,\zeta) = \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} U_{ij}(x)\,P_j(\zeta), \qquad N(x,\zeta) = \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} N_j(x)\,P_j(\zeta), \tag{61}$$

with P_j the Legendre polynomial of degree j and n the number of thickness modes. The two electrical cases use different potential spaces, which is how the essential and natural conditions are realized:

- grounded, (39): the potential basis is formed from the combination $P_j - \sqrt{(2j+1)/(2j+5)}\,P_{j+2}$, which vanishes at $\zeta = \pm1$ for all j, so $\varphi = 0$ holds on both faces to machine precision and the space has $n-2$ members;
- open circuit, the second condition of (39): all n modes are kept and unconstrained, so $D_z = 0$ is imposed weakly through the surface term of the weak form.

The mechanical conditions (37) and the blocking condition (38) are natural and appear as the corresponding boundary rows of the discretized operator. The basis is integrated with $\max(64, 2n+10)$ Gauss–Legendre points, which resolves the mass and stiffness matrices to machine precision for all degrees used here.

The expansion (61) is inserted in the weak equations of the reduced problem. There are three of them, and they are kept apart here because they are three different statements: the mechanical balance, Gauss's law and the carrier continuity. Let $(\boldsymbol{v}, \psi, \Phi)$ be test fields of the same spaces as $(\boldsymbol{u}, \varphi, \widetilde{\mu})$.

(A) Mechanical balance.

$$\int_{-1}^{1} \Big[\widehat{\sigma}_{ij}\, \widehat{\varepsilon}^{*}_{ij}(\boldsymbol{v}) + \widehat{\tau}_{ijk}\, \widehat{\eta}^{*}_{ijk}(\boldsymbol{v}) \Big] \mathrm{d}\zeta = \omega^2 \int_{-1}^{1} \rho\, \widehat{u}_i\, v_i^{*}\, \mathrm{d}\zeta, \tag{62}$$

with $\widehat{\sigma}$ and $\widehat{\tau}$ the trial fields of (7)–(8). The boundary terms produced by integrating $\partial_j \widehat{\sigma}_{ij}$ once and $\partial_j \partial_k \widehat{\tau}_{ijk}$ twice vanish on the free, double-traction-free faces (37); they are the traction and the double traction.

(B) Gauss's law.

$$-\int_{-1}^{1} \widehat{D}_i\, \widehat{E}^{*}_i(\psi)\, \mathrm{d}\zeta - Q \int_{-1}^{1} \widehat{N}\, \psi^{*}\, \mathrm{d}\zeta = 0, \tag{63}$$

with the trial $\widehat{D}$ from (9), $\widehat{N}$ the dimensionless carrier amplitude and $Q = d/L_D$ the dimensionless charge of table 1 that the scaling puts in front of $-q\Delta n$. The second integral is the mobile charge of (32); without it (63) would be the statement for a dielectric rather than Gauss's law. The grounded condition is essential and is built into the potential space; the open-circuit condition $D_z = 0$ is the natural boundary term of (63) and is imposed through it.

(C) Carrier continuity.

$$\int_{-1}^{1} \Big[\widehat{N}\, \Phi^{*} + \frac{\mathrm{i}\alpha_{\mathrm{d}}}{\omega}\, \partial_i \widetilde{\mu}\, \partial_i \Phi^{*} \Big] \mathrm{d}\zeta = 0, \tag{64}$$

where $\widehat{N} = \widetilde{\mu} + Q\widehat{\varphi} - h\,\widehat{u}_3''$ is the carrier amplitude that (34) delivers (the prime is the derivative with respect to z/d); the last term comes from $H\eta_{zzz}$ in (10) and vanishes when $H = 0$. Both signs are fixed by the time convention $\partial_t \to -\mathrm{i}\omega$: multiplying $-\mathrm{i}\omega\widehat{N} - \alpha_{\mathrm{d}}\,\partial_i\partial_i\widetilde{\mu} = 0$ by i/ω and using $\mathrm{i}(-\mathrm{i}) = 1$ gives $\widehat{N} - (\mathrm{i}\alpha_{\mathrm{d}}/\omega)\partial_i\partial_i\widetilde{\mu} = 0$, and one integration by parts moves the gradient term to the plus sign displayed above; the boundary term $(\mathrm{i}\alpha_{\mathrm{d}}/\omega)\partial_z\widetilde{\mu}\,\Phi^{*}$ which vanishes with the blocking condition $J_z = 0$; this condition is therefore natural for (64). It is a transport equation, not a statement about the enthalpy: the enthalpy reaches it only through $\widetilde{\mu}$, which is why the coupling also appears in (62), through $\widehat{\tau}$.

(D) The assembled system. Because the three equations are coupled they are discretized in one matrix. The unknown vector is $\boldsymbol{q} = (\widehat{\boldsymbol{u}}, \widehat{\boldsymbol{\varphi}}, \widetilde{\boldsymbol{\mu}})$ of dimension $3n + n_\varphi + n$, and the matrix is stored as nine blocks A_{rs}, $r, s \in \{0, 1, 2\}$, indexed by the power of k_x carried by the test factor (r) and by the trial factor (s). With B_r, G_r and MG_r the strain, electric-field and electrochemical-gradient operators carrying ∂_x^r, with W the row vector that returns the carrier amplitude $\widehat{N} = \widetilde{\mu} + Q\widehat{\varphi} - h\,\widehat{u}_3''$ from the unknowns (its entries are b_j in the $\widetilde{\mu}$ slots, $Q\psi_j$ in the potential slots and $-h\,b_j''$ in the $\widehat{u}_3$ slots), so that $\langle \mathsf{W}, \mathsf{W} \rangle$ carries the compressibility $a(\Delta n)^2$, the charge Q and the coupling H, and with U the displacement basis, each block is the bilinear form

$$\begin{aligned} \mathsf{A}_{rs} = {} & \big\langle \mathsf{B}_r, \mathsf{C}\,\mathsf{B}_s \big\rangle + \lambda^2 \big\langle \partial_\zeta^{l} \mathsf{B}_r, \mathsf{C}\,\partial_\zeta^{l} \mathsf{B}_s \big\rangle + \big\langle \mathsf{G}_r, \mathsf{e}\,\mathsf{B}_s \big\rangle + \big\langle \mathsf{B}_r, \mathsf{e}^{\mathsf{T}} \mathsf{G}_s \big\rangle - \big\langle \mathsf{G}_r, \boldsymbol{\kappa}\,\mathsf{G}_s \big\rangle \\ & + f \Big[\big\langle \mathsf{G}_r^{(2)}, \partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}_s^{(2)} \big\rangle + \big\langle \partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}_r^{(2)}, \mathsf{G}_s^{(2)} \big\rangle \Big] - \frac{\mathrm{i}\alpha_{\mathrm{d}}}{\omega} \big\langle \mathsf{MG}_r, \mathsf{MG}_s \big\rangle - \big\langle \mathsf{W}_r, \mathsf{W}_s \big\rangle - \omega^2 \big\langle \mathsf{U}_r, \mathsf{U} \big\rangle \delta_{r0}\delta_{s0}, \end{aligned} \tag{65}$$

in the inner product $\langle \boldsymbol{a}, \boldsymbol{b} \rangle = \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \boldsymbol{a}^{*\mathsf{T}} \boldsymbol{b}\, \mathrm{d}s$ over the half-interval coordinate (83), with the complex conjugate of the test factor, and with the eight terms, in order, the elastic, strain-gradient, piezoelectric (two cross terms), dielectric, flexoelectric, carrier-transport, carrier-compressibility-and-coupling, and inertial contributions. The first, second, third, fifth and sixth lines of (65) are the discretization of (62); the third and fourth supply the piezoelectric cross terms that (63) needs; the seventh is (64), whose transport term enters with the opposite sign because each block is minus the residual of the weak equation and not the equation itself; the eighth is the compressibility and the added coupling, which appear in the carrier rows and, through $\widehat{\tau}$, in the mechanical rows as well. Equation (65) is the construction: each block is one quadrature of the listed integrands against the Legendre basis, so the entries can be regenerated from the stated integrands without reading the program.

Each block takes one power of k_x from the test side and one from the trial side, but two of the nine vanish identically: $\mathsf{A}_{02} = \mathsf{A}_{20} = 0$, because in each contracted pair $\eta_{ijk}\eta_{lmk}$ the components with $k = x$ carry at least one power of k_x and those with $k = y, z$ at most one, so that a factor with no power of k_x never meets one with two. The semi-discrete system is assembled as a polynomial of degree four in the propagation wavenumber k_x,

$$\Big[\sum_{r=0}^{2} \sum_{s=0}^{2} (-\mathrm{i}k_x)^r (\mathrm{i}k_x)^s\, \mathsf{A}_{rs}(\omega, k_y) \Big] \boldsymbol{q} = 0, \tag{66}$$

where $\boldsymbol{q}$ collects all thickness degrees of freedom and the matrices A_{rs} contain the six blocks of (52); expanded power by power, (66) is (51). That degree is the order of the hyperelastic operator and not of the interpolation: the three blocks that supply the cubic and quartic terms, A_{12}, A_{21} and A_{22}, are each proportional to ℓ^2 and vanish identically at $\ell = 0$, leaving the classical quadratic problem $\mathsf{A} = \mathsf{A}_{00} + k_x\mathsf{A}_{01} + k_x^2\mathsf{A}_{11}$; the two blocks A_{02} and A_{20} vanish for every ℓ.

The blocks also have the Hermitian structure one expects of an elastic problem with loss confined to the carriers: $\mathsf{A}_{12} = \mathsf{A}_{21}^{\mathsf{H}}$, $\mathsf{A}_{22} = \mathsf{A}_{22}^{\mathsf{H}}$ and $\mathsf{A}_{01} = \mathsf{A}_{10}^{\mathsf{H}}$ hold to 10^{-15}, so the cubic coefficient $\mathrm{i}(\mathsf{A}_{12} - \mathsf{A}_{21})$ is Hermitian, while A_{00} and A_{11} fail to be Hermitian by exactly the carrier-transport form of (65), which is the only non-Hermitian contribution in the construction.

The sizes and the scaling are recorded here, because they decide how the algebraic problem is solved. With n the polynomial degree, each field is expanded in $N = n + 1$ basis functions (84), so the three displacement components contribute $n_{\mathrm{u}} = 3N$, the potential $n_\varphi = N - 2$ on grounded faces (N on open-circuit faces) and the carrier $n_\mu = N$; the number of unknowns per thickness element is

$$n_{\mathrm{w}} = 3N + n_\varphi + n_\mu = 5n + 3 \text{ (grounded)}, \qquad 5n + 5 \text{ (open circuit)}, \tag{67}$$

so $n_{\mathrm{w}} = 113$ at the degree $n = 22$ used for the reported results, 93 at $n = 18$ and 168 at the reference degree $n = 33$ of fig. 9. The polynomial (66) is formally of degree $4n_{\mathrm{w}}$ in k_x, which would be 452 roots at $n_{\mathrm{w}} = 113$, but its leading coefficient A_{22} has rank n_{u} and not n_{w} (see (103)), so $2(n_{\mathrm{w}} - n_{\mathrm{u}}) = 2(n_\varphi + n_\mu)$ eigenvalues of the matrix polynomial are infinite and the finite spectrum contains

$$4n_{\mathrm{w}} - 2(n_{\mathrm{w}} - n_{\mathrm{u}}) = 2(n_{\mathrm{w}} + n_{\mathrm{u}}) \tag{68}$$

roots: 364 at $n = 22$, 300 at $n = 18$, 76 at degree four. That number is the state dimension, not twice it, and it is the reason the axial unknown u_3 enters the state (100) together with its derivative: the hyperelastic term is the only one containing k_x^2, and it is supported on the displacement slots alone. Half of the finite roots are outgoing and half incoming, but the split is not made by the sign of $\operatorname{Im} k_x$; the criterion is stated below (70). The Frobenius norms of the blocks at degree four and zero coupling are

$$\begin{aligned} &\|\mathsf{A}_{00}\| = 1.89 \times 10^4, \quad \|\mathsf{A}_{01}\| = 5.67 \times 10^2, \quad \|\mathsf{A}_{11}\| = 2.35 \times 10^2, \\ &\|\mathsf{A}_{12}\| = 4.04, \quad \|\mathsf{A}_{22}\| = 7.12 \times 10^{-1}, \end{aligned} \tag{69}$$

spanning four and a half decades. The spread is intrinsic to the problem: it is the $\lambda^2 c_{33}/c_{44} = 0.32$ of the gradient term against the $O(10^2)$ of the elastic term, multiplied by the $2j(j+1)(2j+1)$ growth of the stiffness matrix (86) with the mode number. Hence each block is equilibrated row by row before the eigenvalue problem is formed, and the conditioning quoted below is that of the equilibrated problem.

3.2 Modes, the free-edge system and the conditions on a reported share

Two independent solution routes follow from (66).

The *temporal* route fixes a real k_x and solves the generalized eigenvalue problem in ω^2 obtained from (66) with the potential and the electrochemical potential eliminated. It produces the dispersion branches $\omega(k_x)$, the group velocity $v_g = c_s\,\partial\omega/\partial k_x$ by central differences along a branch-tracked sequence, and the temporal attenuation $\gamma = -2\operatorname{Im}\omega$. Branch tracking is done by a modal-assurance criterion on the mass-orthogonal displacements, so a curve can be followed through a crossing without jumping to a neighboring branch.

The *spatial* route fixes a real frequency and solves the quartic problem (66) directly for k_x. It is the route that is physically relevant at an edge, because reflection is a process at fixed frequency, and it is the only route that gives the spatial attenuation $\alpha = 2|\operatorname{Im} k_x|$ used in figs. 1 and 6. The attenuation is taken from the complex root; it is not inferred from the imaginary part of $\sqrt{K^2 + k_y^2}$ at real K, which vanishes by construction.

The two routes are compared with each other in fig. 9(d) and with strong-form integrations of the reduced system. Both comparisons establish the consistency of the implementation, which is what they are used for; the independent checks on the physics are the exact limits and the finite-element plate.

At fixed ω the spatial problem returns $2(n_{\mathrm{w}} + n_{\mathrm{u}})$ finite eigenvalues $k_x^{(j)}$ and their states $\boldsymbol{y}^{(j)}$ (see (68)); the infinite ones are not states of the problem and hold no boundary data. Each is classified as outgoing or incoming by the sign of its decay and of its axial power,

$$\text{outgoing} \iff \operatorname{Im} k_x^{(j)} < -\tau \quad \text{or} \quad \left|\operatorname{Im} k_x^{(j)}\right| \le \tau \text{ and } \mathcal{P}_x^{(j)} < 0, \tag{70}$$

where $\tau = 2 \times 10^{-8}\max(1, |k_x|)$ and $\mathcal{P}_x$ is the thickness-integrated power flux (44). A purely real root is outgoing when it carries energy away from the edge, and an evanescent root is outgoing when it decays away

from the edge. The number of outgoing roots must equal M, which is a structural property of the eigenvalue problem and not a tolerance.

The solution is written as the incident mode plus a combination of the outgoing modes,

$$\boldsymbol{y}(0) = \boldsymbol{y}_{\mathrm{inc}} + \sum_{j} a_j \, \boldsymbol{y}^{(j)}, \tag{71}$$

and the coefficients a_j follow from the homogeneous edge conditions (40) written as $\mathsf{B}\boldsymbol{a} = -\boldsymbol{b}_{\mathrm{inc}}$, with $\mathsf{B} \in \mathbb{C}^{m \times M}$. The system is square by construction, $m = M = n_{\mathrm{w}} + n_{\mathrm{u}}$ (see (108)), which at $n = 22$ is 182 rows against 182 columns; it is row- and column-scaled and solved through a singular-value decomposition, with the rank of B required to equal its column count at a cut-off of 10^{-12} of the largest singular value. A deficient system is reported as such and is not regularized. Because the system is square, a small residual is a statement about the conditioning of the edge operator and not about the physical admissibility of the edge conditions; the latter is argued from (40) independently. The condition number at the operating point is 1.4×10^{2}, and the scaled residual of (71) is below 10^{-12} for all rows used in this article.

The backward channel is the outgoing mode whose real wavenumber is closest to the target k_{Bx}, and its share of the incident power is

$$R_B = \frac{-P_B \, e^{2 \operatorname{Im} k_{Bx} L}}{P_{\mathrm{inc}} \, e^{2 \operatorname{Im} k_{ix} L}} = \frac{-P_B}{P_{\mathrm{inc}}} \, e^{2(\operatorname{Im} k_{Bx} - \operatorname{Im} k_{ix}) L}, \tag{72}$$

evaluated at the reference plane $x = -L$, $L = 10\,d = 2\,\mu\mathrm{m}$. The two exponentials are retained explicitly so that the ratio is measured at the same plane for both modes. Equation (72) defines a *modal share* of the outgoing power, one member of the partition of the incident power; the total propagating share, which is the quantity closest to a reflectance, is reported separately.

Evaluating (72) at the operating point takes four stored numbers and three steps, and the steps are the ones a reader can repeat by hand. The first is the power of the unit-amplitude backward mode at the edge, which the normalization makes independent of the degree:

$$\mathcal{P}_x = -0.0154248, \qquad |a_B| = 1.1184598, \qquad P_B^{\mathrm{edge}} = |a_B|^2 \mathcal{P}_x = -0.0192957, \tag{73}$$

the three numbers being read from the same $n = 22$ row. They are separately degree-dependent ($|\mathcal{P}_x|$ falls by 14 percent and $|a_B|^2$ rises by 16 percent between $n = 18$ and $n = 22$) and their product is not: 0.019296 at $n = 18$, 22, 26 and 30 alike, to six digits (see (110)). Quoting $\mathcal{P}_x$ or $|a_B|$ alone measures the normalization of the eigenvector, not the port. The second is the propagation to the reference plane, with the attenuation taken from the complex root,

$$\operatorname{Im} k_{Bx} = -5.2306 \times 10^{-6}, \quad \operatorname{Im} k_{ix} = +5.4027 \times 10^{-6} \ (\text{per unit } d), \quad L = 10\,d, \tag{74}$$

$$\begin{aligned} P_B(-L) &= -0.0192957 \, e^{2(-5.2306 \times 10^{-6})(10)} = -0.0192937, \\ P_{\mathrm{inc}}(-L) &= e^{2(5.4027 \times 10^{-6})(10)} = 1.0001081, \end{aligned} \tag{75}$$

where the incident mode is normalized to unit power at the edge. The third is the ratio,

$$R_B = \frac{-P_B(-L)}{P_{\mathrm{inc}}(-L)} = \frac{0.0192937}{1.0001081} = 0.0192916, \tag{76}$$

that is 1.93 %. The two exponentials move the fourth digit in opposite directions: the backward mode decays and the incident mode grows as $x \to -L$, so the ratio changes by 2.1×10^{-4} relative to the unnormalized value $|a_B|^2 |\mathcal{P}_x| = 0.0192957$, and it is that difference which (72) exists to account for. The same evaluation at the branch maximum gives 0.9429 (94.29 %), and the two values differ by the factor of forty-nine that section 4.3 attributes to the proximity of the branch to the coincidence condition.

A computed share is reported when it satisfies three conditions, none of which is a plotting threshold.

Conservation. The backward mode is one of the outgoing modes, so its self-power cannot exceed the power available at the plane,

$$0 \le R_B \le 1 + \frac{|P_{\mathrm{cross}}|}{P_{\mathrm{inc}}}. \tag{77}$$

Across the reported solutions the interference term is between 10^{-6} and 10^{-2} of the incident power, so (77) is applied with a bound of 1.01. A row that violates it would assert that a single outgoing mode carries more power than the incident wave plus the interference, which no solution of the boundary-value problem can do; such a row indicates that the identified mode is not the continuation of the backward branch.

Convergence. The reported quantity must be stable under refinement of the Galerkin degree. The peak study shows that both the operating-point value and the branch maximum change by less than 10^{-5} between degree 18 and degree 30.

Resolution of the computed projection. R_B is a ratio of x fluxes. When the energy angle of a mode approaches $\pm 90^\circ$ its x flux vanishes and the ratio loses meaning even though the mode itself is perfectly well resolved. The flux fraction $|\cos\theta_E| = |P_x|/\sqrt{P_x^2 + P_y^2}$ is stored with each row, and the two values quoted in this article have $|\cos\theta_E| = 0.88$ and 0.97.

3.3 Consistency and independent checks

The implementation is checked in six independent ways, each of which compares a computed quantity with a closed-form or independently discretized one.

1. *Exact classical limit.* With $\ell = f = H = 0$ the plate supports exact shear-horizontal modes $\Omega^2 = (c_{66}/c_{44})K^2 + (j\pi)^2$ in scaled units; the spectral solution reproduces the first three of them to 10^{-9}.

2. *Exact strain-gradient limit.* With $\ell \neq 0$ the fundamental shear-horizontal branch has the closed form $\Omega^2 = (c_{66}/c_{44})K^2(1 + \lambda^2 K^2)$, reproduced to 10^{-10}.

3. *Independent strong-form propagator.* An eight-state classical sagittal system and a twelve-state gradient system are integrated directly as ODEs, with no spectral matrices. They reproduce the spectral frequencies to 10^{-10} for both the grounded and the open-circuit problem, and with nonzero f and H.

4. *Independent discretization.* A C^1 finite-element plate formulation in the thickness direction (it keeps the modal x-dependence, so it tests the thickness discretization and not the two-dimensional corner) converges monotonically to the spectral edge result at an observed order between 3.9 and 4.4, with an error below 3×10^{-5} on the finest mesh. This is the only check in the list that tests the edge problem; the dispersion checks do not.

5. *Two-dimensional finite-element solution.* The same variational problem is solved directly on the (x, z) cross-section, without modal x-dependence, at the operating point. The thickness basis is the spectral plate or the C^1 finite-element plate; in x a degree-4 B-spline basis is graded geometrically towards the edge, with a first cell of $0.02\,d$ in the reference case, and a mass-proportional absorbing layer of length $170\,d$ terminates the strip, because a conventional perfectly matched layer fails for backward waves. The incident mode enters as a scattered-field load, and the field on $-20d \leq x \leq -4d$ is fitted on the outgoing modes of section 3.2. The fitted backward share R_B agrees with the modal value 0.019292 to between -0.14 and $+0.42$ % over the variations in table 2. The test applies at the operating point only: at the fold the incident and backward modes coincide, so the modal fit that this comparison relies on is not defined there.

6. *Residuals of the strong form.* For each mode used, the momentum, Gauss, carrier-continuity, traction, double-traction and blocking residuals are below 10^{-8} in the normalized measure reported in fig. 9(c), and the scaled edge residual is below 10^{-12}.

7. *Natural boundary data: derived versus discrete.* The traction, double traction and corner line force of (41)–(42) are evaluated from the physical fields and compared, mode by mode, with the canonical flux rows that the solver actually imposes. The comparison is stated in (43); it closes to 1.4×10^{-13} for the incident guided mode at all degrees from 10 to 28 and for each quadrature rule tested, and it is the check that fixes the index placement and the sign of the corner term, so neither rests on the derivation alone. What the same comparison shows about the pointwise natural conditions (which a Galerkin statement imposes only weakly) is reported in section 5.5: the double traction is annihilated pointwise to 10^{-12}, whereas the traction leaves an interior residual of 9.4×10^{-4} of the incident scale at the corrected maximum (larger, 3.6×10^{-2}, at the operating point) that does not decrease further with degree, and the corner line force stands at 1.7×10^{-3} there and decays only algebraically. Those residuals are properties of the weak solution and not of the implementation, and they are reported with the other checks.

The reciprocity of the operator at $+k_y$ and $-k_y$ holds to 10^{-13}, which verifies the symmetry of the discretized bilinear form, including the added coupling. The seven comparisons above are the independent evidence for the implementation; the practical resolution at which they are carried out, the convergence of the reported quantities with degree and quadrature, and the conservation residual are stated in appendix B, and the full computational record is deposited with the code and data (see the data availability statement).

Table 2: Two-dimensional finite-element check at the operating point. Modal value $R_B = 0.019292$ (spectral plate; 0.019396 and 0.019298 for the C^1 plate with 25 and 49 points). The reference case has strip length $200\,d$, absorbing layer $170\,d$ with strength 0.1, 500 uniform cells, first graded cell $0.02\,d$ and B-spline degree 4.

Variation of the reference case	R_B^{FE}	Difference (%)
Reference	0.019324	+0.17
Strip $300\,d$, layer $260\,d$	0.019346	+0.28
Layer strength 0.05	0.019373	+0.42
800 uniform cells	0.019311	+0.10
B-spline degree 5	0.019265	−0.14
First cell $0.005\,d$	0.019320	+0.15
First cell $0.00125\,d$	0.019313	+0.11
Thickness degree 14, 18	0.019324	+0.17
C^1 plate (25 pts), first cell $0.00125\,d$	0.019418	+0.11
C^1 plate (49 pts), first cell $0.00125\,d$	0.019320	+0.11

4 Numerical results

The operating point used throughout is $k_x d = 0.7362$, $k_y d = 0.1298$, $\omega = 7.6334\,c_s/d$, i.e. $f = 16.68\,\mathrm{GHz}$ for $d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$, with the coupling set to zero unless a sweep says otherwise, and with grounded faces. The reference plane for each reported share is $L = 10\,d = 2\,\mu\mathrm{m}$ from the edge. Unless stated otherwise the Galerkin degree is $n = 22$.

4.1 Dispersion, wave speeds and the operating point

Figure 1 characterizes the guided branch that is later scattered at the edge. Panel (a) plots the frequency against $k_x d$ for the five coupling levels. The five curves superimpose to within the width of the line over the entire range $0.15 \le k_x d \le 1.05$, and the inset resolves their difference: the coupling lowers the frequency by at most 184 kHz, at $k_x d = 1.05$, where the frequency is 16.87 GHz, that is by 1.1×10^{-5} in relative terms; at the negative coupling the lowering remains below 92 kHz over the same range. This is the first indication, confirmed in section 4.6, that the added coupling is a perturbation of the dispersion and a modifier of the edge partition, and does not drive the branch.

Panel (b) shows three different velocities:

$$v_p = \frac{\omega}{|\boldsymbol{k}|} = \frac{\omega}{\sqrt{k_x^2 + k_y^2}}, \qquad \text{(phase speed, a magnitude)} \tag{78}$$

$$v_g = c_s \frac{\partial \omega}{\partial k_x}, \qquad \text{(group velocity, signed)} \tag{79}$$

$$v_E = \frac{\mathcal{P}_x}{E}, \qquad \text{(energy velocity, signed)} \tag{80}$$

with $\mathcal{P}_x$ from (44) and E the stored energy per unit length. The phase speed (78) is a positive magnitude and cannot change sign; it is plotted on the right-hand axis of panel (b) and it decreases monotonically from 105.8 km/s near the cutoff at $k_x d = 0.15$ to 20.0 km/s at $k_x d = 1.05$. The group and energy velocities are signed and are plotted on the left-hand axis: they run from −189 and −189 to +1136 and +1136 m/s, change sign just below $k_x d = 0.53$, and agree with each other to within 0.03 % at every sample; the group velocity is a symmetric difference of half-width 0.0025 in $k_x d$. The sign change of v_g and v_E marks the backward part of the branch. A backward branch exists whether or not an edge is present, and what the edge adds is the conversion into it: the branch provides a mode whose energy travels opposite to the phase, and that is the mode the edge subsequently selects.

Panels (c) and (d) report the linewidth and the attenuation. The linewidth ranges from 1.4 kHz to 0.27 MHz and grows monotonically with $k_x d$; it is smallest at $H = 0$ and rises with $|H|$, further for positive than for negative coupling. The attenuation $\alpha = 2|\operatorname{Im} k_x|$, obtained from the complex spatial root at real frequency and quoted in decibels of power as $4.343\,\alpha$, ranges from 0.11 dB/mm to 228 dB/mm and is positive everywhere on the branch. It is largest on the slow part of the branch, but the plotted grid of $\Delta k_x d = 0.03$ resolves that maximum only at its own sample, $k_x d = 0.54$: the fold has 43.5 dB/mm to 44.5 dB/mm at $H = 0$ (table 4), which a raster of that spacing cannot show.

Before the numbers are read, the part of (6) exercised by the calculations should be stated.

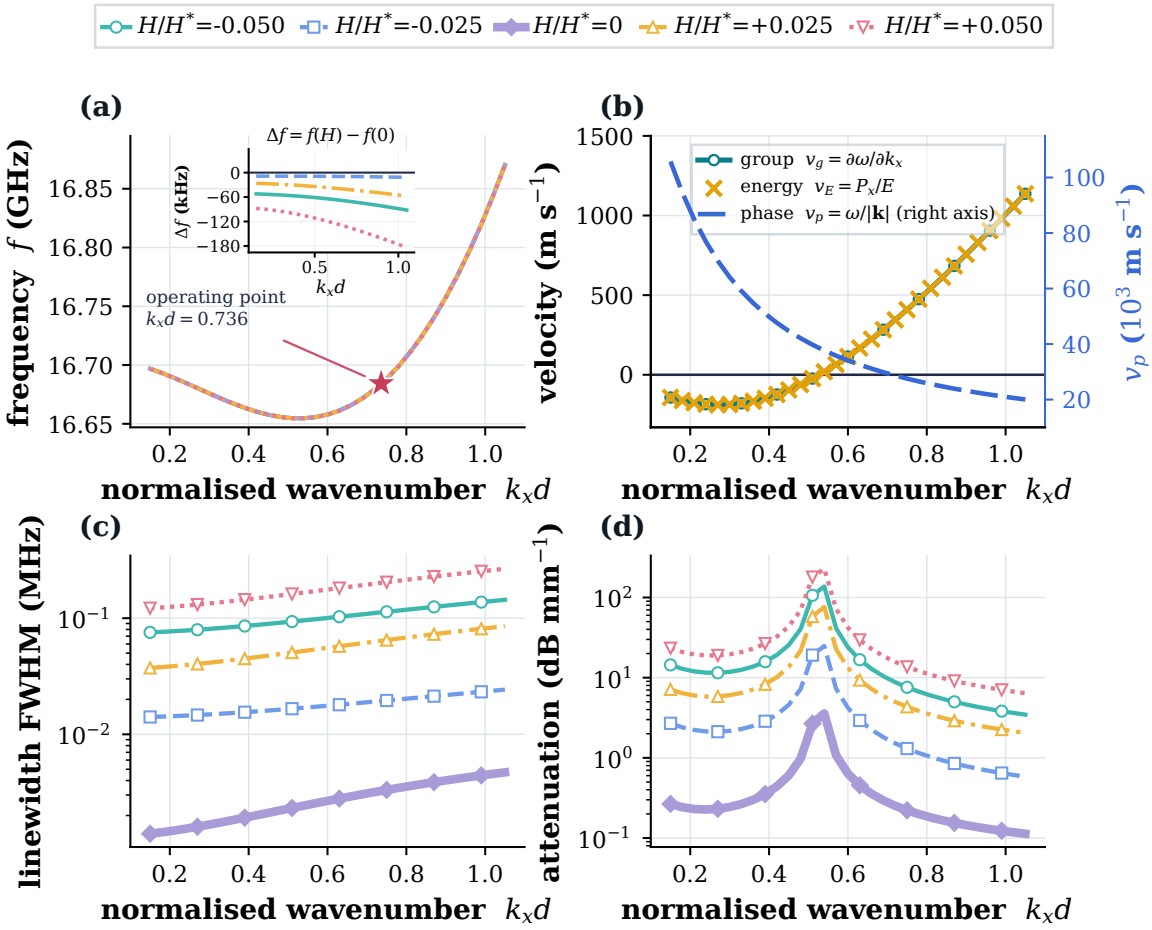


Figure 1: Guided branch at $k_y d = 0.1298$, $d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$, $\ell = 50\,\mathrm{nm}$. (a) Frequency against $k_x d$, with the inset showing $\Delta f = f(H) - f(0)$; the operating point $k_x d = 0.736$ is marked. (b) Group, energy and phase speeds at $H = 0$. (c) Linewidth and (d) attenuation, $4.343 \times 2|\,\mathrm{Im}\,k_x|$ in dB mm^{-1}, for five coupling levels.

Four sectors are active in each solve: the elastic, the strain-gradient, the piezoelectric and the carrier sector. The flexoelectric sector is active but subdominant. A single flexoelectric constant $f \equiv f_{3zz} = 1\,\mathrm{nC/m}$ is retained. It lies at the low end of the range reported for ZnO [23, 56] and is an assumed value, taken independently of the crystal used for the elastic constants; it gives the dimensionless coupling $f = 2.56 \times 10^{-3}$ of table 1. The added carrier–strain-gradient coupling is swept over $|H| \le 2.0 \times 10^{-23}\,\mathrm{J\,m} = 0.022\,H_{\mathrm{bound}}$, i.e. over the range allowed by (60).

The flexoelectric term was tested directly, by repeating the two solved configurations with f set to zero and to ten times the retained value. At the operating point the backward channel is 0.0192916 with the retained f and 0.0192938 with $f = 0$, a change of $-0.012\,\%$; at $k_x d = 0.55$ it is 0.551910 and 0.551976, a change of $-0.012\,\%$. At ten times the retained value the changes are $-1.16\,\%$ and $-1.18\,\%$, so the dependence is smooth and quadratic in the coupling (a factor of 97 for a factor of ten), with no threshold.

Taken together, these numbers place the reported shares within one part in ten thousand of the shares of the *strain-gradient piezoelectric-semiconductor* specialization with the added carrier coupling. The flexoelectric term is present and contributes with the correct sign and magnitude, and it does not drive the effect. What the numbers support is a slow-mode edge effect of the strain-gradient plate, modulated by the carrier coupling, inside a flexoelectric-semiconductor formulation; they do not support the attribution of the negative reflection to the flexoelectric mechanism itself.

4.2 Dependence on carrier density, thickness and frequency

Figure 2 sweeps the two material families. Increasing the carrier density from 1 to $3 \times 10^{18}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$ raises the linewidth (a) and the attenuation (b) by a factor of three each (the conduction loss is linear in the density over this range) and lowers the frequency only slightly. Panel (c) is the most informative: the backward channel at the reference plane is plotted against $k_x d$ for the five densities, and the five curves collapse onto one. The largest sampled value, $R_B \approx 0.552$ (0.5515 to 0.5523), is at $k_x d = 0.55$ for all densities; this raster of $\Delta k_x d = 0.05$ does not resolve the fold at $k_x d = 0.527$, whose maximum is given in section 4.3. The relative spread between the five curves is below 0.2 % over the full range. On this raster, and over this factor-of-three range, the carrier density thus sets the loss but not the partition of the scattered power (see section 4.8 for a wider range).

The mobility behaves in the same way (panel d): over the factor-of-three range 0.00875 to $0.02625\,\mathrm{m}^2/(\mathrm{V\,s})$ the linewidth changes by the same factor of three, while the backward share is unchanged to the same 0.2 percent. The two sweeps are in fact identical row by row, because the density and the mobility enter the conduction term only through their product. Both results are consistent with $Q = d/L_D = 0.075 < 1$: the plate is thinner than the Debye length, the carrier perturbation is not confined to a surface layer, and the density enters the problem mainly through the conduction loss.

Every row of this sweep satisfies the conservation bound (77); the curve in panel (c) extends to $k_x d = 0.9$, falling below 10^{-7} beyond $k_x d = 0.8$ and reaching between 3×10^{-12} and 1×10^{-11} at the last sample. This is the backward port ceasing to carry energy, not a numerical failure. Rows at that end have $|\cos\theta_E| \to 0$, and the flux fraction is stored with each row so that the loss of resolution is visible.

Figure 3 separates the two geometric families, which scale differently and must not be plotted on a common axis. Plate thickness is the dominant scale: across the family between 120 nm and 320 nm the branch lies between 10.5 GHz and 30.4 GHz, and the relative change is of order unity at all wavenumbers (panels a and c). The gradient length shifts the same branch by a smaller amount than the thickness (panels b and d): relative to $\ell = 50\,\mathrm{nm}$, a change to $\ell = 90\,\mathrm{nm}$ shifts the frequency by 2.0 % at $k_x d = 0.145$ and by 10.2 % at $k_x d = 1.00$, while $\ell = 35\,\mathrm{nm}$ shifts it by $-1.9\,\%$ and $-4.9\,\%$ at the same two points. The sign of the effect changes with ℓ across the reference value, so the panel is plotted as a relative change and not as an absolute frequency.

The distinction matters for the interpretation of the rest of the paper. A thickness change rescales the whole problem and is not a coupling effect; a gradient-length change alters the relative weight of the hyperelastic and flexoelectric terms at fixed geometry and so is the parameter that belongs with H in a discussion of the added physics.

Figure 4 sweeps the drive along the solved guided branch, not at a fixed frequency. This matters away from the operating point, where a fixed-frequency solve does not return the physical continuation of the branch and the energy angle collapses towards $-90°$; following the branch gives, for each row, a resolved triple of frequency, wavenumber and share. Two rasters are used: a coarse one over the full window and, at $H = 0$ only, a fine one of spacing $\Delta k_x d = 5 \times 10^{-4}$ across $0.520 \le k_x d \le 0.535$, because the top of the response is three orders of magnitude narrower than any raster that can be drawn on a single axis. The number of rows is a property of the grid and is recorded with the data.

The share along the branch is largest on its slow part. It is 0.0341 at $k_x d = 0.30$ ($f = 16.676\,\mathrm{GHz}$), rises to 0.9429 at $k_x d = 0.52719$ ($f = 16.6547\,\mathrm{GHz}$), and falls to 0.0142 at $k_x d = 0.75$ ($f = 16.688\,\mathrm{GHz}$) (panel

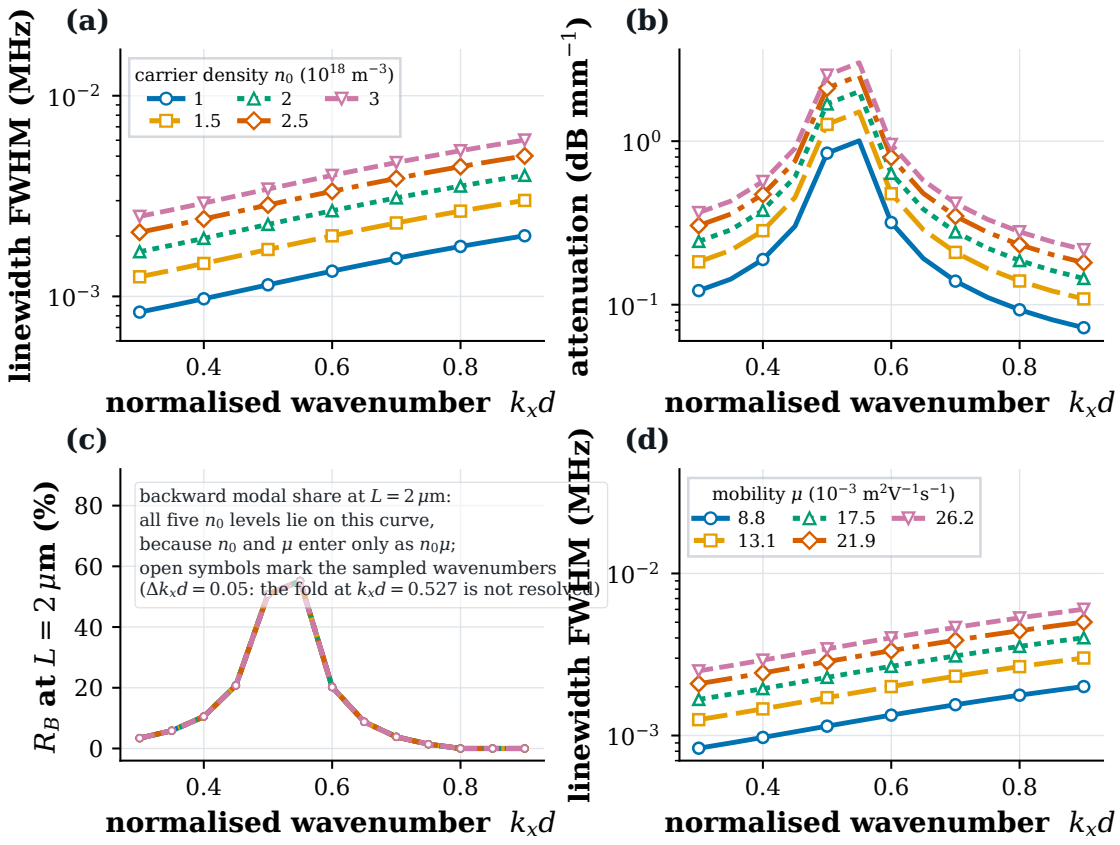


Figure 2: Carrier density and mobility at $H = 0$, $k_yd = 0.1298$, sampled every $\Delta k_xd = 0.05$. (a) Linewidth and (b) attenuation ($4.343 \times 2|\operatorname{Im} k_x|$) for five n_0; (c) backward share at $L = 2\,\mu$m; (d) linewidth for five mobilities.

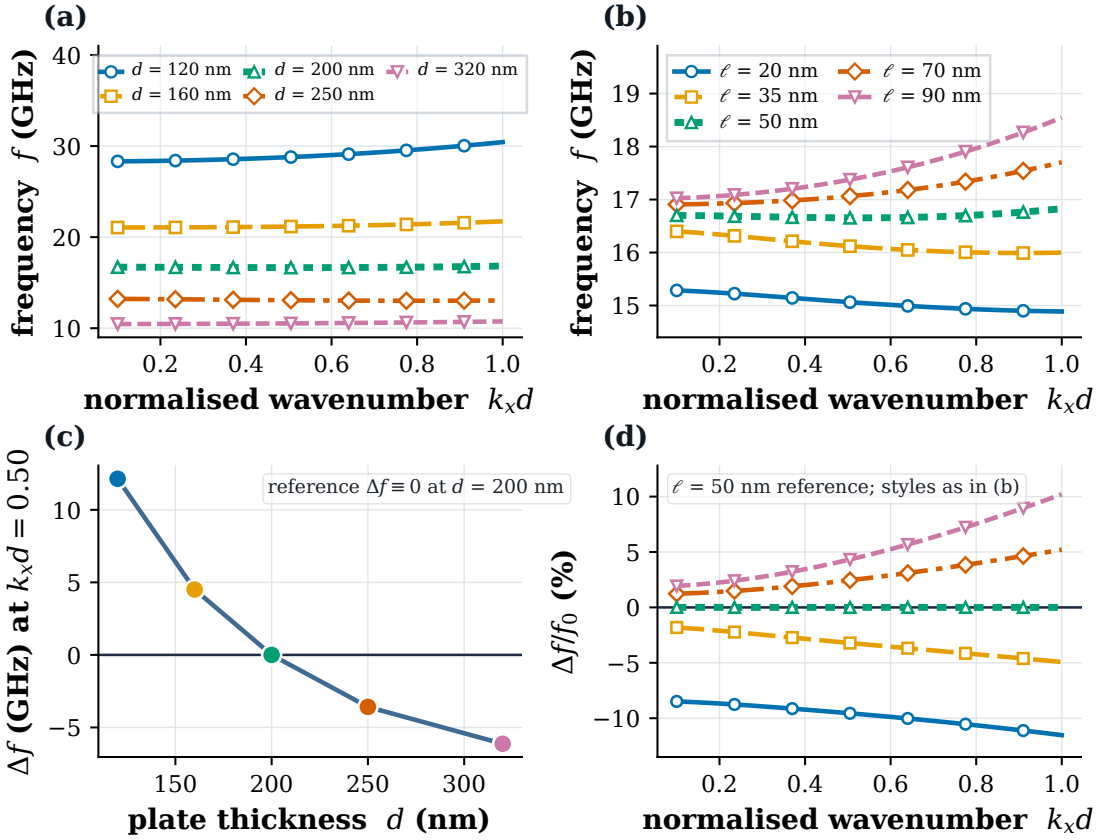


Figure 3: Thickness and gradient length at $H = 0$, $k_y d = 0.1298$. (a) Dispersion for five thicknesses ($\ell = 50\,\mathrm{nm}$); (b) dispersion for five gradient lengths ($d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$), each the operating-point branch followed from $\ell = 50\,\mathrm{nm}$; (c) Δf at $k_x d = 0.50$ against thickness; (d) relative frequency change for five gradient lengths.

a). The response has a single peak over the entire window: the coarse raster finds no second local extremum, and the top of the peak is located by a refined search. Panel (b) shows the signed energy angle changing by 17° across the window and passing through its own extremum next to the maximum of R_B, so the two are not independent readings. Panel (c) plots the same data against the ratio k_{Bx}/k_{ix}: all five coupling levels collapse onto one master curve, and the conversion is largest where the backward wavenumber approaches the incident one, reaching $k_{Bx}/k_{ix} = 0.9960$ at the maximum. The backward port is a propagating mode on the backward-slope part of the same branch, not an evanescent artifact, and the projection onto it becomes decisive where the two wavenumbers approach each other. Panel (d) shows why they do: the branch passes through a zero-group-velocity point at $k_x d \approx 0.527$, where $|v_g|$ falls below 1 m/s against −187 and +409 m/s at the two ends of the window, and the incident and backward wavenumbers close on one another there and open again beyond it.

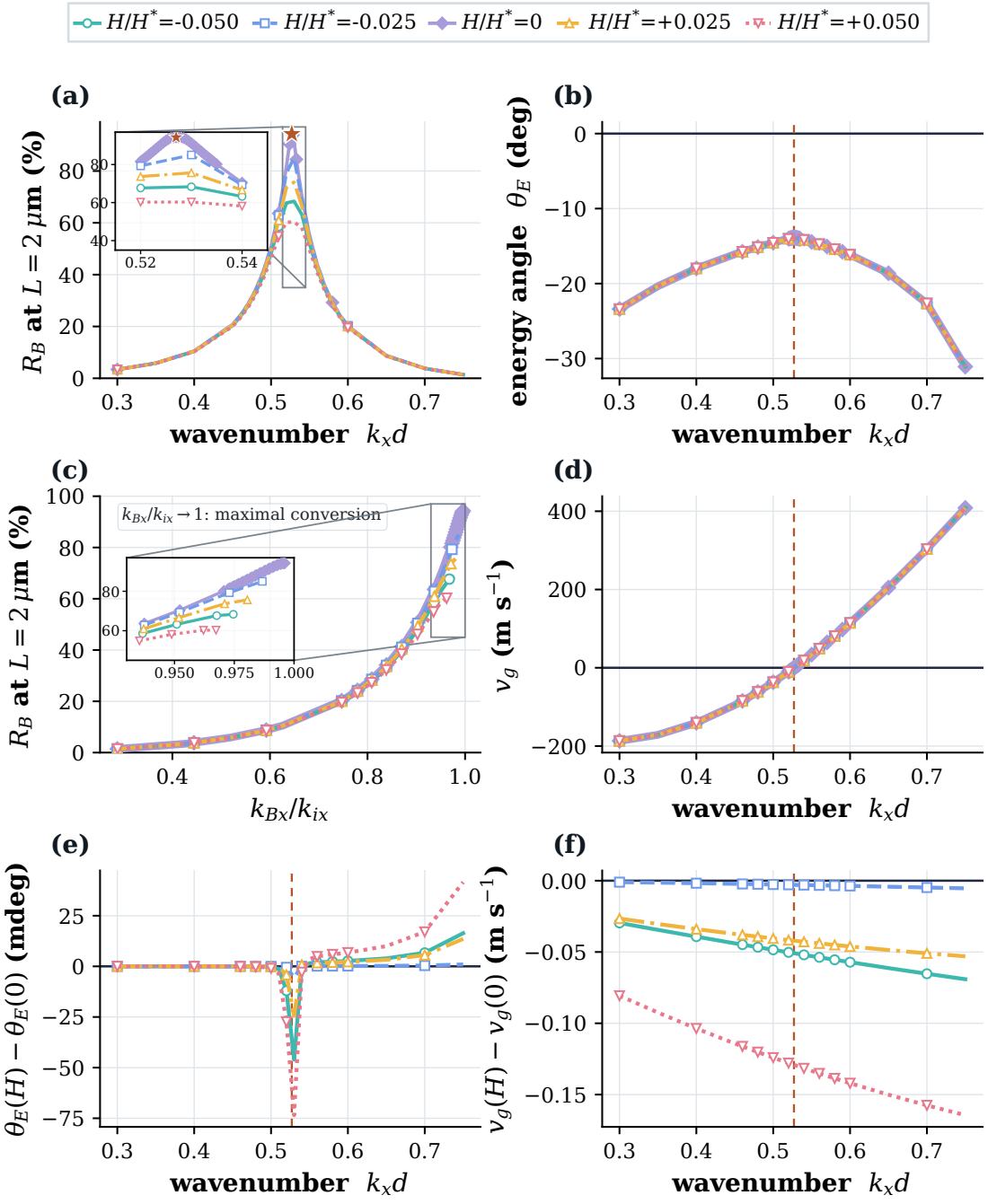


Figure 4: Backward conversion along the branch at $k_y d = 0.1298$, $L = 2\,\mu$m, with the frequency following the branch. (a) R_B against $k_x d$, maximum marked by a star. (b) Energy angle. (c) R_B against k_{Bx}/k_{ix}. (d) Group velocity. Insets magnify the region near the maximum; (e), (f) show the departure of (b) and (d) from $H = 0$.

In fig. 4 the five coupling levels separate only near the maximum (insets of panels a and c); the curves of

Table 3: Refinement with the Galerkin degree n at $H = 0$; the last column is the largest relative change of R_B with respect to $n = 30$.

Case	$k_x d$	R_B at $n = 30$	θ_E at $n = 30$ (deg)	$\max \lvert\Delta R_B\rvert / R_B$
Operating point	0.7362	0.019 292	−27.8997	2.5×10^{-5}
Maximum	0.52719	0.942 872	−13.8493	1.1×10^{-6}
Earlier sample	0.5250	0.925 604	−13.8888	1.3×10^{-6}
$k_x d = 0.55$	0.5500	0.551 909	−14.4487	7.7×10^{-6}

panels (b) and (d) coincide on the scale of the full response. Panels (e) and (f) show that the energy angle changes by at most 7×10^{-2} degree, at the maximum, and the group velocity by less than 0.2 m/s. Every plotted row satisfies the conservation bound (77).

4.3 The branch maximum and its convergence

The maximum of fig. 4 falls between two samples of the coarse raster, so it is solved again at six Galerkin degrees with the same physics, and each value is checked against the quadrature rule. Table 3 reports the outcome.

Three properties of the sequence should be noted. First, the values are converged in the Galerkin degree: between degrees 14 and 34 the relative change of the maximum remains below 10^{-5} at both the located argmax and the reported wavenumber, the operating point changes by 2.5×10^{-5}, and the successive changes decrease monotonically and are still decreasing at the highest degree. The two spreads are differences of nearly equal numbers, so they are reported as bounds and not as values. Quadrature is not a limitation either: with the degree fixed at 22 and the rule taken from 64 to 256 nodes the maximum changes by less than 10^{-8}. Second, the values are well conditioned: the singular-value condition number of the edge system is at most 1.9×10^2 and the scaled edge residual is below 3×10^{-15} in all cases. Third, the values are resolved projections: the energy angles are $-13.9°$ and $-27.9°$, so the measured x flux is 97.1 % and 88.4 % of the total modal flux respectively. Neither value is an artifact of a near-grazing mode.

The precision of the printed digits is set by the refinement spreads, not by the location of the top. At a fixed configuration the share is reproducible to about 10^{-6} relative: it changes by 1.1×10^{-6} across degrees 14 to 34 and by 1.6×10^{-7} between degrees 22 and 34, the quadrature rule (64 to 256 nodes) changes it by 1.0×10^{-9}, and the three tracking paths that reach the maximum from below, from above and in a single step agree to 2.3×10^{-7}. The located argmax and the reported sample are the same point, $k_x d = 0.52719$, so no offset between them enters the printed digits. In addition, the incident wavenumber returned by the spatial problem is $k_{ix} d = 0.52821$, not the branch parameter $k_x d = 0.52719$: on a flat branch the two differ by 0.19 % at the maximum. Both are tabulated and no conclusion depends on the difference.

The quantity maximized is the one defined by (72): the modal self-power of the identified backward outgoing mode at the reference plane, divided by the incident power at the same plane with the incident mode normalized to unity. The other outgoing modes, the interference term and the dissipation are quoted separately and are never folded into it; the edge-plane value is reported beside the reference-plane value and never substituted for it.

The location is found in three stages. A coarse raster of $\Delta k_x d = 0.002$ over $0.465 \le k_x d \le 0.625$ (the whole window in which a backward port exists at this k_y) contains a single peak and no second local extremum, with its largest sample at $k_x d = 0.527$. A plateau raster of $\Delta k_x d = 10^{-4}$ over $0.5265 \le k_x d \le 0.5285$, and a refined raster of $\Delta k_x d = 10^{-5}$ around it, place the maximum at $k_x d = 0.52719$ with $R_B = 0.9428718$; the reported value is that of the resolved maximum of the sampled raster, and the value at the center of the flat top, $k_x d = 0.52752$, is $R_B = 0.9428521$, 2.0×10^{-5} lower, a difference between two abscissae and not between two runs. Every sampled wavenumber in $0.5267 \le k_x d \le 0.5276$ lies within 0.01 percentage point of the maximum and all sampled wavenumbers in $0.5265 \le k_x d \le 0.5280$ within 0.1 percentage point, so the response has a flat top and not a sharp peak: the reported location is the center of that top, determined to within its half-width of ± 0.0005, not a five-digit abscissa.

Two independent restarts, from the brackets $[0.520, 0.532]$ and $[0.524, 0.536]$ on a raster of 10^{-3}, return the same interval and the same sample value, 3.2×10^{-6} below the refined maximum: the restarts test the bracketing, while the refinement is the task of the two finer rasters above. The result is a *local maximum within the declared window*. It is not a global maximum over all k_y, all thicknesses or all material sets, none of which is searched here. The search record also stores whether the refined raster is flat and interior; a raster that is not flat, or that meets the boundary of the interval, is reported as the largest sample and is not called a maximum.

4.4 The maximum read as a modal share and the energy budget of the edge

Three properties of the solution decide whether such a number can be read at face value.

A small denominator. The incident flux at the maximum is small, a factor 131 below its value at the operating point, so the fraction could in principle be a ratio of two nearly vanishing quantities. It is not: the value is reproduced to better than 10^{-5} across six Galerkin degrees, to better than 10^{-8} across four quadrature rules, and to 2.3×10^{-7} along three different tracking paths that reach the same wavenumber from below, from above and in a single step. A ratio of two independently vanishing numbers would scatter under all three.

Reference plane and port. The reference plane is moved from 0 to 20 thicknesses and the partition is rescaled by $\exp[2(|\operatorname{Im} k_{ix}| + |\operatorname{Im} k_{Bx}|)(L - L_{\mathrm{ref}})/d]$, which is the net attenuation of the two partner modes travelling in opposite directions. The rescaled values agree to 2×10^{-16}, so the number is a property of the edge and both attenuations are resolved and not assumed. The transform is implemented once and imported everywhere it is used, and the stored edge-plane fractions of the search, of the matched controls and of the coupling dataset are reproduced by a fresh evaluation to 10^{-10} relative or better; the plane at which a share is quoted is hence a reporting choice and not a second definition. The backward port is also unique: the second outgoing candidate lies $2.0|k_x|$ away, the condition number of the normalized edge matrix is 1.4×10^2, and the relative error bound of the projection is cond $\times\, \epsilon = 4 \times 10^{-14}$.

Nearly parallel modes. The incident and backward eigenvectors are nearly parallel, with overlap 0.999995, and their wavenumbers are separated by 1.45 times the modal decay rate: close, but resolved. The partition rebuilt from the stored amplitudes and modal powers alone reproduces the computed value to machine precision, which is the direct statement that no eigenvector phase or scale enters the result. What the near-coincidence does change is interpretation, not accuracy: because the incident flux falls towards the fold, the fraction is anti-correlated with it across the window, so a maximal share goes together with a minimal transported power.

The maximum is a modal share and not a reflectance. At $k_x d = 0.52719$ the total outgoing propagating power is 1.00050 of the incident power and the interference correction at the reference plane is $+5.2 \times 10^{-4}$, so the backward mode carries 94.29 % of the incident power and 94.24 % of the outgoing propagating power. At this fold the interference term is sensitive at the level of 10^{-3} to the wavenumber at which the frequency is fixed (it is -8.0×10^{-4} at the neighboring sample $k_x d = 0.5275$, which has the same frequency to 10^{-8}), whereas the modal share changes by 2×10^{-5} relative. The modal share is 94.29 %; the energy statement is that the propagating outgoing modes carry the incident power to within 0.1 %. The two are different readings of the same solution.

The maximum must also be read with its own amplitude in mind. It lies on a zero-group-velocity fold, and a mode with vanishing group velocity carries vanishing flux: the incident modal power per unit normalization falls from 5.08×10^{-3} at the operating point to 3.87×10^{-5} at the maximum, a factor 131, while $|\operatorname{Im} k_{ix}|d$ rises to 1.0×10^{-3}. The fraction is the ratio of two small but resolved fluxes (well defined, unchanged by the incident normalization, and stable to 1×10^{-5} under degree and quadrature refinement), but it is not a statement that a large amount of energy is turned around. Both readings are needed: the partition is maximal at the fold and the transported power is minimal there.

The three configurations are compared term by term in table 4. Every entry is evaluated at degree 30, except the attenuations, which are $2|\operatorname{Im} k_x|/d$ formed from the same spatial roots and quoted in decibels of power (4.343×).

Figure 5 closes the energy identity (45) at the reference plane. At $H = 0$ the incident power normalized to unity is partitioned as follows: the identified backward channel carries 1.9292×10^{-2}, the remaining propagating outgoing modes carry 0.980505, dissipation removes 1.989×10^{-4}, and the interference term is -4.6×10^{-6}. The first two sum to 0.999796, the total outgoing propagating power; adding the dissipation leaves 5×10^{-6} of the incident power, which is the magnitude of the interference term to the six digits quoted. The interference term is defined as the remainder of the identity, so the sum closes by construction; the independent check is the balance of the flux at the reference plane against the edge flux and the conduction loss, which closes to better than 10^{-11} relative at each Galerkin degree from 14 to 34, five orders of magnitude below the 10^{-6} threshold plotted in panel (c). At the maximum the backward channel carries 0.942872 and the remaining propagating modes 5.76×10^{-2}, which together account for 1.00050 of the incident power; dissipation removes 2.78×10^{-5} and the interference term is $+5.2 \times 10^{-4}$. The same power balance closes there to 6×10^{-14}.

The evanescent spectrum does not belong to the transported budget. At the reference plane the entire evanescent content has decayed by a factor $\exp(-2|\operatorname{Im} k_x|L)$ with $|\operatorname{Im} k_x|L \gtrsim 10$, which leaves 4.8×10^{-28} of the incident power. Reactive accounting is meaningful only at the edge plane, where it is 4.4×10^{-6}, and even there it is not transported energy. For the same reason P_{cross} is an interference correction and not a channel, and the evanescent members of $\{P_j\}$ are reactive; the complete statement is the partition above,

Table 4: The three reported configurations ($d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$, $\ell = 50\,\mathrm{nm}$, $H = 0$, $k_y d = 0.1298$, $L = 10d$). R_B is a modal share, not a reflectance.

Quantity	Operating point	Maximum	$k_x d = 0.55$
frequency	16.684 GHz	16.6547 GHz	16.6550 GHz
longitudinal wavenumber $k_x d$	0.7362	0.52719	0.5500
incident wavenumber $\mathrm{Re}\, k_{ix} d$	0.7362	0.5282	0.5500
group velocity v_g	379 m/s	0.01 m/s	34 m/s
incident attenuation, $4.343 \times 2\lvert \mathrm{Im}\, k_{ix}\rvert$	0.235 dB/mm	43.5 dB/mm to 44.5 dB/mm	2.01 dB/mm
backward attenuation, $4.343 \times 2\lvert \mathrm{Im}\, k_{Bx}\rvert$	0.227 dB/mm	43.5 dB/mm to 44.5 dB/mm	1.96 dB/mm
backward share R_B	0.0192916	0.9428718	0.5519095
modal share at the edge plane	0.0193	0.9824	0.5529
energy angle θ_E	$-27.90°$	$-13.85°$	$-14.45°$
total outgoing propagating power	0.99980	1.00050	0.99878
interference $P_{\mathrm{cross}}/P_{\mathrm{inc}}$	-4.6×10^{-6}	$+5.2 \times 10^{-4}$	-1.03×10^{-3}
dissipation $P_{\mathrm{diss}}/P_{\mathrm{inc}}$	1.99×10^{-4}	2.78×10^{-5}	1.93×10^{-4}
edge-system condition number	$\leq 2 \times 10^2$	$\leq 2 \times 10^2$	$\leq 2 \times 10^2$
scaled edge residual	$\leq 3 \times 10^{-15}$	$\leq 3 \times 10^{-15}$	$\leq 3 \times 10^{-15}$

Table 5: Matched controls. The frequency follows the branch. Entries marked "sp" are specular self-powers, not backward conversion.

	Operating point ($k_x d = 0.736$)		Maximum ($k_x d = 0.52719$)		$k_x d = 0.550$	
Configuration	freq. (GHz)	R_B	freq. (GHz)	R_B	freq. (GHz)	R_B
full (f_0, $H/H^* = +0.05$)	16.6840	0.019 058	16.6546	0.602 292	16.6549	0.495 776
$f = f_0$, $H = 0$	16.6841	0.019 292	16.6547	0.942 872	16.6550	0.551 910
$f = 0$, $H/H^* = +0.05$	16.6840	0.019 060	16.6546	0.602 290	16.6549	0.495 822
$f = 0$, $H = 0$	16.6841	0.019 294	16.6547	0.942 878	16.6550	0.551 976
$\ell = 0$, $f = 0$, $H = 0$	16.2077	$0.075\,961^{\mathrm{sp}}$	15.9717	$0.133\,278^{\mathrm{sp}}$	15.9943	$0.124\,109^{\mathrm{sp}}$

with the interference term quoted explicitly.

Panels (b) and (d) sweep the coupling at the *fixed* operating frequency $\omega = \omega_0$, so the incident wavenumber drifts with H along the branch instead of the frequency doing so. That is the response of the plate driven at one frequency; the branch-consistent comparison is the relevant one. At fixed frequency the backward channel changes from 1.9051×10^{-2} at $H/H^* = -0.05$ to 1.8876×10^{-2} at $H/H^* = +0.05$, a variation of 0.92 %; dissipation rises from 6.9×10^{-3} to 1.2×10^{-2}; the other propagating modes carry the balance. Panel (d) gives the same information as a relative change against the uncoupled baseline: the largest deviation is -2.15 % at $H/H^* = +0.05$. When instead k_x is held fixed and the frequency follows the branch (the branch-consistent comparison), the deviation at the same tabulated extreme is -1.21 %: part of the fixed-frequency variation is the dispersion shift of H, which reaches 6.3×10^{-5} in ω.

4.5 What creates the backward channel, and how far it persists

The partition quoted above was computed at $H = 0$, with the carrier–strain-gradient coupling switched off, and the contribution of that coupling is isolated by matched controls: each ingredient except the named one is held fixed (same k_x, same k_y, same n_0, same ℓ, same reference plane, same unit incident self-power), and the frequency follows the branch, because switching an ingredient off changes the dispersion and solutions taken at different frequencies of a different branch would not be comparable. Table 5 lists the outcome.

Three statements follow.

First, the effect is already present with $H = 0$: the same branch converts 1.93 % at the operating point and 94.29 % at the maximum. The strain-gradient piezoelectric-semiconductor model already contains the partition, and the coupling can only modify it.

Second, the size of the modification depends strongly on where the branch is sampled, and it is quantified. Turning H on at the tabulated extreme $|H| = 0.05H^*$ *reduces* the partition by 1.21 % at the operating point, by 10.17 % at $k_x d = 0.55$ and by 36.1 % at the maximum. The flexoelectric coefficient is neutral by comparison: at $f_0 = 1\,\mathrm{nC/m}$ it moves the partition by -0.012 % at the operating point, by -0.012 % at $k_x d = 0.55$ and by 0.0004 % at the maximum. The mechanism of the reduction is attenuation of both partner modes, whose decay rate rises from 1.0×10^{-3} to 8.5×10^{-3} per unit thickness at the maximum, so a larger part of the conversion is lost between the edge and the reference plane: referred to the edge plane, where

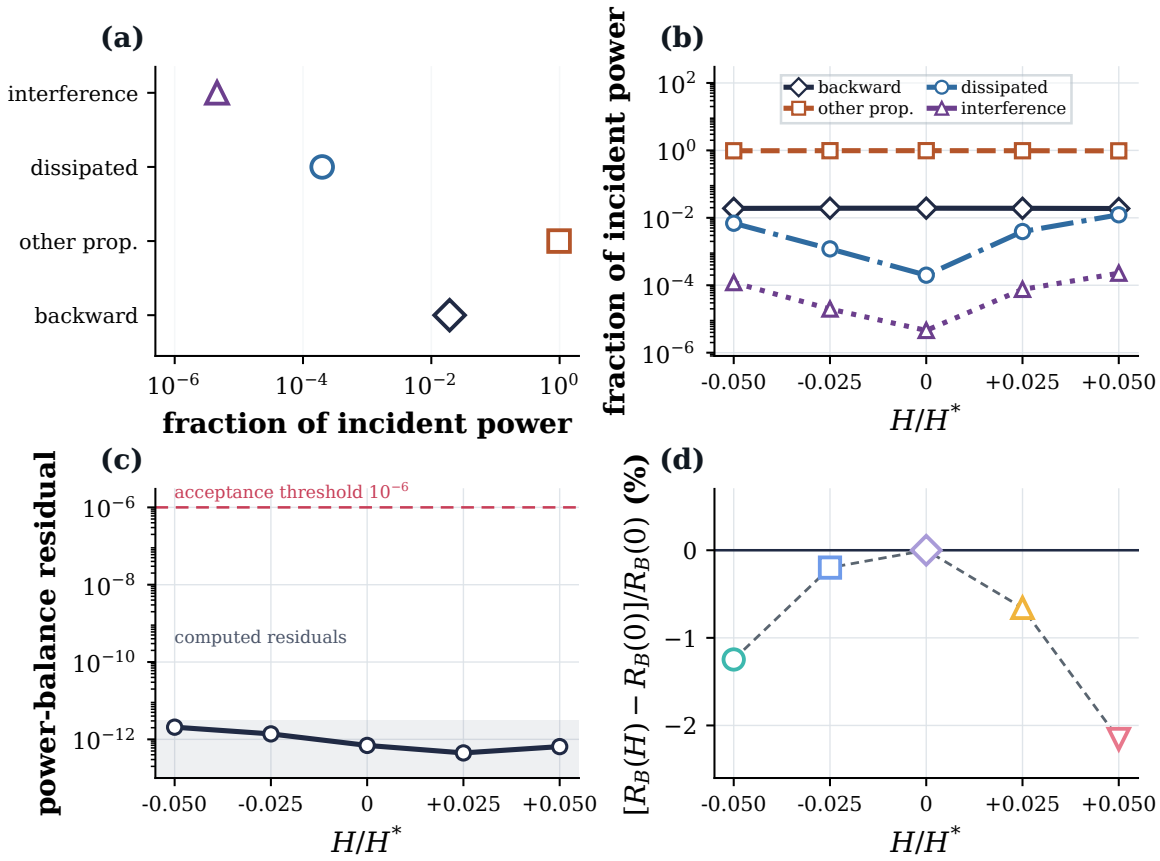


Figure 5: Energy budget at the operating point and the reference plane $x = -10\,d$; the interference term is shown as a magnitude. (a) Partition at $H = 0$. (b) The same fractions against H/H^* at fixed frequency. (c) Power-balance residual. (d) Relative change of the backward channel.

Table 6: Operating-point branch followed from $\lambda = \ell/d = 0.25$ to 0 at fixed k_y, with the flexoelectric coefficient and H set to zero; v_g in units of c_s.

λ	freq. at K_0 (GHz)	fold $k_x d$	fold freq. (GHz)	$\min v_g/c_s$
0.25	16.684	0.527	16.655	−0.069
0.20	16.274	0.805	16.270	−0.241
0.15	15.707	0.988	15.659	−0.450
0.10	14.951	1.084	14.884	−0.281
0.05	14.130	1.020	14.104	−0.106
0.00	13.687	0.824	13.685	−0.038

both effects are evaluated at the same place, the reduction is 13.8 %, whereas it is 36.1 % at the reference plane, and the remaining 22.3 percentage points are propagation loss. At $k_x d = 0.55$ the same comparison gives 1.65 % at the edge plane, against −10.17 % at the reference plane: there the coupling slightly *raises* the edge-plane share, and the whole of the reference-plane reduction is propagation loss. The branch-consistent sweep is monotone in $|H|$: at the maximum $R_B = 0.9429$, 0.7564, 0.6023 for $H/H^* = 0$, +0.025, +0.05 and 0.8541, 0.6827 for −0.025, −0.05. When the extremum is re-searched afresh at each coupling level it moves to $k_x d = 0.5222$, 0.5292, 0.5272, 0.5279, 0.5240 for $H/H^* = +0.05$, +0.025, 0, −0.025, −0.05, and the largest attainable share falls to 0.6034 and 0.6832 at the two extremes, so the coupling lowers the upper bound as well as shifting the location, and the shift is not monotone in the sign of H.

Third, the gradient length fixes the frequency and the wavenumber of the fold; it does not create the backward interval. At the control frequencies of the last row of table 5, which lie on a different classical branch from the continuation followed below, the classical plate ($\ell = 0$) has no outgoing mode with positive axial wavenumber and negative axial power: the only negative-power outgoing mode is the specular reflection, whose wavenumber equals $-k_{x,\mathrm{inc}}$; those entries therefore carry the superscript "sp". Following the operating-point mode to $\ell = 0$ at fixed k_y, however, shows that the classical plate has a backward interval of its own. Table 6 lists the frequency at $k_x = K_0$ and the zero-group-velocity point along that path: the fold moves from $k_x d = 0.527$ at $\lambda = 0.25$ to $k_x d = 0.824$ at $\lambda = 0$, and the group velocity is negative below the fold for all values of λ in the table.

The branch is tracked by modal overlap (at least 0.998 between neighboring steps), the group velocity is $\mathrm{d}\Omega/\mathrm{d}K$ by finite differences with $\Delta K = 0.01$, and the results agree to four digits between Galerkin degrees 18 and 24.

The edge problem was solved for the classical plate ($\lambda = 0$, no flexoelectricity, no coupling) at the fold of the tracked branch: at $k_x d = 0.824$ and 13.6855 GHz the backward mode carries 0.83620 of the incident power at the reference plane, and at $k_x d = 0.95$ (13.6891 GHz) it carries 0.95904. The spectral expansion at degrees 18 and 26 and the independent C^1 finite-element plate with 24 elements agree to 9×10^{-9} (first point) and 4×10^{-8} (second point), the power balance closes to 3×10^{-11} or better, and the scaled edge residual is below 3×10^{-15}. The large backward share is present in the classical plate before any strain-gradient length is introduced.

Taken together, the results read as follows. The negative reflection is a property of the backward guided branch: on it the energy flux travels opposite to the phase, the free edge converts into it, and, at $\lambda = 0.25$, the conversion is largest where the branch group velocity vanishes; the gradient length determines where that fold lies. The carrier dynamics determine the attenuation of both branches and so the observed value at a finite reference plane. The added carrier–strain-gradient coupling acts through that attenuation: it leaves the partition almost untouched where the branch is fast, and removes a third of it at the slow point, because there the conversion is large and the added decay has the whole distance to the reference plane to act. It modifies the picture; it does not create it.

Figure 6 follows the two channels away from the edge. The backward coefficient decays with the observation distance L (panel a) as $\exp(-\alpha_B L)$ with $\alpha_B = 2|\operatorname{Im} k_{Bx}|$, and the incident power arriving at the edge obeys a survival factor normalized to its edge value, which cannot exceed unity (panel b); the minimum over the solved range, reached at $H/H^* = +0.05$, is 0.0356 at $L = 1000\,\mu\mathrm{m}$, one millimeter from the edge.

Panels (c) and (d) give the attenuation length and the loss coefficient against the coupling. Both are obtained from the complex spatial roots, $\alpha = 2|\operatorname{Im} k_x|$, and neither is derived from a real square root. The attenuation length is largest at $H = 0$ (≈ 18 mm) and falls by more than an order of magnitude at either extreme of the coupling range, to 0.54 mm at $H/H^* = -0.05$ and to 0.30 mm at +0.05, and the loss coefficient follows the same pattern with a minimum of 0.23 dB/mm at $H = 0$ and a maximum of 14.5 dB/mm at $H/H^* = +0.05$; the corresponding attenuation length falls from 18.5 mm to 0.30 mm, a factor of sixty-two. The incident and backward channels share the same attenuation only at $H = 0$ (0.235 and 0.227 dB/mm); away from it they separate strongly, reaching 8.08 and 11.5 dB/mm at $H/H^* = -0.05$. The coupling thus

controls the loss of the plate much more strongly than it controls the partition of the scattered power, which is the opposite of what one might expect from the magnitude of the term (3) alone.

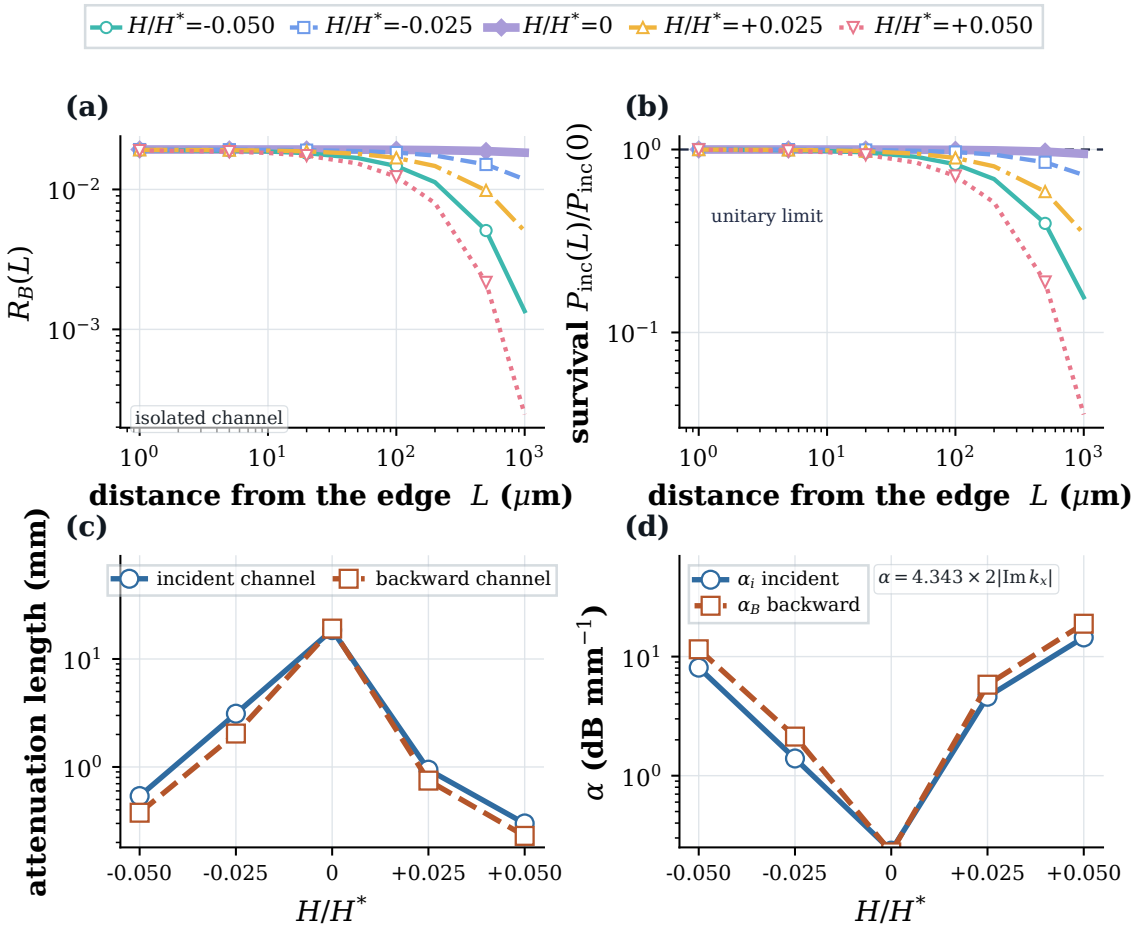


Figure 6: Distance, survival and attenuation at the operating point. (a) Backward channel against distance from the edge; (b) incident-power survival factor, normalized to its edge value; (c) attenuation length ($1/\alpha$ with $\alpha = 2|\operatorname{Im} k_x|$) and (d) loss coefficient in dB mm^{-1} ($4.343\,\alpha$) against H/H^*.

4.6 Coupling sensitivity and the through-thickness flux

Figure 7 resolves the two-parameter dependence. Over the solved box $0.05 \le k_y d \le 0.20$ and $-0.05 \le H/H^* \le 0.05$, the backward channel ranges from 0.01546 to 0.02180. Panel (a) shows that the transverse wavenumber alone accounts for almost all of that range: the five coupling curves are displaced but their common slope is set by k_y. Panels (c) and (d) quantify the displacement: against H/H^* at fixed operating frequency the relative change is at most 2.48 %, and against k_y it is a slow drift that never exceeds the same bound. The ratio of the two sensitivities is the quantitative statement of this paper about the added coupling: k_y changes the backward channel by a factor of 1.41 across the box, while H changes it by at most 2.5 % at fixed frequency and by 1.21 % in the branch-consistent comparison. The coupling is a perturbation of the partition and not its organizing parameter. The comparison must be made at fixed k_x, because it is the branch and not the coupling that sets the partition; the two sensitivities do meet, however, at the branch maximum, where the branch-consistent coupling effect grows to 36.1 %. The k_y sweep of fig. 7 was solved at the operating point only.

Panel (b) draws the computed 5×19 grid cell by cell, with no interpolation beyond the computational box and no smoothing between the five coupling levels. Every row of the grid satisfies (77).

Figure 8 examines how the backward flux is distributed through the thickness. The plotted quantity is the x component of the backward Poynting flux, normalized by the incident flux, as a function of z/d; it is an evaluated field, not an interpolated surface.

The distribution is a signature of the mode and not of the edge. The x component changes sign inside the plate: it is positive near both free surfaces and negative in the core, reaching -0.0306 and $+0.0264$ in units of the thickness-integrated incident flux, while its thickness integral remains negative. The net backward

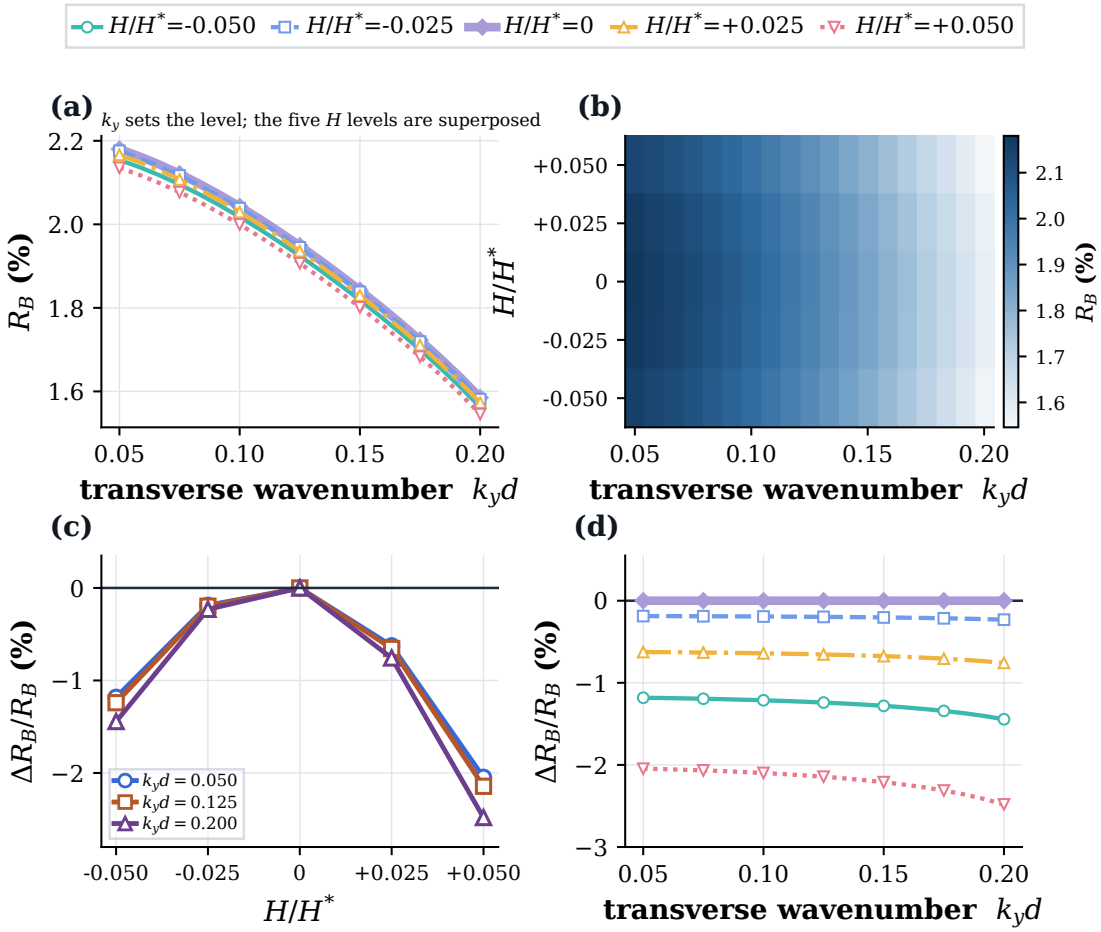


Figure 7: Coupling sensitivity at the operating frequency and wavenumber $k_x d = 0.7362$ (the operating point has $k_y d = 0.1298$). (a) R_B against $k_y d$ for five H/H^*; (b) measured $R_B(k_y d, H)$ grid; (c) relative change against H/H^* for three $k_y d$; (d) relative change against $k_y d$.

power is carried by a mode whose local flux direction alternates across the thickness, which follows from the strain-gradient plate mode itself. The z component behaves differently: it is largest at the free surfaces and does not vanish there, so the surfaces carry a transverse flux even though both traction and double traction vanish on them. This is the configuration in which the reactive near field must be retained at the edge plane, and it explains why the energy budget separates the reactive content from the transported content instead of adding them.

Panel (c) gives the running thickness integral normalized to its own total, so the curve rises from zero to one across the plate for each coupling level and the five curves are indistinguishable. Panel (d) compares the shape of the backward and incident x fluxes at $H = 0$, both normalized by their own maxima; both profiles are symmetric about the mid-plane, the incident flux lies mostly near the two faces (55 % of $\int |P_x|\,\mathrm{d}z$ within $0.1\,d$ of them) and the backward flux does not (9 %).

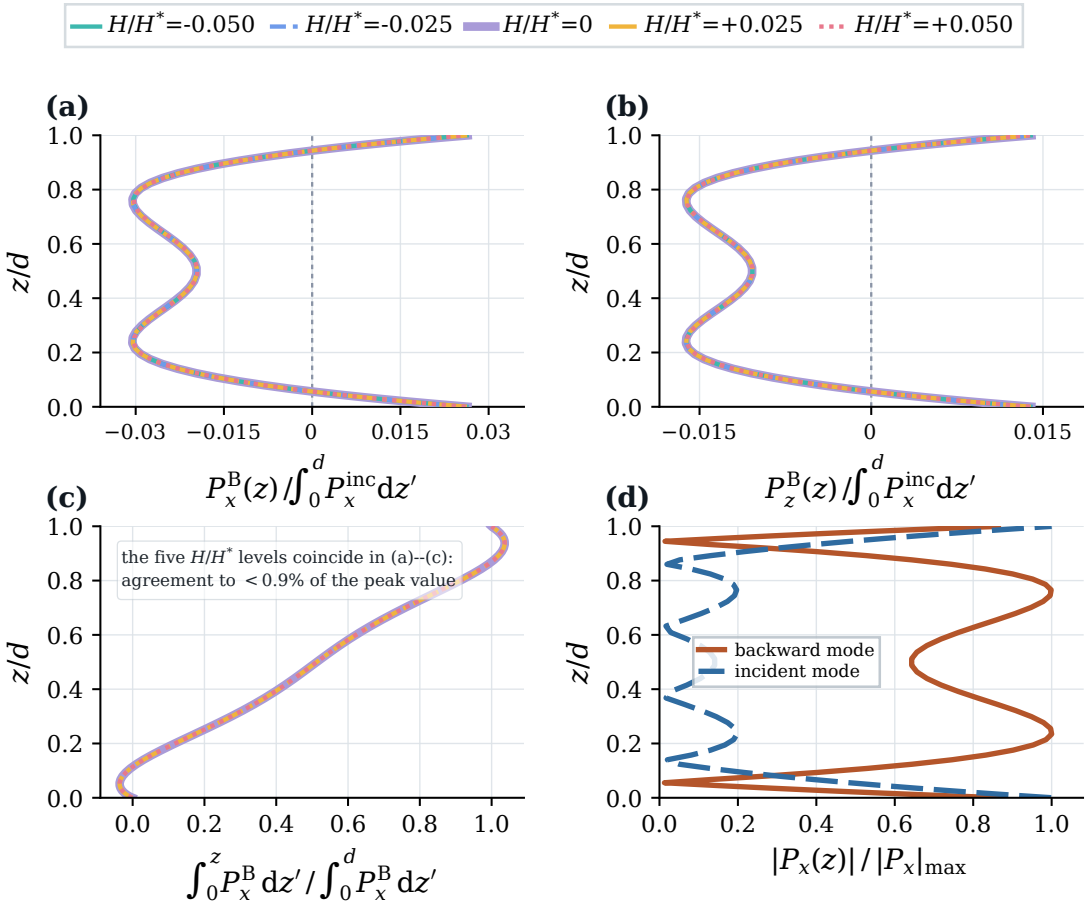


Figure 8: Through-thickness backward flux at the operating point and the reference plane, in units of the thickness-integrated incident flux $\int_0^d P_x^{\mathrm{inc}}\,\mathrm{d}z$. (a) $P_x^{\mathrm{B}}(z)$ and (b) $P_z^{\mathrm{B}}(z)$ for five H/H^*; (c) running integral of P_x^{B}; (d) backward and incident x fluxes at $H = 0$.

The coincidence of the five profiles in fig. 8(a)–(c) follows from the assembly and not from a plotting choice, and it can be quantified. The coupling enters through the two off-diagonal blocks that connect the out-of-plane displacement to the carrier, whose entries are

$$\left(\mathsf{A}_{u\mu}\right)_{ij} = h \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} b_i''(s)\, b_j(s)\,\mathrm{d}s, \tag{81}$$

because $\widetilde{\mu}$ contains $-h\,\partial_s^2 u_3$ and (10) is the relation that conveys the coupling; written in the coordinate $\zeta = 2s$ of the field equations the same term acquires a factor four, $4\partial_\zeta^2$, and the measure $\mathrm{d}s = \mathrm{d}\zeta/2$ is what keeps (81) free of it. Since b_i'' has degree $i-2$ and b_j has degree j, the matrix of (81) vanishes unless $j \le i-2$: it is lower triangular, not upper triangular, and its row norms 0, 0, 26.83, 91.65, 222.89, 450.87, 809.44 at degree six grow with the mode number as the second derivative does, the largest single entry being 580.5 in the last row. With $h = 1.06 \times 10^{-2}$ the largest entry of the assembled block is 6.13, which is 10.5% of the inertia scale $\omega^2 = 58.3$ that sets the through-thickness balance of the lowest rows, and four and a half orders

of magnitude below the largest diagonal entry of the same rows, 2.16×10^{5}. That is a statement about the size of the coupling, not about a mode: the operator is row-equilibrated before the eigenvalue problem is formed, so no entry ratio is a frequency. The size of these entries sets the scale of the coupling in the assembled operator but is not used to derive the profile differences. Those are read from fig. 8(a)–(c): the flux profiles of the five levels differ by less than 0.9 % of the peak value, while the partition at the same coupling changes by 1.21 % at the operating point.

The same reading applies to the density sweep, where five carrier densities collapse onto one curve. The density enters the carrier sector only through the screening group $Q^2 = d^2q^2n_0/(\kappa_{33}k_BT)$, which multiplies the single potential block $\mathsf{A}_{\varphi\mu}$, and through the mobility in $\alpha_{\mathrm{d}} = \mu_e k_B T/(q\,d\,c_s)$; in the response the two appear as the conductivity $n_0\mu_e$, so at fixed $n_0\mu_e$ the partition is unchanged and the collapse reflects that product and not either parameter separately.

4.7 Independent cross-checks and the near field

Figure 9 documents the numerical behavior of the edge solve. Panels (a) and (b) show the relative error of the backward channel and of the backward wavenumber against the degree-33 reference: the channel error falls from 2.6×10^{-5} at $n = 14$ to 1.6×10^{-6} at $n = 26$, while the wavenumber error remains at the 10^{-12} round-off floor over the full range, so the channel error is still decreasing at the highest degree shown. Panel (c) shows the scaled edge residual and the relative energy-balance error for each degree: the residual is 3×10^{-15}, six to seven orders below the 10^{-8} tolerance drawn in the panel, and the energy-balance error lies between 2×10^{-13} and 4×10^{-12}, one to three orders below the 10^{-10} line. Both are round-off in a relative measure, and the panel shows that neither drifts with the degree. Panel (d) compares the temporal and spatial routes for the same dispersion relation across the box; they agree to 2×10^{-5}.

The last panel is a check on the implementation, not a physical validation. The two routes discretize the same variational statement and differ only in which variable is used as the eigenvalue; agreement to 2×10^{-5} shows that the assembly, the boundary conditions and the elimination of the potential are implemented consistently.

The classical part of the edge solver was compared with the published free-edge calculation of Gérardin et al. [45]. The ZnO constants were replaced by those of their Duralumin plate ($\rho = 2790\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}$, $c_L = 6398\,\mathrm{m/s}$, $c_T = 3122\,\mathrm{m/s}$), with no piezoelectricity, strain gradient or carrier coupling, and the incident S_1 mode was taken at normal incidence ($k_y = 10^{-7}$ in the units of the solver). The backward branch appears at $f\times(2h) = 2.8727\,\mathrm{MHz\,mm}$, against 2.87 in [45]. The modal share $R_B = |r_{S_1|S_{2b}}|^2$ is 0.9988 at $2\times10^{-6}\,\mathrm{MHz\,mm}$ above that frequency, which is the perfect conversion of [45], and then falls to 0.797, 0.500 and 0.288 at 2.90, 3.00 and 3.10 MHz mm, that is $|r| = 0.893$, 0.707 and 0.537. Read from their Fig. 2(b) by eye, the corresponding values are about 0.9, 0.7 and 0.55, so the agreement is within the reading accuracy of the figure; no tabulated values are available for a closer comparison. Degrees 18 and 26 differ by less than 10^{-9} in R_B, the power balance closes to 4×10^{-11} and the edge residual is below 10^{-14} (`benchmark_duralumin.py`). This benchmark covers the classical elastic edge problem only; it does not test the piezoelectric, strain-gradient or carrier terms. The independent checks are the strong-form integrations and the C^1 finite-element plate, neither of which shares the spectral matrices with the production path.

Figure 10 shows the solved field. Panels (a) and (b) show the incident and backward intensities on a shared logarithmic color scale over $x \in [-60, 1.5]\,\mu\mathrm{m}$ and $y \in [-45, 45]\,\mu\mathrm{m}$; the vertical line at $x = 0$ is the edge, the plate lies to its left, and the intensities are normalized to a common maximum so that the backward field is visibly weaker by one to three decades. The incident field approaches the edge at $+10.0°$ and the backward field leaves it at $-27.9°$, both measured from the thickness-integrated Poynting flux.

Panel (c) is a schematic, but its arrows are not drawn by hand: they are the solved directions. The two wavenumbers point into the plate, $\boldsymbol{k}_i \propto (1, 0.176)$ and $\boldsymbol{k}_B \propto (1, 0.529)$, because k_y is positive and both axial wavenumbers are real and positive. The incident flux follows its wavenumber, $\boldsymbol{P}_i \propto (1, 0.176)$, whereas the backward flux is $\boldsymbol{P}_B \propto (-1, -0.529)$: the backward mode carries energy in $-x$ and in $-y$ simultaneously, so its energy transport is opposite in both components to its own phase direction, and the two flux arrows are the geometric content of the word "negative". Panel (d) shows the two components of the backward flux against $k_y d$; both are negative throughout the box, and both tend to a common small value as $k_y d \to 0.2$.

4.8 Sensitivity of the fold conversion to carrier density and to structural loss

The two sweeps above vary the carrier density over a factor of three and contain no loss other than carrier conduction and diffusion. Because the conversion is largest where the incident flux nearly vanishes, both limits were tested with the same branch-following definition of R_B ($L = 10\,d$, $k_y d = 0.1298$, $H = 0$); the code is `robustness_sweeps.py`.

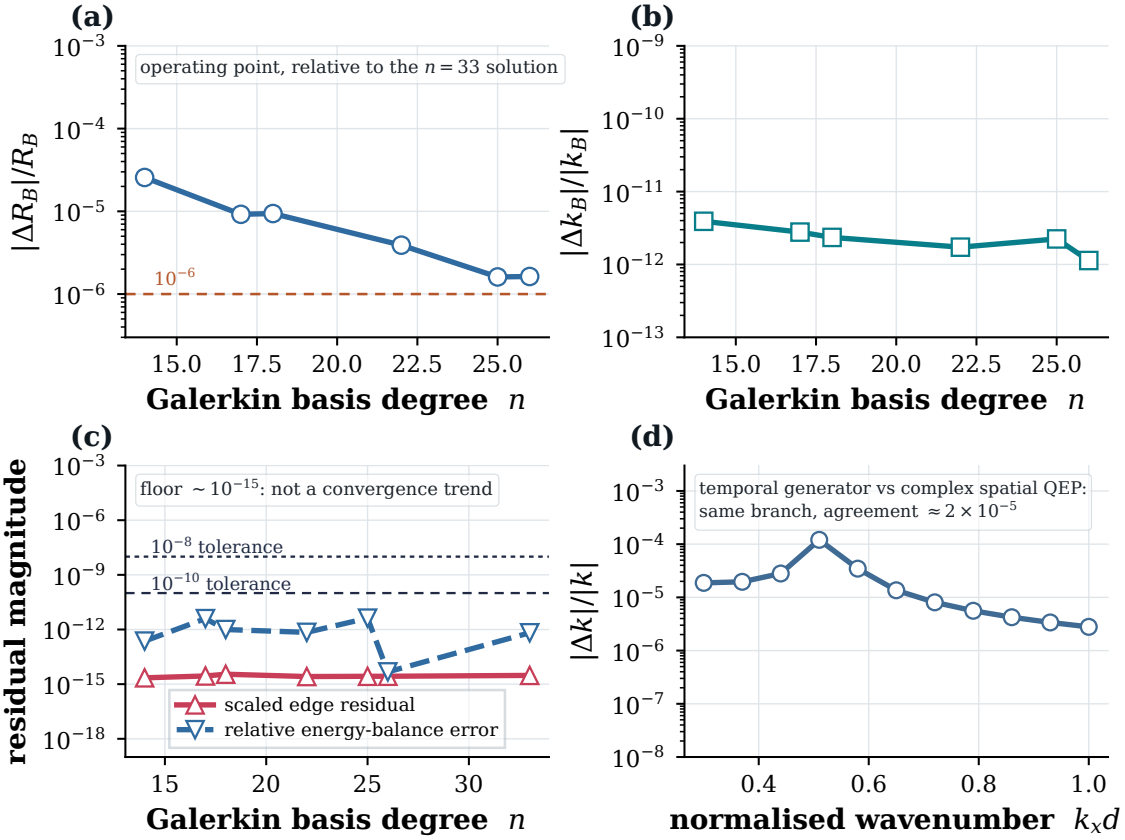


Figure 9: Convergence and consistency checks at the operating point. (a) Error of R_B and (b) of the backward wavenumber against the Galerkin degree, relative to the $n = 33$ solution; (c) edge residual and energy-balance error; (d) temporal-generator against spatial eigenvalue routes.

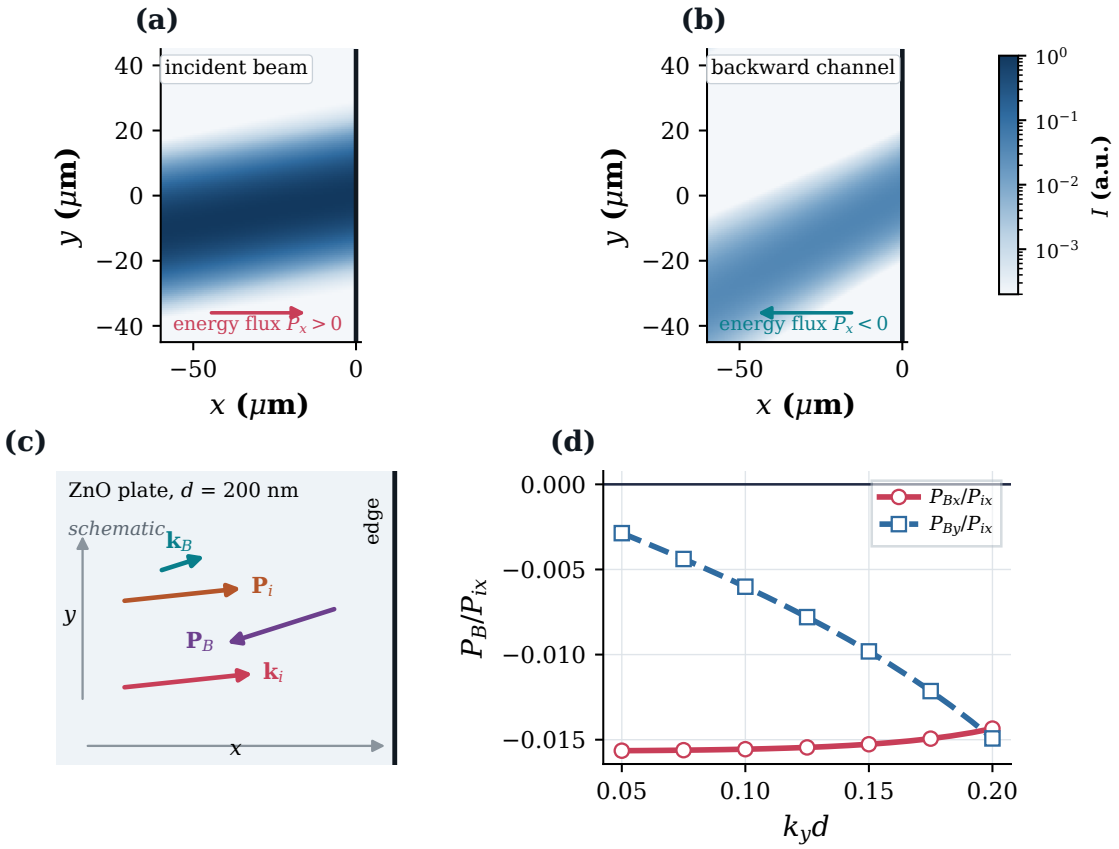


Figure 10: Field maps and flux directions at the operating point. (a) Incident and (b) backward intensity (arbitrary units, common logarithmic scale) for a Gaussian superposition in $k_y d$ of standard deviation 0.022 about 0.1298, edge at $x = 0$; (c) schematic of wavenumber and flux directions; (d) components of the backward flux against $k_y d$.

Table 7: Fold search at six carrier densities ($d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$, $\ell = 50\,\mathrm{nm}$, $H = 0$, $k_y d = 0.1298$, $L = 10d$). Entries marked $\geq$ are the largest sampled value in a window of ± 0.03 in $k_x d$ about the fold, with the argmax on the edge of the window.

n_0 (1/m^3)	$Q = d/L_D$	linewidth at the maximum (MHz)	R_B maximum
2×10^{18}	0.075	0.0024	0.9428
2×10^{19}	0.24	0.024	0.828
2×10^{20}	0.75	0.23	0.545
2×10^{21}	2.4	2.1	≥ 0.168
2×10^{22}	7.5	6.9	≥ 0.043
2×10^{23}	24	2.2	≥ 0.174

Table 8: Maximum R_B at the fold against an added loss tangent η ($n_0 = 2 \times 10^{18}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$, $H = 0$, $k_y d = 0.1298$, $L = 10d$); lower bounds over 41 frequencies.

η	$1/\eta$	R_B maximum	$\lvert \mathrm{Im}\, k_{ix} \rvert d$
0	—	0.943	1.0×10^{-3}
10^{-5}	10^5	0.600	8.1×10^{-3}
10^{-4}	10^4	0.197	2.0×10^{-2}
10^{-3}	10^3	not evaluated	
10^{-2}	10^2	not evaluated	

Carrier density. Table 7 repeats the search for the fold at six densities from 2×10^{18} to $2 \times 10^{23}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$, which takes $Q = d/L_D$ from 0.075 to 24. This range covers the densities of nominally undoped ZnO compiled in Table VII of [3], 8×10^{19}–$5 \times 10^{23}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$, up to its upper end. The maximum falls from 0.943 to 0.545 over the first two decades, with the argmax inside the raster. From $2 \times 10^{21}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$ upward the largest sampled value in a window of ± 0.03 about the fold lies on the edge of the window, so the entries are lower bounds and the maximum itself was not located. At the operating point the share stays between 0.0158 and 0.0410 over the whole range 2×10^{18} to $6 \times 10^{23}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$, and its linewidth peaks near $2 \times 10^{22}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$ at 8.7 MHz. The statement of section 4.2 that the density sets the loss but not the partition therefore holds for the range of fig. 2; at the fold the partition depends on the density through the loss.

Structural loss. The model contains no intrinsic elastic loss. To measure the effect of one, the elastic and gradient-elastic tensors were multiplied by $1 - i\eta$ (time dependence $e^{-i\omega t}$), a loss tangent η, i.e. a quality factor $1/\eta$, with the carrier terms unchanged. The form and the values of η are assumed; none is taken from a measurement. Viscoelastic loss of the Kelvin–Voigt type has been treated for nonlocal piezo-semiconductors elsewhere [57]. The frequency was scanned over 41 values within $\pm 3 \times 10^{-3}$ of the lossless fold frequency and the largest R_B is reported, so that each entry is a lower bound on the maximum over frequency. Table 8 shows that $\eta = 10^{-5}$ lowers the maximum from 0.943 to 0.600 and $\eta = 10^{-4}$ to 0.197, while $\lvert \mathrm{Im}\, k_{ix} \rvert d$ rises from 1.0×10^{-3} to 8.1×10^{-3} and 2.0×10^{-2}. This is the square-root response of the spatial roots to a small loss near a zero-group-velocity point. For $\eta \geq 10^{-3}$ the port selection finds no propagating incident mode in the scan window and the entries are not evaluated. The value 0.943 is therefore that of a plate whose only loss is carrier conduction, and it should be read as an upper bound for a real plate.

5 Discussion

This section interprets the results rather than restating them. The discussion covers what the partition means, which sector of the model provides the branch, how the mechanism relates to published formulations, where each constant comes from and what the model does not resolve.

5.1 The observable: a modal partition of the scattered power

The central quantity of this work is R_B: the share of the incident power that ends up in one particular outgoing mode, measured at a plane ten thicknesses from the edge. It is a partition of the scattered field and not a reflectance. At the operating point the backward mode takes 1.93 % while the remaining propagating outgoing modes take 98.05 %; at the maximum the backward mode takes 94.29 % while the rest take 5.76 %. At the operating point the total outgoing propagating power is 0.99980 of the incident power and at the maximum 1.00050, so the plate is an almost perfect scatterer of the guided mode in both cases and the question of interest is not how much is reflected but into which branch it goes.

The distinction has a practical consequence. A measurement of the total reflectance of an edge would see essentially unity everywhere on the branch. A measurement that resolves the modal content (by a wavenumber filter, or by a time-of-flight separation of the branches) would see the partition move from almost nothing in the backward channel to more than half of the incident power. The negative reflection discussed here is an observable that requires modal resolution.

The word "backward" is used in an operational sense: a mode is backward when the x component of its thickness-integrated Poynting flux is negative, and (70) confirms that the same mode is outgoing at the edge. The dispersion branch has a region where v_g and v_E are negative (fig. 1b), which is necessary for a backward mode to exist, and that region is a property of the infinite plate. What creates the conversion is the edge, and what controls its strength is where the operating point lies on the branch.

5.2 The mechanism

The sweep along the branch (fig. 4) places the maximum of the conversion at $k_x d = 0.52719$, where the group velocity vanishes ($+0.01\,\mathrm{m/s}$ against -187 and $+409\,\mathrm{m/s}$ at the ends of the solved window) and where the backward wavenumber approaches the incident one to within 0.4 %. This is a slow-mode effect and it has a simple reading: at a zero-group-velocity fold the incident and backward wavenumbers are nearly equal, so the two modes are nearly parallel and the edge condition can be met with only a small admixture of the other outgoing modes; the projection onto the backward mode then takes almost all of the partition. Panel (c) of the same figure makes this explicit: all coupling levels collapse onto one curve in k_{Bx}/k_{ix}, with the conversion maximal as the ratio approaches unity. The same mechanism explains why the conversion falls steeply on both flanks: on the fast side the wavenumbers separate, and on the far side of the fold the branch has changed character. A grid of $\Delta k_x d = 0.05$ would miss this maximum, because the entire top of the response is 10^{-3} wide; the two rasters of fig. 4 locate it.

The reading has a second half. At the fold the incident mode itself is nearly cut off: its group velocity vanishes, so the flux it carries per unit normalization falls by a factor 131 with respect to the operating point. The partition is maximal at the very point where the transported power is minimal. A statement that ninety-four percent of the energy is turned around would be true as a ratio and false as an energy budget, and only the first is claimed.

The reflection is present before the coupling is switched on. The controls of section 4.5 establish this directly: with $H = 0$ the same branch converts 94.29 % of the incident power at the maximum and 1.93 % at the operating point, and at the same frequency the classical plate of the control row has no backward member. The strong negative reflection is thus a property of the backward guided branch and of the edge, not a resonance of the added coupling; the gradient length places the fold of that branch at the reported frequency.

However, the coupling H acts on the loss, and through the loss on the partition. It shifts the dispersion by at most 1.1×10^{-5} in relative terms (inset of fig. 1a), it shifts the loss by up to a factor of sixty-two (fig. 6c,d), and the partition follows with a weight that depends on where the branch is sampled: -1.21 % at the operating point, -10.17 % at $k_x d = 0.55$ and -36.1 % at the maximum. The ordering (dispersion unaffected, partition affected only where the branch is slow, loss strongly affected everywhere) is what a carrier-level coupling acting through conduction loss should produce. The third of the partition lost at the maximum is mostly loss acting on the backward mode between the edge and the reference plane: referred to the edge plane, where both effects act at the same place, the same comparison gives 13.8 %, against 36.1 % at the reference plane, so 22.3 percentage points are propagation loss and the rest is an actual reduction of the conversion. Re-searching the extremum at each coupling level separates the two effects further: the location moves from 0.5272 to 0.5222 and 0.5240 at the two extremes of H, and the largest attainable share falls from 0.9429 to 0.6034 and 0.6832, so the coupling both lowers the attainable maximum and displaces it, asymmetrically in the sign of H.

The transverse wavenumber is the organizing parameter at the operating point, not the coupling. Figure 7 shows that k_y changes the backward channel by a factor of 1.41 across the solved box while H moves it by 1.21 % branch-consistently (2.5 % at fixed frequency). At the maximum, however, the coupling moves the partition by 36.1 %, more than the k_y factor found at the operating point; the k_y sweep was not repeated there. The ordering is not a property of the coupling alone; it is a property of the coupling and the operating point together. Any statement about the added coupling must be made at fixed k_y, and any experimental attempt to see the coupling must control the transverse wavenumber much better than it controls the doping or the mobility.

5.3 Relation to the literature

The formulation belongs to the flexoelectric-semiconductor continuum developed by Qu and co-workers [19, 20], in which the strain gradient polarizes the medium, the polarization is screened by the mobile carriers, and the redistributed carriers act back on the field. The wave theory used here is that of Yang et al. [24, 25] for flexoelectric plates and half-spaces with strain-gradient elasticity, and Zhang et al. [7] find, for a simply supported plate under static load and in free vibration, that the semiconductor coupling is active only within a window of initial electron concentration, and that this window moves to larger concentrations as the plate becomes thinner. The concentration at which their damping is largest is $10^{18.6}$, $10^{19.6}$ and $10^{20.6}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$ for $h = 30$, 3 and $0.3\,\mu\mathrm{m}$. The present plate ($d = 200\,\mathrm{nm}$, $n_0 \le 3\times10^{18}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$) lies below these values, so the carrier results here describe the weakly conducting side of that window. Qu et al. [58] derive plate equations for flexoelectric semiconductors by the Mindlin method with the same simplified gradient modulus $g = \ell^2 c$, and check them against three-dimensional dispersion relations for a silicon plate of thickness $0.2\,\mu\mathrm{m}$. For piezoelectric-semiconductor ZnO plates, Li et al. [59] report for shear-horizontal waves that an initial density below $2\times10^{18}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$ barely changes the cut-off frequencies and that above $10^{23}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$ the plate responds as an elastic one; the density sweep of section 4.8 lies within this range. Dispersion and damping of Rayleigh-type waves in a piezo-thermo-electric semiconductor with fractional and nonlocal effects have also been computed [60].

What is different here is the object of study. The references above compute dispersion relations and attenuation of modes in an unbounded or layered medium, and the scattering calculations available for flexoelectric media are plane-wave reflection coefficients at a free surface of a half-space [28]. This paper computes the *scattering* of a guided mode at a free edge of a plate, resolves the outgoing spectrum into its branches, and reports the partition. That is a different calculation with a different output: a dispersion curve is an eigenvalue problem, whereas an edge partition requires the matching of a continuum of outgoing modes and a classification of each of them.

The closest primary work is the thermodynamically consistent theory of Qu, Pan, Zhu and Deng [22], who derive the constitutive equations for a flexoelectric semiconductor from the free-energy imbalance with the Coleman–Noll procedure, and who obtain the drift–diffusion current, the flexoelectric and piezoelectric couplings and the higher-order stress in one framework. That article builds a continuum theory for flexoelectric semiconductors from the balances of mass, charge, momentum and angular momentum together with the thermodynamic laws. Its constitutive equations follow from the dissipation inequality and include piezoelectric, flexoelectric, thermoelectric and drift–diffusion couplings, and the theory is completed by a principle of virtual work and a linearization for small carrier perturbations. The interaction of strain gradient and electric current is therefore the subject of that framework, and a carrier–strain-gradient coupling of the class used here is not claimed as new to it. The explicit form of its free energy is reproduced, with attribution, in the open-access computational paper of Hu et al. [23] (Eqs. (4a)–(4e) there), and that form is used for the comparison. In that formulation the electric Gibbs free energy is additive,

$$\Psi_{\mathrm{Gib}} = \Psi_{\mathrm{Mech}}(\varepsilon, g) + \Psi_{\mathrm{Elec}}(e) + \Psi_{\mathrm{Diele}}(\varepsilon, g, e) + \Psi_{\mathrm{Carrier}}(n, p), \tag{82}$$

with $\Psi_{\mathrm{Mech}} = \frac{1}{2}C_{ijkl}\varepsilon_{ij}\varepsilon_{kl} + \frac{1}{2}A_{ijklmn}g_{ijk}g_{lmn}$, $\Psi_{\mathrm{Diele}} = -\eta_{ijk}e_i\varepsilon_{jk} - \mu_{lijk}e_l g_{ijk}$ and $\Psi_{\mathrm{Carrier}}(n,p)$ a function of the two carrier densities alone. Three consequences follow for the present paper.

First, the carrier energy in (82), which is the form of the main text of [22] (Eqs. (3.16)–(3.17) there), contains no strain gradient. Since the thermodynamic restriction fixes $\partial\Psi_{\mathrm{Gib}}/\partial n = \mu_n + q\psi$, the electrochemical potential of that decomposition contains no strain-gradient contribution, and the strain gradient reaches the carriers only *indirectly*, through the flexoelectric polarization that enters Gauss's law. The direct bilinear term $\Delta n\, H_{jkl}\varepsilon_{jk,l}$ of (3) is absent from that postulate, but not from the article: its Appendix C.1 adds a chemo-mechanical energy that is linear in the carrier concentration and in the strain and the strain gradient, $\tilde{n}\, M^n_{IJ}G_{IJ} + \tilde{n}\, M^n_{IJK}\eta_{IJK}$ (and the same for holes), so that the electrochemical potential acquires $M^n_{IJ}G_{IJ} + M^n_{IJK}\eta_{IJK}$ (their Eqs. (C.1)–(C.2)). The term used here corresponds to M^n_{IJK}, with H_{jkl} linearized about n_0 and written in the scaled units; the article neglects it in its Sec. 3.4 and does not pose an edge-scattering problem. Relative to the main-text postulate it is an *independent* addition, neither a change of variables nor a special case of a more general tensor.

Second, the symbol H is overloaded in the literature and we flag the collision explicitly to avoid a misreading: in [23] the sixth-order strain-gradient elasticity tensor is written H_{ijklmn} and in [22] it is G_{IJKLMN}, while there H_{IJKLM} is a fifth-order strain–strain-gradient coupling; in this paper the sixth-order tensor is written A_{ijklmn} (eq. (6), eq. (8)); the coefficient H_{jkl} used here is a third-order carrier–strain-gradient coefficient with different units (J m). The two are unrelated, and the positivity bounds derived in the formulation apply only to the latter.

Third, the comparison locates the contribution. Were the coupling the main result, the contribution would be a constitutive hypothesis of the kind that [22] already systematizes; it is not the main result,

Table 9: Provenance of each parameter.

Parameter	Value and provenance	Source
c_{ij}, e_{ij}, κ_{ij}, ρ	$c_{11} = 210$, $c_{33} = 221$, $c_{44} = 43\,\mathrm{GPa}$; $e_{33} = 1.32$, $e_{31} = -0.57$, $e_{15} = -0.48\,\mathrm{C/m^2}$; $\kappa_{33} = 8.85 \times 10^{-11}\,\mathrm{F/m}$; literature values	Table 1 of [7]
μ_e, D	$0.0175\,\mathrm{m^2/(V\,s)}$, $D = 4.55 \times 10^{-4}\,\mathrm{m^2/s}$, equal to $\mu_e k_B T/q$ at $T = 301.7\,\mathrm{K}$ (0.6 % above the value at 300 K); representative, within the 120–$205\,\mathrm{cm^2/(V\,s)}$ compiled for nominally undoped bulk and film ZnO in Table VII of [3]; [7] use $100\,\mathrm{cm^2/(V\,s)}$ and $2.6\,\mathrm{cm^2/s}$; [59] use $1\,\mathrm{m^2/(V\,s)}$ and $0.026\,\mathrm{m^2/s}$	input value
n_0	$1\text{–}3 \times 10^{18}\,1/\mathrm{m^3}$; modeling scenario, below the 8×10^{13}–$5 \times 10^{17}\,1/\mathrm{cm^3}$ (8×10^{19}–$5 \times 10^{23}\,1/\mathrm{m^3}$) of Table VII of [3]	parameter sweep of fig. 2
d	200 nm reference, 120–320 nm sweep; modeling scenario	geometry sweep of fig. 3
ℓ	50 nm; assumed; the same $g = \ell^2 c$ form is used in [58] with 20 nm for silicon	this work
f_{3zz}	1 nC/m; assumed, in the nC/m range reported for ZnO; contributes −0.01 % to R_B	this work
H_{jkl}	H_{333} only, $\lvert H\rvert \le 2.0 \times 10^{-23}\,\mathrm{J\,m} = 0.022\,H_{\mathrm{bound}}$; assumed, within the positivity bound	this work

because section 4.5 shows that the negative reflection exists with $H = 0$. What this paper contributes is the *scattering* problem: the partition of a guided mode into the outgoing branches of a free edge, with a backward branch on which energy and phase travel in opposite directions, together with the demonstration that a carrier–strain-gradient enthalpy can be added to a strain-gradient piezoelectric semiconductor without violating the positivity bound, and a quantified account of its incremental effect.

For this reason the added term is not put forward as new. The formulations compared above already contain a flexoelectric coupling of strain gradients to the electric field, and the carrier density enters them through the free energy of the electron gas; the term $\Delta n\, H_{jkl}\varepsilon_{jk,l}$ with its reciprocal partners in σ_{ij} and $\widetilde{\mu}$ is written here as the minimal extension that closes the enthalpy, and the paper establishes as much about what it does not do as about what it does: it moves the partition by 1.21 % at the operating point, 10.17 % at $k_x d = 0.55$ and 36.1 % at the maximum, all at $\lvert H\rvert = 0.05 H^*$, and it is not the origin of the backward branch. No priority is claimed for it, as the term has precedent in the cited thermodynamic framework. What the present numbers do establish is that the edge-scattering problem is well posed, that its energy budget closes to better than 10^{-11}, and that the coupling is a perturbation of a branch that the classical plate already has, near $k_x d = 0.82$, while at the operating frequency and in-plane wavenumber considered here the gradient-free plate has no accessible outgoing backward channel.

5.4 Material provenance

The provenance of the parameters is mixed and is stated explicitly in table 9. The classical constants are literature values; the transport parameters are representative values for n-type ZnO at room temperature linked by the Einstein relation; the strain-gradient length, the flexoelectric coefficient and the coupling scale are *assumed*. The flexoelectric coefficient lies in the nC/m range reported for ZnO [23, 56]. For H_{jkl} no published value is available, and the numbers used here ($\lvert H\rvert \le 2.0 \times 10^{-23}\,\mathrm{J\,m}$) are fixed by the positivity bound (60), which leaves the $(\varepsilon, \eta, \Delta n)$ block of the enthalpy positive definite with a margin of a factor of forty-five in H; no specimen provides them.

5.5 Limitations

Five limitations bound the conclusions, and each is stated where it enters the model.

1. *Geometry.* The formulation is two-and-a-half-dimensional: a plate infinite in y, semi-infinite in x, with three displacement components on the (x, z) cross-section. It has one edge and not two, and it does not resolve the three-dimensional corner where the edge meets the free surfaces. A finite plate, a second edge, and the interference between them are outside the model.

2. *The corner.* The corner line force (42) is a natural datum that the polynomial basis cannot annihilate pointwise, so it is measured instead of assumed, on the coherent sum of the incident mode and every outgoing mode. Relative to the incident mode's own corner scale it is 8.4×10^{-2} at the operating point, 3.3×10^{-3} at the corrected maximum and 3.8×10^{-2} at $k_xd=0.55$, all at the lowest degree tested (10), and it falls to 4.5×10^{-2}, 1.7×10^{-3} and 2.0×10^{-2} at degree 28. Over that range it follows one algebraic law in each configuration, $3.5\times10^{-1}n^{-0.62}$, $1.4\times10^{-2}n^{-0.63}$ and $1.6\times10^{-1}n^{-0.63}$: the same exponent to 0.014 in three independent configurations, which is the signature of an unresolved corner singularity of the continuum solution and not of a quadrature or coding artifact; it is unchanged to six digits when the quadrature rule is varied from 96 to 192 nodes. So two things are established and one is not. Established: the line force decays towards zero algebraically and is bounded by the numbers above over the full tested range; and it does not decide the result, because the reported partition at the maximum moves by 3.9×10^{-6} between degrees 10 and 28, while the line force halves over the same range and the energy identity closes to better than 10^{-11}. Not established: that the force vanishes, or that the exponent is 0.62 as opposed to a nearby value; a proof would need the local corner eigenvalue problem of the second-gradient operator with the flexoelectric and carrier couplings. The closure claimed here is thus a *bounded* one, not a full one, and the scattering result does not rest on it. The same holds for the traction itself: the weak form of the edge condition closes to machine precision, but the pointwise traction is not identically zero. At the operating point its normalized norm away from the corners is 4.3×10^{-2} at degree 10 and 3.6×10^{-2} at degree 28, while its maximum over the edge, which sits at the corners, grows from 0.77 to 2.4 over the same range. The free edge is therefore satisfied in the weak sense, and a direct two-dimensional x–z finite-element solution of the same variational problem, with the edge cells refined down to $0.00125\,d$, reproduces the modal backward share at the operating point to within 0.5 % (table 2), with no systematic drift under refinement. That check is made at the operating point only. The same measurements settle what the earlier band-energy argument could not: the strain-gradient energy in the outer band $|z|>0.4\,d/2$ is 0.93–1.00 % of the total at the operating point, 1.22–1.30 % at the maximum and 1.18–1.26 % at $k_xd=0.55$, and its share decreases with degree, but the band average of the mixed hyperstress exceeds the pointwise corner value by factors of five to ten, so no band average is used here to argue the corner datum away.

3. *The carrier model and the electrical condition.* The only loss in the base model is carrier conduction and diffusion; section 4.8 shows that an added elastic loss tangent of 10^{-5} already lowers the maximum conversion from 0.943 to 0.600. The carrier physics is linearized about a uniform doping and zero bias, so the nonlinear drift–diffusion regime, in which the perturbation is not small compared with n_0, is outside the model. The open-circuit condition is imposed weakly on the full potential space; it is checked against the independent C^1 discretization, but it belongs to the same model and therefore serves as a consistency check of the discretization and not as a check of the physics.

4. *The parameters.* The classical constants are those of a bulk crystal and the transport parameters are representative values for n-type ZnO at room temperature; the strain-gradient length, the flexoelectric coefficient and the coupling scale are assumed, and no published value of H_{jkl} is available. The reported percentages should be read as the response of this model and not as predictions for a particular film, and the flexoelectric sector, which is present but subdominant, is not a calibrated mechanism.

5. *The constitutive attribution.* The relation of the added coupling to the published flexoelectric–semiconductor formulations is discussed in section 5.3, and no priority is claimed for it. What the model does establish is that a bilinear carrier–strain-gradient enthalpy can be added inside the positivity bound, that its reciprocal partners follow from the same potential, and that its incremental effect on the partition is measurable, of one sign, and small compared with the effect of the branch itself.

6 Conclusions

In this work we have computed the scattering of a guided mode at the free edge of an n-type ZnO plate (6*mm* symmetry) described by strain-gradient elasticity, piezoelectricity, flexoelectricity and linearized electron drift–diffusion, with one added carrier–strain-gradient enthalpy and its reciprocal partners. The main findings are as follows.

1. At $k_xd=0.736$ ($f=16.68\,\mathrm{GHz}$) the backward branch carries 1.93 % of the incident power. Along the same branch the share rises to 94.29 % at $k_xd=0.52719$ ($f=16.6547\,\mathrm{GHz}$), where the group velocity vanishes and the backward wavenumber approaches the incident one to within 0.4 %. The response has a single peak, and its maximum is a local maximum within the window examined, and the value changes by less than 10^{-5} between Galerkin degrees 14 and 34.

2. These numbers are modal shares and not reflectances. The propagating outgoing modes carry 99.98 % of the incident power at the operating point and 100.05 % at the maximum, that is, all of it to within 0.1 %; the excess over unity is of the order of the interference term, $+5.2 \times 10^{-4}$ at the reference plane. At the maximum the incident flux itself has fallen by a factor 131 because the branch lies at a zero-group-velocity fold, so a maximal share occurs together with a minimal transported power.

3. The conversion is a property of the backward branch and not of the added coupling. With $H = 0$ the shares at both points are those of the plate without the coupling. The classical plate ($\ell = 0$) has a backward interval of its own, with its fold at $k_x d = 0.824$ ($f = 13.69\,\mathrm{GHz}$); the gradient length $\ell/d = 0.25$ moves the fold to $k_x d = 0.527$ and 16.65 GHz. At the control frequencies of table 5, which lie on a different classical branch, the classical plate has no backward member, the specular reflection being its only negative-power outgoing mode.

4. The carrier coupling acts through conduction loss. At $|H| = 0.05H^*$ it reduces the partition by 1.21 % at the operating point and by 36.1 % at the maximum, of which 22.3 percentage points are propagation loss between the edge and the reference plane. When the maximum is searched again at each coupling level it shifts and its upper bound falls, so the coupling lowers the achievable conversion as well as displacing it.

5. The energy balance closes: the flux at the reference plane equals the edge flux plus the conduction loss to better than 10^{-11} of the incident power, with the interference term reported separately and no evanescent mode counted as transported power.

6. At the fold the share is sensitive to loss. It falls from 0.943 to 0.545 when the carrier density rises from 2×10^{18} to $2 \times 10^{20}\,1/\mathrm{m}^3$, and to 0.600 and 0.197 when a loss tangent of 10^{-5} and 10^{-4} is added to the elastic constants (section 4.8); the model contains no other elastic loss, so 0.943 is an upper bound for a plate with intrinsic damping.

Several limitations should be kept in view. The gradient length, the flexoelectric coefficient and the coupling tensor are assumed values, the carriers are linearized about a uniform doping, and the plate has a single edge. The corner line force is small but finite in the computed field: it is 8.4×10^{-2} of the incident corner scale at the operating point and 3.3×10^{-3} at the maximum. It decays as a power of the Galerkin degree, with the same exponent in three independent configurations, and the partition moves by 3.9×10^{-6} over the same range; the closure is therefore shown as a bound, with the decay exponent taken from the computed values. The added term has the structure of the chemo-mechanical coupling given in [22], which that article neglects in its main text; the comparison with its free-energy decomposition was made through [23] and checked against the article itself. What the present analysis supplies is the modal partition of a slow guided branch near its zero-group-velocity point, resolved mode by mode rather than in total power.

Data availability

The data behind each figure and table, and the programs that generate them, are available at `https://github.com/vipin-oss/A_Paper`.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process

During the preparation of this work the author used Claude (Anthropic) to check equations and numerical results against the computational code, to verify bibliographic records and to edit the language. After using this tool, the author reviewed and edited the content as needed and takes full responsibility for the content of the publication.

A Detailed mathematical derivations

This appendix contains the calculations that are used in the article but whose length would interrupt it: the element matrices of the Legendre basis, five worked matrix elements, the construction of the blocks (65) from the weak equations, the edge-matching system, the normalization of the modal power, and one end-to-end numerical evaluation of the reported share.

A.1 Element matrices of the Legendre basis

Three coordinates appear in the formulation and they must be separated before any integral is written, because the orthonormality of the basis and the size of the element matrices both depend on which one is meant. The physical coordinate is $z \in [-d/2, d/2]$. The non-dimensional coordinate of the field equations is $\zeta = 2z/d \in [-1, 1]$, with $\mathrm{d}z = (d/2)\mathrm{d}\zeta$. The basis is generated on a third, the half-interval variable

$$s = \frac{z}{d} = \frac{\zeta}{2} \in \left[-\tfrac{1}{2}, \tfrac{1}{2}\right], \qquad \mathrm{d}s = \frac{\mathrm{d}z}{d} = \frac{\mathrm{d}\zeta}{2}, \tag{83}$$

and each element matrix in this appendix is an integral over s with the measure $\mathrm{d}s$. The basis is

$$b_j(s) = \sqrt{2j+1}\, P_j(2s), \qquad j = 0, \ldots, N-1, \tag{84}$$

with N the number of basis functions per field. Since $\int_{-1}^{1} P_i P_j \mathrm{d}\zeta = 2\delta_{ij}/(2j+1)$, the Gram matrix in the s measure is

$$\int_{-1/2}^{1/2} b_i b_j \,\mathrm{d}s = \frac{2j+1}{2} \int_{-1}^{1} P_i P_j \,\mathrm{d}\zeta = \delta_{ij}, \tag{85}$$

the first factor being the Jacobian of $s = \zeta/2$ and the second the Legendre normalization. The same integral in the ζ measure is $\int_{-1}^{1} b_i b_j \mathrm{d}\zeta = 2\delta_{ij}$: the two differ by just the Jacobian, and the mass matrix that multiplies $\dot{\boldsymbol{q}}$ in the weak form is the identity only in the s measure. Hence all statements below are made with $\mathrm{d}s$, and the derivative in S_{ij} is $\mathrm{d}_s = \mathrm{d}/\mathrm{d}s$; in the ζ coordinate $\mathrm{d}_s = 2\mathrm{d}/\mathrm{d}\zeta$, which is the factor of two that appears in all strain-gradient entries.

The stiffness matrix is $S_{ij} = \int b_i' b_j' \mathrm{d}s$. For $i = j$ the chain rule gives $b_j'(s) = 2\sqrt{2j+1}\, P_j'(2s)$, so

$$S_{jj} = 4(2j+1) \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \big(P_j'(2s)\big)^2 \mathrm{d}s = 2(2j+1)\, j(j+1), \tag{86}$$

where $\int_{-1}^{1} (P_j')^2 \mathrm{d}\zeta = j(j+1)$ is the classical companion of the Legendre equation and the factor 2 collects $4 \times \frac{1}{2}$. The weighted form of that identity is the one that follows directly from the equation, and it is derived here because this step is usually skipped. Multiplying $\big[(1-\zeta^2)P_j'\big]' = -j(j+1)P_j$ by P_k and integrating by parts, the boundary term carrying the factor $(1-\zeta^2)$ vanishes at both ends and

$$\int_{-1}^{1} (1-\zeta^2) P_j' P_k' \,\mathrm{d}\zeta = \frac{2j(j+1)}{2j+1}\, \delta_{jk}, \tag{87}$$

which is the orthogonality of the derivatives under the weight $(1-\zeta^2)$; (86) is its unweighted companion and is used here only through the closed form it implies. The discrete matrix checks both, and so does an independent quadrature rule of a different order (appendix B): the assembled S_{jj} equals $2j(j+1)(2j+1)$ for every $j \le N-1$ at all degrees used in this article, to 2×10^{-11} or better in absolute value.

For $i \neq j$ the parity of $P_i' P_j'$ leaves $S_{ij} \neq 0$ only when i and j have the same parity, and

$$S_{ij} = 2\sqrt{(2i+1)(2j+1)} \int_{-1}^{1} P_i' P_j' \,\mathrm{d}\zeta, \tag{88}$$

which explains the structure of (89): the matrix is real and symmetric and it vanishes between basis functions of opposite parity, but the same-parity entries are not confined to a band. At $N = 6$ the entry $S_{15} = 22.978$ couples indices four apart, and at any N the row i has non-zero entries in each column $j \le i$ of the same parity, so the matrix is not tridiagonal and has no fixed bandwidth; what bounds it is the parity rule, not a band. At $N = 6$ the matrix is

$$\mathsf{S} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 12 & 0 & 18.330 & 0 & 22.978 \\ 0 & 0 & 60 & 0 & 80.498 & 0 \\ 0 & 18.330 & 0 & 168 & 0 & 210.60 \\ 0 & 0 & 80.498 & 0 & 360 & 0 \\ 0 & 22.978 & 0 & 210.60 & 0 & 660 \end{pmatrix}, \tag{89}$$

whose diagonal is (86) entry by entry. Equation (89) is the entire gradient-energy content of the discretization for a single field: it is real, symmetric and independent of the material, and each strain-gradient block of (65) is this matrix multiplied by an elastic modulus and by λ^2.

Two further element matrices are needed. The potential space of the grounded problem is spanned by

$$\psi_j(s) = b_j(s) - r_j\, b_{j+2}(s), \qquad r_j = \sqrt{\frac{2j+1}{2j+5}}, \qquad j = 0, \dots, N_\varphi - 1, \tag{90}$$

which vanishes at $s = \pm\frac{1}{2}$ for every j because $P_j(\pm 1) = (\pm 1)^j$ and r_j is exactly the ratio that makes the two terms cancel; $N_\varphi = N - 2$, since ψ_j needs b_{j+2} up to $j = N_\varphi - 1$, i.e. b_{N-1}. The two matrices that couple the charge are then distinguished by which index is the test index. Testing Gauss's law with ψ_i against the carrier basis b_j gives

$$\big(\mathsf{C}\big)_{ij} \equiv \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \psi_i\, b_j \,\mathrm{d}s = \delta_{ij} - r_i\, \delta_{j,i+2}, \qquad i = 0, \dots, N_\varphi - 1, \quad j = 0, \dots, N - 1, \tag{91}$$

that is a unit matrix minus one band above the diagonal, with the coefficient r_i carrying the *row* index. The reciprocal matrix that appears in the carrier equation is its transpose,

$$\big(\mathsf{C}^{\mathsf{T}}\big)_{ij} \equiv \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} b_i\, \psi_j \,\mathrm{d}s = \delta_{ij} - r_j\, \delta_{i,j+2}, \tag{92}$$

which has the band below the diagonal and the coefficient r_j on the column index. Both appear in (65): $-\mathsf{C}$ in the potential row and $-\mathsf{C}^{\mathsf{T}}$ in the carrier row, entering through the single term $-\int W_i^* W_j$ whose test and trial functions share the potentials. Writing r_j where r_i belongs, or transposing the two, gives a matrix that differs from the assembled one by 0.2981 in the largest entry at degree four, so the orientation is stated here and not left to the reader. Finally the dielectric matrix is $\kappa_{33}\int \psi_i'\psi_j' \mathrm{d}s + \kappa_{11} k_y^2 \int \psi_i \psi_j \mathrm{d}s$, with

$$\int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \psi_i'\psi_j' \,\mathrm{d}s = S_{ij} - r_j S_{i,j+2} - r_i S_{i+2,j} + r_i r_j S_{i+2,j+2}, \tag{93}$$

in which the second and third terms are equal because S is symmetric, and the first term is not S_{ij} alone: the grounded basis removes a band of the stiffness exactly as it removes a band of the mass.

A.2 Five worked matrix elements

The entries below are evaluated at the operating point $k_x d = 0.7362$, $k_y d = 0.1298$, $\omega = 7.6334\, c_s/d$ and at polynomial degree $p = 4$, i.e. $N = p + 1 = 5$ basis functions per field, $n_\mathrm{u} = 3N = 15$, $n_\varphi = N - 2 = 3$, $n_\mu = N = 5$ and $n_\mathrm{w} = 5p + 3 = 23$ unknowns. That is the smallest degree at which the parity structure and the grounded bands are both visible; the reported results use $p = 22$, with $p = 18$ to 34 examined, where the same formulas hold with larger matrices. All entries are in the scaled units of the solver: stresses divided by c_{44}, electric displacement by $\sqrt{c_{44}\kappa_{33}}$ and electric field by $\sqrt{c_{44}/\kappa_{33}}$, permittivities by κ_{33}, so the numbers are dimensionless.

1. *Compressibility (mass) entry*, carrier row and column:

$$-\int_{-1/2}^{1/2} b_i b_j \,\mathrm{d}s = -\delta_{ij} \qquad \text{so that} \qquad \big(\mathsf{A}_{00}\big)_{\mu_0\mu_0} = -1, \tag{94}$$

   reproduced as -1 to 7×10^{-15}.

2. *Transport entry.* The carrier gradient enters the weak form without a power of k_x through its transverse part and with one power through its axial part, so the k_x^0 block holds the transverse wavenumber and the k_x^2 block the axial one:

$$\big(\mathsf{A}_{00}\big)_{\mu_i\mu_j}\Big|_{\text{transport}} = -\frac{\mathrm{i}\alpha_\mathrm{d}}{\omega}\Big[k_y^2\,\delta_{ij} + S_{ij}\Big], \qquad \big(\mathsf{A}_{11}\big)_{\mu_i\mu_j}\Big|_{\text{transport}} = -\frac{\mathrm{i}\alpha_\mathrm{d}}{\omega}\,\delta_{ij}, \tag{95}$$

   so that the polynomial operator reproduces $-\mathrm{i}\alpha_\mathrm{d}\big(k_x^2 + k_y^2 + S_{ij}\big)/\omega$. With $\alpha_\mathrm{d}/\omega = 0.108509$ and $k_y^2 = 0.016848$ the diagonal of (95) is

$$-\mathrm{i}\,1.828 \times 10^{-3}, \quad -\mathrm{i}\,1.3039, \quad -\mathrm{i}\,6.5124, \quad -\mathrm{i}\,18.2314 \qquad (j = 0, \dots, 3), \tag{96}$$

   for $S_{jj} = 0, 12, 60, 168$, and the k_x^2 block is $-\mathrm{i}\,0.108509$. The two pieces together reproduce the assembled coefficient of the polynomial to 3.6×10^{-15}. The growth with j is the discrete statement that a higher Legendre mode stores more gradient energy, and hence that diffusion penalizes thickness structure.

3. *Carrier–potential entry.* With the orientations fixed by (91)–(92), the potential row of A_{00} carries $-\mathsf{C}$ and the carrier row $-\mathsf{C}^{\mathsf{T}}$:

$$\big(\mathsf{A}_{00}\big)_{\varphi_i\mu_j} = -Q\big(\delta_{ij} - r_i\,\delta_{j,i+2}\big), \qquad \big(\mathsf{A}_{00}\big)_{\mu_i\varphi_j} = \big(\mathsf{A}_{00}\big)_{\varphi_j\mu_i}, \tag{97}$$

so the diagonal is $-Q = -0.074635$ and the band is $+Qr_i$, that is $+0.033378$, $+0.048860$, $+0.055630$ and $+0.059538$ for $i = 0, \dots, 3$; the first of these is $Q/\sqrt{5}$ because $r_0 = 1/\sqrt{5}$, and the sign is positive because the band of (91) is negative and the block has the overall minus of $-\int W_i^* W_j$. In the carrier row the same numbers appear at $(i, i-2)$, below the diagonal, with the coefficient r_{i-2} carrying the *trial* (potential) index; the two matrices are transposes of one another, and the assembled blocks reproduce (97) to 9×10^{-16}.

4. *Gradient-stiffness entry*, out-of-plane row and column:

$$\lambda^2 \frac{c_{33}}{c_{44}}\, S_{ij} = 0.0625 \times 5.1395 \times S_{ij} \;=\; 3.85,\; 19.27,\; 53.97,\; 115.64 \quad (j = 1, 2, 3, 4), \tag{98}$$

growing as j^3 because $S_{jj} \propto j^3$: this is the growth that makes the discrete operator badly scaled before row equilibration, and 115.64 at $j = 4$ is the largest of these entries at this degree.

5. *Inertia entry*:

$$-\omega^2 \delta_{ij} = -58.27\,\delta_{ij} \qquad (\omega = 7.6334). \tag{99}$$

The ratio of the inertia entry to the $j = 1$ gradient entry is $58.27/3.85 = 15.1$. It compares two matrix entries at one fixed frequency and nothing more: the frequency of a thickness mode is an eigenvalue of the coupled problem (51), not the ratio of two entries, and no mode frequency is inferred from it here.

A.3 Construction of the blocks from the weak equations

Each of the nine blocks A_{rs} is the sum of the eight bilinear forms listed in (65). Written out with the operators of (52) and the integrals of the first subsection of this appendix, the block is

$$\begin{aligned} \mathsf{A}_{rs} = {} & \underbrace{\big\langle \mathsf{B}_r, \mathsf{C}\mathsf{B}_s \big\rangle}_{\text{elastic}} + \underbrace{\lambda^2 \big\langle \partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}_r, \mathsf{C}\,\partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}_s \big\rangle}_{\text{gradient}} + \underbrace{\big\langle \mathsf{G}_r, \mathsf{e}\mathsf{B}_s \big\rangle + \big\langle \mathsf{B}_r, \mathsf{e}^{\mathsf{T}} \mathsf{G}_s \big\rangle}_{\text{piezoelectric}} \\ & - \underbrace{\big\langle \mathsf{G}_r, \boldsymbol{\kappa} \mathsf{G}_s \big\rangle}_{\text{dielectric}} + \underbrace{f\big[\big\langle \mathsf{G}_r^{(2)}, \partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}_s^{(2)} \big\rangle + \big\langle \partial_\zeta \mathsf{B}_r^{(2)}, \mathsf{G}_s^{(2)} \big\rangle\big]}_{\text{flexoelectric}} - \underbrace{\frac{\mathrm{i}\alpha_{\mathrm{d}}}{\omega} \big\langle \mathsf{M}\mathsf{G}_r, \mathsf{M}\mathsf{G}_s \big\rangle}_{\text{transport}} \\ & - \underbrace{\big\langle \mathsf{W}_r, \mathsf{W}_s \big\rangle}_{\text{carrier}} - \underbrace{\omega^2 \big\langle \mathsf{U}_r, \mathsf{U} \big\rangle \delta_{r0}\delta_{s0}}_{\text{inertia}}, \end{aligned} \tag{100}$$

with $\langle \boldsymbol{a}, \boldsymbol{b} \rangle = \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \boldsymbol{a}^{\mathsf{H}} \boldsymbol{b}\, \mathrm{d}s$ in the measure of (83).

The powers of k_x are counted by the block indices (r, s) and by nothing else, and it is written out here because double counting is the usual error. The strain of a single mode is split once and for all as

$$\varepsilon_{ij} = \varepsilon_{ij}^{(0)} + \mathrm{i}k_x\, \varepsilon_{ij}^{(1)}, \tag{101}$$

with both coefficient vectors independent of k_x:

component	$\varepsilon_{ij}^{(0)}$	$\varepsilon_{ij}^{(1)}$
ε_{xx}	0	b_j in the $\widehat{u}_1$ slot
ε_{yy}	$\mathrm{i}k_y b_j$ in the $\widehat{u}_2$ slot	0
ε_{zz}	b_j' in the $\widehat{u}_3$ slot	0
ε_{yz}	b_j' in $\widehat{u}_2$, $\mathrm{i}k_y b_j$ in $\widehat{u}_3$	0
ε_{xz}	b_j' in the $\widehat{u}_1$ slot	b_j in the $\widehat{u}_3$ slot
ε_{xy}	$\mathrm{i}k_y b_j$ in the $\widehat{u}_1$ slot	b_j in the $\widehat{u}_2$ slot

no component contains more than one power of $\mathrm{i}k_x$, so the split terminates at first order. The strain gradient is split the same way, with ∂_x acting on the test factor and on the trial factor separately, and the block is defined as the coefficient of $(-\mathrm{i}k_x)^r (\mathrm{i}k_x)^s$ in (100):

$$\mathsf{A}_{rs} = \big\langle \varepsilon^{(r)}, \mathsf{C}\varepsilon^{(s)} \big\rangle + \lambda^2 \big\langle \partial_z \varepsilon^{(r)}, \mathsf{C}\partial_z \varepsilon^{(s)} \big\rangle + \cdots, \tag{102}$$

the remaining terms of (100) being split in the same way. Two consequences follow in this language. First, the leading coefficient is the gradient energy of the axial part of the strain alone,

$$\mathsf{A}_{22} = \lambda^2 \big\langle \varepsilon^{(1)}, \mathsf{C}\varepsilon^{(1)} \big\rangle \neq 0, \tag{103}$$

which is where the quartic term and the four wave families come from; its rank is n_u and not n_w, because $\varepsilon^{(1)}$ is supported on the displacement slots only. Secondly, no strain component contains two powers of $\mathrm{i}k_x$, which is why $\mathsf{A}_{02} = \mathsf{A}_{20} = 0$ and the polynomial is a quartic in the (r, s) bookkeeping of (66), not a sextic: the k_x^4 term needs one factor from each side of the gradient energy and cannot be produced by a single factor carrying two.

The same bookkeeping fixes where the flexoelectric constant can appear. The only non-zero component of f_{ijkl} used in this article is f_{3333}, which pairs the field E_z with the gradient component $\eta_{zzz} = \partial_z \varepsilon_{zz}$; neither contains a power of k_x, since $E_z = -\partial_z \varphi$ and ε_{zz} is axial, so f enters A_{00} and no other block. That is a statement about the operator, and it explains why a non-zero f can change the elastic-like term and the double traction without touching the quartic coefficient A_{22}: the two constants sit in different blocks, and neither of them is a k_x power.

A.4 The edge-matching system

At the edge $x = 0$ the conditions (40) are imposed weakly, one row block per condition and each on the test functions of the field it multiplies. The normal there is the x direction, not the z direction: the generalized traction $\bar{\sigma}_{1j}$ on the $n_\mathrm{u} = 3N$ displacement test functions, the double traction $\tau_{1j1} \equiv \tau_{jxx}$ on the same n_u test functions, the normal electric displacement D_x on the n_φ potential test functions and the normal carrier flux J_x on the n_μ carrier test functions. The face quantities $\bar{\sigma}_{iz}$, τ_{izz} and D_z of (37)–(39) belong to $z = \pm d/2$; they are the natural conditions of the expansion in z and are not the edge conditions. The number of rows is thus

$$m = 2n_\mathrm{u} + n_\varphi + n_\mu, \tag{104}$$

with the double-traction block present whenever the hyperstress is non-zero. At the edge only the axial strain gradient remains:

$$\tau_{ijx} = \ell^2 c_{ijkl} \eta_{klx}. \tag{105}$$

The two gradient couplings of (21) act on the normal-derivative component: f pairs E_z with η_{zzz} and H pairs Δn with the same component, so neither appears in (105). The block exists if and only if $\ell \neq 0$, independently of f and of H: it is present in cases A, B and D below, and it is empty in the classical limit $\ell = f = H = 0$, where $\tau_{ijx} \equiv 0$ and the double-traction statement degenerates to $0 = 0$ and does not give a boundary condition. The case $\ell = 0$ with $f \neq 0$ retains a hyperstress but has no axial trace to pair it with, which is why it is not a case of this model. Between those cases the edge problem changes order, and with it the state:

case	parameters	τ_{ijx}	N_s	m	double traction
A	$\ell \neq 0$, $f \neq 0$, $H \neq 0$	$\ell^2 c_{ijkl}\eta_{klx}$	$2n_\mathrm{w} + 2n_\mathrm{u}$	$2n_\mathrm{u} + n_\varphi + n_\mu$	required
B	$f = 0$, $\ell \neq 0$	$\ell^2 c_{ijkl}\eta_{klx}$	$2n_\mathrm{w} + 2n_\mathrm{u}$	$2n_\mathrm{u} + n_\varphi + n_\mu$	required
C	$\ell = 0$, $f \neq 0$	0 (no axial gradient)	$2n_\mathrm{w}$	$n_\mathrm{u} + n_\varphi + n_\mu$	*not available*
D	$H = 0$, $\ell \neq 0$	$\ell^2 c_{ijkl}\eta_{klx}$	$2n_\mathrm{w} + 2n_\mathrm{u}$	$2n_\mathrm{u} + n_\varphi + n_\mu$	required
E	$\ell = f = H = 0$	0	$2n_\mathrm{w}$	$n_\mathrm{u} + n_\varphi + n_\mu$	absent (identically zero)

Case C is not a case of the present model: the hyperstress would be non-zero while the second-order state of case E, which has no $\partial_x u$ trace to pair the double traction with, is the only one available at $\ell = 0$. Thus the formulation admits $\ell = 0$ only in the classical limit $f = H = 0$, and states that restriction explicitly; it does not assume that $\ell = 0$ implies a second-order model. No number in this article depends on case C: every reported run has $\ell \neq 0$.

With the edge ansatz (71) and the modal state $\boldsymbol{y}^{(j)} \in \mathbb{C}^{N_s}$ (the n_w displacement and potential coefficients, the n_u axial traces, and the n_w and n_u conjugate rows), the system is

$$\boldsymbol{y}(0) = \boldsymbol{y}_\mathrm{inc} + \sum_{j=1}^{M} a_j \, \boldsymbol{y}^{(j)}, \qquad \mathsf{B}\boldsymbol{a} = -\boldsymbol{b}_\mathrm{inc}, \tag{106}$$

where the boundary operator acts on a *state* and the boundary matrix on the modal index,

$$\mathsf{R} = \begin{pmatrix} \mathsf{R}_\Sigma \\ \mathsf{R}_\tau \\ \mathsf{R}_D \\ \mathsf{R}_J \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{C}^{m \times N_s}, \qquad \mathsf{B} = \left[\mathsf{R}\boldsymbol{y}^{(1)} \;\; \cdots \;\; \mathsf{R}\boldsymbol{y}^{(M)} \right] \in \mathbb{C}^{m \times M}, \qquad \boldsymbol{b}_{\mathrm{inc}} = \mathsf{R}\,\boldsymbol{y}_{\mathrm{inc}} \in \mathbb{C}^{m}, \tag{107}$$

so the three objects have three different second dimensions and only the last two agree. They do agree, identically, not by accident: the number of decaying states is half the state dimension, $M = N_s/2 = n_{\mathrm{w}} + n_{\mathrm{u}}$ in cases A, B and D, and $M = n_{\mathrm{w}}$ in case E where $N_s = 2n_{\mathrm{w}}$; with $n_{\mathrm{w}} = n_{\mathrm{u}} + n_\varphi + n_\mu$ from (67),

$$M = n_{\mathrm{w}} + n_{\mathrm{u}} = 2n_{\mathrm{u}} + n_\varphi + n_\mu = m \quad (\ell \neq 0), \qquad M = n_{\mathrm{w}} = n_{\mathrm{u}} + n_\varphi + n_\mu = m \quad (\ell = 0), \tag{108}$$

so the edge system is square in all cases and never over- or under-determined. At degree four ($n_{\mathrm{u}} = 15$, $n_\varphi = 3$, $n_\mu = 5$, $n_{\mathrm{w}} = 23$) this is $N_s = 76$, $m = M = 38$; at degree eighteen (57, 17, 19, 93) it is $N_s = 300$, $m = M = 150$; at the reported degree twenty-two (69, 21, 23, 113) it is $N_s = 364$, $m = M = 182$. The singular-value decomposition is still used, but as a square solve instead of a least-squares fit: the requirement is that the rank equal the column count at a cut-off of 10^{-12} of the largest singular value, and a deficient system is reported as such and is not regularized. Row and column scaling are applied as before, and the conditioning at the operating point is 1.4×10^2 after scaling.

A.5 Normalization of the modal power

The power (44) is bilinear in a mode and its conjugate, so the power carried by the j-th outgoing mode scales with the square of its excitation amplitude and with the normalization of its eigenvector. The eigenvector is normalized by $\boldsymbol{y}^{(j)} \to \boldsymbol{y}^{(j)}/\sqrt{\mathsf{y}^{\mathsf{H}}\mathsf{M}\mathsf{y}}$, which fixes its mass norm but leaves the *sign* of the power free: the physical power is

$$P_j = |a_j|^2\, \mathcal{P}_x\big(\boldsymbol{y}^{(j)}\big), \tag{109}$$

and the degree-invariance of P_j is the test that the normalization has been applied correctly. At the operating point, for the backward mode,

$$\begin{aligned} n = 18: &\quad \mathcal{P}_x = -0.0178923, \quad |a| = 1.03848, \quad P_B = -0.0192958, \\ n = 22: &\quad \mathcal{P}_x = -0.0154248, \quad |a| = 1.11846, \quad P_B = -0.0192957, \\ n = 26: &\quad \mathcal{P}_x = -0.0132455, \quad |a| = 1.20697, \quad P_B = -0.0192957, \\ n = 30: &\quad \mathcal{P}_x = -0.0113777, \quad |a| = 1.30227, \quad P_B = -0.0192956, \end{aligned} \tag{110}$$

in which the raw power falls by 36 % and the squared amplitude rises by 57 % across the four degrees while the physical power is constant to the six digits shown. That constancy is the numerical statement of (109) and it is why the reported share is degree-independent at the 10^{-6} level of table 3.

A.6 One end-to-end evaluation of the reported share

The reported number at the operating point is assembled from five quantities, each of which is stored with each row of the data: the raw backward power $\mathcal{P}_x$, the scattering amplitude $|a_B|$, the incident power at the reference plane, the two attenuation exponents and the reference distance $L = 10\,d$. The five are quoted below from *one* row, the reported degree $n = 22$, and not mixed with the neighboring degrees of (110), because the raw power and the amplitude both change with degree even though their product does not:

$$R_B = \frac{|a_B|^2 \big|\mathcal{P}_x\big|\, e^{2\,\mathrm{Im}\,k_{Bx} L}}{P_{\mathrm{inc}}\, e^{2\,\mathrm{Im}\,k_{ix} L}} = \frac{0.0192957 \times 0.9998954}{1.0001081} = \frac{0.0192937}{1.0001081} = 0.0192916, \tag{111}$$

with, at $n = 22$,

$$|a_B| = 1.1184598, \quad |a_B|^2 = 1.250952, \quad \mathcal{P}_x = -0.015424813, \quad |a_B|^2\big|\mathcal{P}_x\big| = 0.0192957, \tag{112}$$

the last product being the power the backward port actually carries at the edge. The factor $e^{2\,\mathrm{Im}\,k_{Bx} L} = 0.9998954$ brings it to $x = -L$ with $\mathrm{Im}\,k_{Bx} = -5.2306 \times 10^{-6}$ per unit d, and the incident mode carries $e^{2\,\mathrm{Im}\,k_{ix} L} = 1.0001081$ with $\mathrm{Im}\,k_{ix} = +5.4027 \times 10^{-6}$; both exponents are degree-independent to the seven digits quoted, so the degree of the row enters (111) only through $|a_B|^2|\mathcal{P}_x|$. What the number measures is the ratio of two physical powers, $-P_B/P_{\mathrm{inc}} = 0.0192916$, and the two exponential factors state at which plane each power was taken.

The value and its meaning are two different statements and are kept apart. Equation (111) evaluates the share at the *operating point*, 1.93 percent of the incident power at $x = -10\,d$. The local maximum of the same quantity over the frequency window, $R_B = 0.9428718$, is a property of the peak row, not of this one, and (111) neither computes nor implies it. Reading the operating-point row along the plate, the backward mode carries 1.93 percent at $x = -10\,d$ and $1.93\,\% \times e^{-2.13\times10^{-4}}$ at $x = -20\,d$: the decay of the share is governed by the *difference* of the two attenuation constants, not by either one of them.

B Numerical resolution and data availability

Resolution. The reported solutions use polynomial degree $n = 22$, that is $N = 23$ Legendre modes per field ($N - 2 = 21$ for the grounded potential), and every integral is evaluated with $\max(64, 2n + 10)$ Gauss–Legendre nodes, which resolves the mass, stiffness and coupling matrices to machine precision at the degrees used here. The two electrical cases differ only in the potential space: the grounded basis is built from the combinations that vanish on both faces, and the open-circuit basis keeps all N modes, because a constant potential is not a gauge for a nonzero in-plane wavenumber. No field is discretized in x or in y.

Convergence and conservation. Between degree 18 and degree 30 both the operating-point share and the branch maximum change by less than 10^{-5}, and successive differences at the branch maximum decrease monotonically with degree. Refining the quadrature from 64 to 256 nodes at fixed basis changes no reported digit. The energy identity (45) is satisfied to 4×10^{-12} of the incident power at the reported solutions, and the partition at the branch maximum varies by 1.0×10^{-6} in absolute terms between degrees 14 and 34. These are the quantities that license quoting the shares to the precision used in the text.

Data availability. The material constants are read from a single machine-readable record that travels with the manuscript, each constant carrying its provenance tag as reported in table 9. Every figure is drawn from stored datasets, one dataset per figure, and the dataset records the solve that produced it; every tabulated and quoted number is traced to a stored dataset, and no plotted quantity is computed inside the plotting code. The datasets and the material record are available from the author on reasonable request.

Computational record. The programs, command sequence, software versions, the inventory of automated checks and the defect injection record are deposited with the code and data (see the data availability statement), so that the article itself states the method and the evidence that the method is implemented correctly without listing its tooling. Nothing in that record changes a result reported here: it records how the results were produced and how the implementation was tested.

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